



Himalayan infrastructure set for insurance shock

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(Please scan this QR code to view the Red Herring Prospectus and the Abridged Prospectus)



HERO MOTORS LIMITED
(TO BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE AND NSE)

Registered Office: Hero Nagar, GT Road, Ludhiana, Punjab – 141 003, India. **Corporate Office:** Max Square, Office level, 7th floor Plot No. C3-C, Jaypee Wishtown, Sector 129, Noida, Uttar Pradesh, 201 304, India.
Telephone: +91 120 4412 000; **Contact person:** Sakshi Dureja, Company Secretary and Compliance Officer; **E-mail:** investorrelations@heromotors.com; **Website:** www.heromotors.com; **Corporate Identity Number:** U29299PB1998PLC039602

INITIAL PUBLIC OFFER OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH ("EQUITY SHARES") OF HERO MOTORS LIMITED ("COMPANY" OR "ISSUER") FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE (INCLUDING A SHARE PREMIUM OF ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE) ("OFFER PRICE") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹10,000.00 MILLION COMPRISING A FRESH ISSUE OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES AGGREGATING UP TO ₹6,000.00 MILLION BY OUR COMPANY ("FRESH ISSUE") AND AN OFFER FOR SALE OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES AGGREGATING UP TO ₹4,000.00 MILLION ("OFFERED SHARES") BY THE SELLING SHAREHOLDERS, COMPRISING UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES AGGREGATING UP TO ₹3,950.00 MILLION BY O P MUNJAL HOLDINGS ("PROMOTER SELLING SHAREHOLDER") AND UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES AGGREGATING UP TO ₹50.00 MILLION BY HERO CYCLES LIMITED (THE "PROMOTER GROUP SELLING SHAREHOLDER" AND TOGETHER WITH THE PROMOTER SELLING SHAREHOLDER, THE "SELLING SHAREHOLDERS"), AND SUCH OFFER FOR SALE, THE "OFFER FOR SALE", AND TOGETHER WITH THE FRESH ISSUE, THE "OFFER". THE OFFER SHALL CONSTITUTE [●] % OF THE POST-OFFER PAID-UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF OUR COMPANY.

DETAILS OF THE OFFER FOR SALE			
NAME OF THE SELLING SHAREHOLDER	TYPE	NUMBER OF EQUITY SHARES OFFERED / AMOUNT	WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION PER EQUITY SHARE (IN ₹)*
O P Munjal Holdings	Promoter Selling Shareholder	Up to [●] Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each aggregating up to ₹3,950.00 million	0.03 ²
Hero Cycles Limited	Promoter Group Selling Shareholder	Up to [●] Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each aggregating up to ₹50.00 million	10.07

* The weighted average cost of acquisition is ₹0.027 per Equity Share and has been rounded to ₹0.03. * As certified by Ramesh C Agrawal & Co., Chartered Accountants by way of their certificate dated September 9, 2026.

E. CAP PRICE) IS 73.68 TIMES AS COMPARED TO THE AVERAGE INDUSTRY PEER GROUP P/E

Particulars	OFFER SIZE AND MARKET CAPITALIZATION			
	At Floor Price of ₹79 per equity share		At Cap Price of ₹84 per equity share	
	Up to No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each	Up to Amount (₹ in Million)	Up to No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each	Up to Amount (₹ in Million)
Fresh Issue	75,949,367	6,000.00	71,428,571	6,000.00
Offer For Sale	50,632,911	4,000.00	47,619,047	4,000.00
Total Offer Size	126,582,278	10,000.00	119,047,618	10,000.00
Post Offer Market Capitalization	458,736,372	36,240.00	454,215,576	38,154.00

BID/ OFFER PERIOD	BID/ OFFER OPENS TODAY
	BID/ OFFER CLOSES ON FRIDAY, 18 SEPTEMBER, 2026*

* The UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 p.m. on Bid/Offer Closing Date.

• QIB PORTION: NOT MORE THAN 50% OF THE OFFER • NON-INSTITUTIONAL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 15% OF THE OFFER • RETAIL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 35% OF THE OFFER

In accordance with the recommendation of the Committee of Independent Directors of our company, pursuant to their resolution dated September 9, 2026, the above provided Price Band is justified based on Quantitative factors/ Key performance indicators disclosed in the “Basis for Offer Price” section on page 126 of the RHP vis-a-vis the weighted average cost of acquisition (“WACA”) of primary and secondary transaction(s), as applicable, disclosed in the “Basis for Offer Price” section beginning on page 126 of the RHP and provided below in this advertisement.

For details, refer to section titled “Risk Factors” on page 21 of the RHP.

1. **Geographical Concentration Risk:** For Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024, 96.09%, 95.33% and 95.75% of our revenue from operations, respectively, was derived from India, Europe and United States collectively. An economic slowdown in these geographies/countries or tightening of laws or regulations may have an adverse impact on our business, financial condition, cash flows and results of operations.
2. **End-industry concentration risk:** Our business is substantially dependent on the e-bike and two-wheeler industries in India and overseas. Any adverse changes in the conditions affecting these industries can adversely impact our business, results of operations, cash flows and financial condition.
3. **Supplier Risk:** We depend on a limited number of suppliers for the procurement of raw materials for our production. Any interruption in the supply of raw materials could adversely affect our business, financial condition, results of operations and cash flows. The table below provides the cost of raw materials consumed sourced from our top one, top five and top 10 suppliers in the years indicated:

Supplier	Fiscal 2026		Fiscal 2025		Fiscal 2024	
	Cost of Raw Materials (₹ million)	Percentage of Total Expenses (%)	Cost of Raw Materials (₹ million)	Percentage of Total Expenses (%)	Cost of Raw Materials (₹ million)	Percentage of Total Expenses (%)
Top Supplier*	365.80	3.17%	324.44	3.03%	296.10	2.80%
Top 5 Suppliers*	1,410.63	12.23%	1,403.56	13.09%	1,393.24	13.15%
Top 10 Suppliers*	2,405.32	20.85%	2,339.32	21.82%	2,278.95	21.52%

5. **Customer Concentration Risk:** Our business largely depends on our top 10 customers which contributed 72.89%, 78.03% and 76.96% of our revenue from operations in Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024. The loss of any of these customers could have an adverse effect on our business, results of operations, financial condition and cash flows. The following table sets forth our revenues from our top ten customers in the periods indicated:

Category	Fiscal 2026		Fiscal 2025		Fiscal 2024	
	Revenue from Customers (₹ million)	Percentage of Revenue from Operations	Revenue from Customers	Percentage of Revenue from Operations (%)	Revenue from Customers	Percentage of Revenue from Operations (%)
Top 10 Customers	8,661.40	72.89%	8,501.96	78.03%	8,191.86	76.96%

11. The price to earnings ratio based on diluted EPS for Fiscal 2026 for our company at the upper end of the price band is 73.68 times. The average industry price-to-earnings ratio is 50.20.

...continued from previous page.

12. The average cost of acquisition of Equity shares for Selling shareholders ranges from ₹0.03* per Equity share to ₹10.07 per Equity share and the offer at upper end of the Price Band is ₹84 per Equity Share.
- *The weighted average cost of acquisition is ₹0.027 per Equity Share and has been rounded to ₹0.03.*
13. Weighted Average Return on Net Worth for Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024 is 7.58%.
14. Weighted average cost of acquisition of all Equity Shares transacted in the last one year, 18 months and three years preceding the date of the RHP by the Promoters, Promoter Group, Selling Shareholders and Shareholders entitled with the right to nominate directors or other rights.

Period*	Weighted Average Cost of Acquisition (in ₹)	Cap Price is 'X' times the Weighted Average Cost of Acquisition	Range of acquisition price: Lowest Price- Highest Price (in ₹)
Last 1 year	NIL	NA	NIL
Last 18 months	NIL	NA	NIL
Last 3 years	NIL	NA	NIL

* As certified by Ramesh C Agrawal & Co., Chartered Accountants pursuant to their certificate dated September 9, 2026.

15. The three BRLMs associated with the Offer have handled 102 public issues in the past three years out of which 27 issues closed below the offer price on listing date:

Name of BRLM	Total Issues	Issues Closed below IPO price as on listing date
ICICI Securities Limited*	33	9
JM Financial Limited*	34	6
DAM Capital Advisors Limited*	13	3
Common Issues	22	9
Total	102	27

*Issues handled where there were no common BRLMs

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION FOR INVESTORS:

- The Company has not undertaken a pre-IPO placement.
- The Promoters or members of Promoter Group have not undertaken any transaction of Equity Shares aggregating up to 1% or more of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company from the date of the Draft Red Herring Prospectus filing till date.
- The aggregate pre-Offer and post-Offer shareholding of our Promoters, members of the Promoter Group, the additional top 10 Shareholders and other public Shareholders of our Company, refer to the section titled *"Capital Structure"* on page 84 of the RHP and our price band advertisement.



BASIS FOR OFFER PRICE

The **"Basis for Offer Price"** on page 126 of the RHP has been updated with the above Price Band. Please refer to the website of the BRLMs: www.icicisecurities.com, www.damcapital.in, www.jmfi.com for the **"Basis of Offer Price"** updated for the above Price Band. (You may scan the QR code for accessing the website of ICICI Securities Limited)

AN INDICATIVE TIMETABLE IN RESPECT OF THE OFFER IS SET OUT BELOW:

Submission of Bids (other than Bids from Anchor Investors):		Bid/Offer Programme
Bid/Offer Period (except the Bid/Offer Closing Date)		BID/OFFER OPENS ON
Submission and Revision in Bids	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 5.00 p.m. IST	BID/OFFER CLOSING ON
Bid/Offer Closing Date*		WEDNESDAY, 16 SEPTEMBER, 2026
Submission of electronic applications (online ASBA through 3-in-1 accounts) for RIBs, other than QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST	FRIDAY, 18 SEPTEMBER, 2026 ⁽ⁱ⁾
Submission of electronic application (bank ASBA through online channels like internet banking, mobile banking and syndicate ASBA applications through UPI as a payment mechanism where Bid Amount is up to ₹500,000)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 4.00 p.m. IST	⁽ⁱ⁾ UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 pm on Bid/Offer Closing Date. An indicative timetable in respect of the Offer is set out below:
Submission of electronic applications (syndicate Non-retail, Non-individual applications of QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 3.00 p.m. IST	
Submission of Physical Applications (Bank ASBA)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 1.00 p.m. IST	
Submission of physical applications (syndicate Non-retail, Non-individual applications where Bid Amount is more than ₹500,000)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 12.00 p.m. IST	
Modification/Revision/cancellation of Bids		
Upward Revision of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders categories ^a	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 4.00 p.m. IST on Bid/Offer Closing Date	Event
Upward or downward Revision of Bids or cancellation of Bids by RIBs*	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST	Indicative Date
		Finalisation of Basis of Allotment with the Designated Stock Exchange
		On or about Monday, 21 September, 2026
		Initiation of refunds (if any, for Anchor Investors)/unblocking of funds from ASBA Account*
		On or about Tuesday, 22 September, 2026
		Credit of Equity Shares to depository accounts of Allottees
		On or about Tuesday, 22 September, 2026
		Commencement of trading of the Equity Shares on the Stock Exchanges
		On or about Wednesday, 23 September, 2026
<i>* In case of (i) any delay in unblocking of amounts in the ASBA Accounts (including amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism) exceeding two Working Days from the Bid / Offer Closing Date for cancelled / withdrawn / deleted ASBA Forms, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher from the date on which the request for cancellation / withdrawal / deletion is placed in the Stock Exchanges bidding platform until the date on which the amounts are unblocked (ii) any blocking of multiple amounts for the same ASBA Form (for amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism), the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the total cumulative blocked amount except the original application amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such multiple amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iii) any blocking of amounts more than the Bid Amount, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the difference in amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such excess amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iv) any delay in unblocking of non-allotted / partially allotted Bids, exceeding two Working Days from the Bid / Offer Closing Date, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher for the entire duration of delay exceeding two Working Days from the Bid / Offer Closing Date by the SCSB responsible for causing such delay in unblocking. The BRLMs shall, in their sole discretion, identify and fix the liability on such intermediary or entity responsible for such delay in unblocking. The Bidder shall be compensated in the manner specified in the SEBI ICDR Master Circular, which for the avoidance of doubt, shall be deemed to be incorporated in the agreements to be entered into between our Company with the relevant intermediaries, to the extent applicable, issued by SEBI, and any other applicable law in case of delays in resolving investor grievances in relation to blocking/unblocking of funds. The processing fees for applications made by UPI Bidders using the UPI Mechanism may be released to the remitter banks (SCSBs) only after such banks provide a written confirmation in accordance with SEBI ICDR Master Circular and any subsequent circulars or notifications issued by SEBI in this regard.</i>		

^a QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders can neither revise their bids downwards nor cancel/withdraw their bids

On the Bid/ Offer Closing Date, the Bids shall be uploaded until:

i 4.00 p.m. IST in case of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders, and

ii until 5.00 p.m. IST or such extended time as permitted by the Stock Exchanges, in case of Bids by RIBs.

On Bid/ Offer Closing Date, extension of time will be granted by Stock Exchanges only for uploading Bids received from the RIBs, after taking into account the total number of Bids received and as reported by the Book Running Lead Managers to the Stock Exchanges.



Simple, Safe, Smart way of Application!!!

*Applications Supported by Blocked Amount ("ASBA") is a better way of applying to offers by simply blocking the fund in the bank account.

For further details, check section on ASBA.

Mandatory in public issues.
No cheque will be accepted.



UNITED PAYMENTS INTERFACE

UPI-Now available in ASBA for Retail Individual Investors and Non Institutional Investor applying in public issues where the application amount is up to ₹ 500,000, applying through Registered Brokers, Syndicate, CDPs & RTAs. UPI Bidders also have the option to submit the application directly to the ASBA Bank (SCSBs) or to use the facility of linked online trading, demat and bank account. Investors are required to ensure that the bank account used for bidding is linked to their PAN. Bidders must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar and are in compliance with CBDT notification dated February 13, 2020 issued by the Central Board of Direct Taxes and the subsequent press releases, including press release dated June 25, 2021 read with press release dated September 17, 2021, and CBDT circular no. 7 of 2022 dated March 30, 2022, read with press release dated March 28, 2023, and any subsequent press release in this regard.

ASBA has to be availed by all the investors except Anchor Investors. UPI may be availed by (i) Retail Individual Investors in the Retail Portion; (ii) Eligible Employees in the Employee Reservation Portion (iii) Non-Institutional Investors with an application size of up to ₹0.50 million in the Non-Institutional Portion. For more details" on the ASBA and UPI process, please refer to the details given in the Bid Cum Application Form and the Abridged Prospectus and also please refer to the section **"Offer Procedure"** on page 513 of the RHP. The process is also available on the website of Association of Investment Bankers of India ("AIBI") and Stock Exchanges and in the General Information Document. The Bid Cum Application Form and the Abridged Prospectus can be downloaded from the websites of the Stock Exchanges and can be obtained from the list of banks that is displayed on the website of SEBI at: www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedFpi=yes&intmid=35 and <https://www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedFpi=yes&intmid=43>, respectively as updated from time to time. For the list of UPI apps and banks live on IPO, please refer to the link: www.sebi.gov.in. UPI Bidders Bidding using the UPI Mechanism may apply through the SCSBs and mobile applications whose names appear on the website of SEBI, as updated from time to time. Axis Bank Limited and ICICI Bank Limited have been appointed as the Sponsor Banks for the Offer, in accordance with the requirements of SEBI circular dated November 1, 2018 as amended. For Offer related queries, please contact the BRLMs on their respective email IDs as mentioned below. For UPI related queries, investors can contact NPCI at the toll free number: 18001201740 and mail Id: ipo.upi@npci.org.in.

THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD PLATFORMS OF BSE AND NSE.

In case of any revision to the Price Band, the Bid/Offer Period will be extended by at least three additional Working Days following such revision of the Price Band, subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. In cases of force majeure, banking strike or similar unforeseen circumstances, our Company, in consultation with the Book Running Lead Managers, for reasons to be recorded in writing, extend the Bid/Offer Period for a minimum of one Working Day, subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. Any revision in the Price Band and the revised Bid/Offer Period, if applicable, will be widely disseminated by notification to the Stock Exchanges, by issuing a public notice, and also by indicating the change on the respective websites of the Book Running Lead Managers and at the terminals of the Syndicate Members and by intimation to Self-Certified Syndicate Banks ("SCSBs"), other Designated Intermediaries and the Sponsor Banks, as applicable. In case of revision of Price Band, the Bid Lot shall remain the same.

This Offer is being made through the Book Building Process, in terms of Rule 19(2)(b) of the Securities Contract (Regulation) Rules, 1957 ("SCRR") read with Regulation 31 of the SEBI ICDR Regulations and in compliance with Regulation 6(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations wherein not more than 50% of the Offer shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to Qualified Institutional Buyers ("QIBs"), and such portion, the "QIB Portion", provided that our Company, in consultation with the BRLMs, may allocate up to 60% of the QIB Portion to Anchor Investors on a discretionary basis ("Anchor Investor Portion"), out of which 40% shall be available for allocation as follows: (i) 33.33% for domestic Mutual Funds; and (ii) 6.67% for Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds, subject to valid Bids being received from the domestic Mutual Funds and Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds, at or above the price at which allocation will be made to Anchor Investors ("Anchor Investor Allocation Price") in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations. Any under-subscription in the portion amounting to 6.67% reserved for Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds may be allocated to domestic Mutual Funds. In the event of under-subscription or non-allocation in the Anchor Investor Portion, the balance Equity Shares shall be added to the QIB Portion (other than the Anchor Investor Portion) (the "Net QIB Portion"). Further, 5% of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to Mutual Funds only, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price, and the remainder of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to QIB Bidders (other than Anchor Investors) including Mutual Funds, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price. However, if the aggregate demand from Mutual Funds is less than 5% of the Net QIB Portion, the balance Equity Shares available for allocation in the Mutual Fund Portion will be added to the remaining Net QIB Portion for proportionate allocation to all QIBs. Further, not less than 15% of the Offer shall be available for allocation to Non-Institutional Bidders (out of which one-third of the portion available to Non-Institutional Bidders shall be reserved for Bidders with an application size of more than ₹0.20 million and up to ₹1.00 million and two-thirds shall be reserved for Bidders with an application size of more than ₹1.00 million, provided that the unsubscribed portion in either of the aforementioned sub-categories may be allocated to Bidders in the other sub-category) and not less than 35% of the Offer shall be available for allocation to Retail Individual Bidders in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received from them at or above the Offer Price. All Bidders, other than Anchor Investors, are required to participate in the Offer by mandatorily utilising the Application Supported by Blocked Amount ("ASBA") process by providing details of their respective ASBA Account and UPI ID in case of UPI Bidders, as applicable, pursuant to which their corresponding Bid Amounts will be blocked by the or by the Sponsor Banks under the UPI Mechanism, as the case may be, to the extent of respective Bid Amounts. Anchor Investors are not permitted to participate in the Offer through the ASBA process. For further details, see **"Offer Procedure"** on page 513 of the RHP.

Bidders/Applicants should ensure that DP ID, PAN and the Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through UPI Mechanism) are correctly filled in the Bid cum Application Form. The DP ID, PAN and Client ID provided in the Bid cum Application Form should match with the DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID available (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) in the Depository database, otherwise, the Bid cum Application Form is liable to be rejected. Bidders/Applicants should ensure that the beneficiary account provided in the Bid cum Application Form is active. Bidders/Applicants should note that on the basis of the PAN, DP ID, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI mechanism) as provided in the Bid cum Application Form, the Bidder/Applicant may be deemed to have authorized the Depositories to provide to the Registrar to the Offer, any requested Demographic Details of the Bidder/Applicant as available on the records of the depositories. These Demographic Details may be used, among other things, for giving Allotment Advice or unblocking of ASBA Account or for other correspondence(s) related to the Offer.

BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS			REGISTRAR TO THE OFFER	COMPANY SECRETARY AND COMPLIANCE OFFICER
 ICICI Securities Limited ICICI Venture House Appasaheb Marathe Marg Prabhadevi, Mumbai 400 025 Maharashtra, India Tel: +91 22 6807 7100 E-mail: heromotors.ipo@icicisecurities.com Investor grievance e-mail: customercare@icicisecurities.com Website: www.icicisecurities.com Contact Person: Namrata Ravasia SEBI Registration No.: INM000011179	 DAM Capital Advisors Limited Altimus 2202, Level 22 Pandurang Budhkar Marg Worli, Mumbai 400018 Maharashtra, India Tel: +91 22 4202 3500 E-mail: hml.ipo@damcapital.in Investor grievance e-mail: complaint@damcapital.in Website: www.damcapital.in Contact Person: Puneet Agnihotri/ Chandresh Sharma SEBI Registration No.: MB/INM00011336	 JM Financial Limited 7 th Floor, Chery Appasaheb Marathe Marg Prabhadevi Mumbai 400 025 Maharashtra, India Tel: +91 22 6630 3030 E-mail: heromotors.ipo@jmfi.com Investor grievance e-mail: grievance.ibd@jmfi.com Website: www.jmfi.com Contact Person: Prachee Dhuri SEBI Registration No.: INM000010361	 KFin Technologies Limited 301, The Centrum, 3rd Floor, 57, Lal Bahadur Shastri Road, Nav Pada, Kurla (West), Kurla, Mumbai 400070 Maharashtra, India Tel: +91 40 6716 2222 E-mail: heromotors.ipo@kfintech.com Investor grievance e-mail: einward.ris@kfintech.com Website: www.kfintech.com Contact Person: M. Murali Krishna SEBI Registration No.: INR000002221	Sakshi Dureja HERO MOTORS LIMITED Max Square, Office level, 7 th Floor, Plot No. C-3-C, Jaypee Wishtown, Sector 129, Noida, Uttar Pradesh 201 304, India Tel: +91 120 4412 000 E-mail: investorrelations@heromotors.com Website: www.heromotors.com Investors may contact the Company Secretary and Compliance Officer or the Registrar to the Offer in case of any pre-Offer or post-Offer related grievances including non-receipt of letters of Allotment, non-credit of Allotted Equity Shares in the respective beneficiary account, non-receipt of refund orders or non-receipt of funds by electronic mode, etc. For all Offer related queries and for redressal of complaints, investors may also write to the BRLMs.

AVAILABILITY OF THE RHP: Investors are advised to refer to the RHP and the **"Risk Factors"** beginning on page 21 of the RHP before applying in the Offer. A copy of the RHP will be made available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in and is available on the websites of the BRLMs, ICICI Securities Limited at www.icicisecurities.com, DAM Capital Advisors Limited at www.damcapital.in and JM Financial Limited at www.jmfi.com and at the website of our Company, HERO MOTORS LIMITED at www.heromotors.com and the websites of the Stock Exchanges, for BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and for National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com.

AVAILABILITY OF THE ABRIDGED PROSPECTUS: A copy of the Abridged Prospectus shall be available on the website of the Company, the BRLMs and the Registrar to the Offer at: www.heromotors.com, www.icicisecurities.com, www.damcapital.in and www.jmfi.com and www.kfintech.com, respectively.

AVAILABILITY OF BID CUM APPLICATION FORM: Bid cum Application Form can be obtained from the Registered Office of our Company, HERO MOTORS LIMITED, Telephone: +91 120 4412 000; **BRLMs:** ICICI Securities Limited, Tel: +91 22 6807 7100; DAM Capital Advisors Limited, Tel: +91 22 4202 2500 and JM Financial Limited, Tel: +91 22 6630 3030 and **Syndicate Members:** Sharekhan Limited, Telephone Number: +91 22 6750 2000, and JM Financial Services Limited, Telephone Number: +91 22 6136 3400, Registered Brokers, SCSBs, Designated RTA Locations and Designated CDP Locations for participating in the Offer. Bid cum Application Forms will also be available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and at all the Designated Branches of SCSBs, the list of which is available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges and SEBI.

APPLICATIONS SUPPORTED BY BLOCKED AMOUNT (ASBA): Investors have to apply through the ASBA process. ASBA has to be availed by all the investors. For details on ASBA process, please refer to the details given in the ASBA Form and Abridged Prospectus and also please refer to **"Offer Procedure"** on page 513 of the RHP. Further ASBA Application forms can be obtained from Designated Branches of SCSBs, the list of banks that are available on website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in and website of Stock Exchanges at www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com. The investors are required to fill the Bid cum Application Form and submit the same to the relevant SCSBs at the specific locations or registered brokers at the broker centers or RTA or DP's. The SCSB's will block the amount in the account as per the authority contained in application form. On allotment, amount will be unblocked and account will be debited only to the extent required to be paid for allotment of shares. Hence, there will be no need of refund.

HERO MOTORS LIMITED is proposing, subject to receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, an initial public offer of its Equity Shares and has filed a RHP dated September 9, 2026 with the RoC. The RHP is made available on the website of the SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in as well as on the website of the BRLMs, i.e., ICICI Securities Limited at www.icicisecurities.com, DAM Capital Advisors Limited at www.damcapital.in and JM Financial Limited at www.jmfi.com, the website of the NSE at www.nseindia.com and the website of the BSE at www.bseindia.com and the website of the Company at www.heromotors.com. Any potential investor should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and should refer to the RHP, including the section titled **"Risk Factors"** beginning on page 21 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP for making any investment decision.

This announcement does not constitute an invitation or offer of securities for sale in any jurisdiction. The Equity Shares have not been, and will not be, registered under the United States Securities Act of 1933, as amended ("**U.S. Securities Act**") or any state securities laws in the United States, and unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable U.S. state securities laws. Accordingly, the Equity Shares are being offered and sold only outside the United States, in "offshore transactions", as defined in and in reliance on Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act and the applicable laws of the jurisdictions in which such offers and sales are made. There will be no public offering in the United States.

SUB-SYNDICATE MEMBERS: Almondz Global Securities Limited; Ambit Capital Limited; Anand Rathi Share & Stock Brokers Limited; Asit C Mehta Financial Services Limited; Axis Capital Limited; Bajaj Financial Securities Limited; Centrum Finverse Limited; Centrum Wealth Management Ltd; Choice Equity Broking Private Limited; DB(International) Stock Brokers Limited; Eureka Stock & Share Broking Services Limited; Finwizard Technology Private Limited; Globe Capital Market Limited; HDFC Securities Limited; IDBI Capital Market Services Limited; IIFL Capital Services Limited; Jobanputra Fiscal Services Pvt. Limited; Keynote Capital Limited; KJMC Capital Market Services Limited; Kotak Securities Limited; LKP Securities Limited; Motilal Oswal Financial Services Limited; Nirmal Bang Securities Pvt Limited; Nuvama Wealth and Investment Limited; Pantomath Financial Services Limited; PAYTM Money Limited; Prabhudas Lilladher Pvt Limited; Pravin Ratilal Share and Stock Brokers Limited; Reliance Securities Limited; Religare Broking Limited; RR Equity Brokers Pvt Limited; SBICAP Securities Limited; SMC Global Securities Limited; Standard Chartered Securities; Sushil Financial Services Pvt. Limited; Systematix Shares and Stocks (India) Limited; Trade Bulls Securities (P) Limited; Trust Securities Limited; YES Securities (India) Limited.

PUBLIC OFFER ACCOUNT BANK AND SPONSOR BANK: Axis Bank Limited.

ESCROW COLLECTION BANK, REFUND BANK AND SPONSOR BANK: ICICI Bank Limited.

UPI: UPI Bidders can also Bid through UPI Mechanism.

All capitalised terms used herein and not specifically defined shall have the same meaning as ascribed to them in the RHP.

Place: Noida, Uttar Pradesh
Date: September 15, 2026

For **HERO MOTORS LIMITED**

On behalf of the Board of Directors

Sd/-

Sakshi Dureja

Company Secretary and Compliance Officer

Wednesday, September 16, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Why are AI pioneers urging a slowdown?

BY SHOUVIK DAS

Last week, Anthropic cofounder Dario Amodei urged slowing down of AI innovations. In a rare consensus, OpenAI cofounder Sam Altman and xAI's Elon Musk echoed his concern over the risks from AI. The warnings come as Anthropic and OpenAI are reportedly targeting trillion-dollar public listings. Why this sudden caution? *Mint* explores.



(L-R) xAI founder Elon Musk, Anthropic cofounder and CEO Dario Amodei, and OpenAI cofounder Sam Altman. AFP

1 What lies behind Amodei's much-discussed essay?
The backdrop is an internal event. On 8 September, Anthropic employee Jacob Coxon resigned from the company over concerns about AI firms building self-training algorithms and tools. Coxon's primary fear was that AI could develop a version of itself beyond human comprehension, ultimately taking control of the internet and society. Within days of the resignation, Amodei said in his 12 September essay, "A race to the bottom, spurred by commercial incentives, can make these risks more acute." The central argument from AI founders is that artificial intelligence (AI) progress must be regulated and evaluated by a broader group of stakeholders, including governments.

TURN TO PAGE 7

QUICK EDIT

Export defiance

There's further evidence of India's growth defying global headwinds. Government data released on Tuesday showed India's goods exports jumped 26% from a year earlier to \$43.8 billion in August. This is notable considering that global demand has been buffeted by tariff havoc started by the US, apart from unending military wars in Europe and West Asia. Indian imports grew 14% to \$70.7 billion, although their slower pace meant India's trade deficit narrowed to \$26.9 billion last month. That exports for April-August are also up a robust 18% at \$215.9 billion suggests that this export momentum isn't a flash in the pan. The government's trade deal with the UK has been operationalized while another with the EU is moving closer to implementation. These, along with others that kicked in earlier, should support trade with deal partners and thus help strengthen the Indian economy amid a bleak global outlook. This week's spike in crude oil to nearly \$110 a barrel has sent bond yields surging globally; the US 10-year Treasury bond has exceeded the psychologically significant 5% mark. This could raise credit costs around the world and weigh on global growth.

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Chairperson,
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Development Authority of India



Shri. Challa Sreenivasulu Setty
Chairman,
State Bank of India



Shri. Rajkiran Rai G.
Managing Director,
National Bank for Financing
Infrastructure and
Development

Panel Topics

Bridging India's infrastructure financing gap: Unlocking domestic and global capital

Mobilizing domestic and global insurance capital for India's infrastructure growth

Structured financial solutions for recycling capital and expanding investment:
Securitization, CDS and TRS

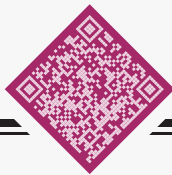
Asset monetization for states: Attracting institutional capital for infrastructure



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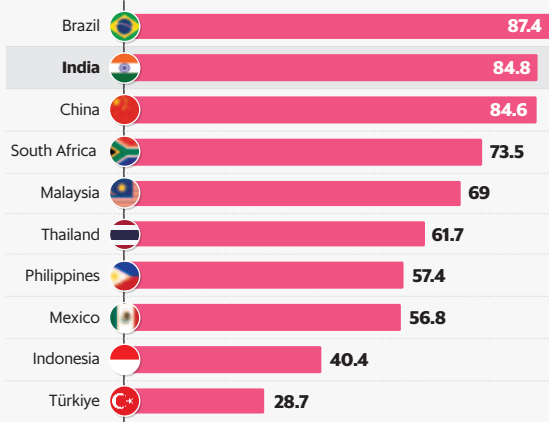
WHY REDUCING GOVT DEBT IS KEY FOR INDIA

BY DEEPA VASUDEVAN

India's high interest-to-revenue burden and strict market expectations for emerging economies make reducing public debt key to safeguard investor trust, even as India runs lower debt levels compared to advanced economies.

India has one of the highest debt ratios among emerging market economies

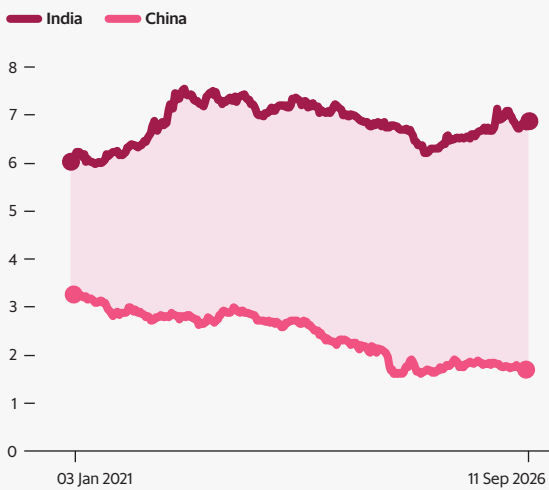
General government debt as % of GDP among key emerging market economies, 2021-2025 average*



*Five-year average based on the latest available data used.

Government borrowing rates in India are much higher than in China

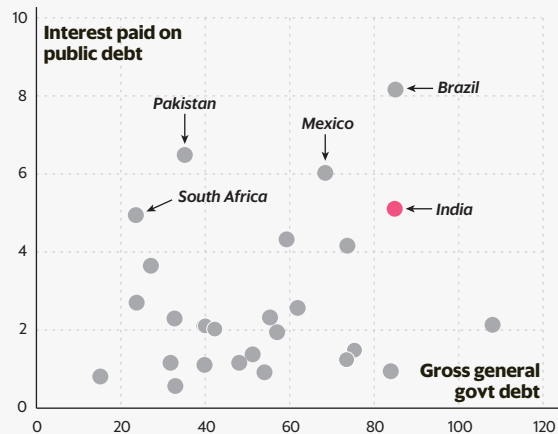
Yields on 10-year government bonds (in %), weekly



Source: International Monetary Fund, Investing.com

For its level of outstanding debt, India has a relatively high interest-to-GDP ratio

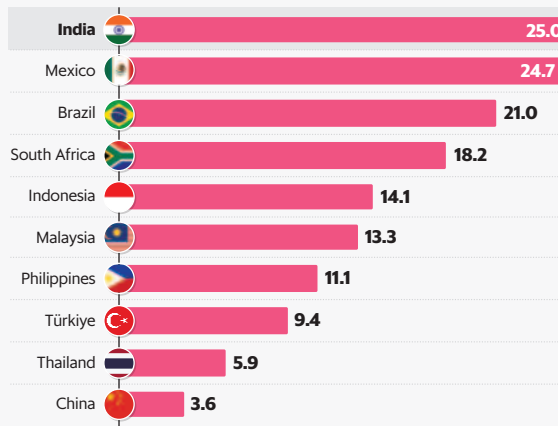
Values as % of GDP, 2022-2024 average*



*Three-year average based on the latest available data used.

India earmarks over a quarter of government revenues towards interest payments

Interest paid on public debt as % of revenues in key emerging market economies, 2022-2024 average*



*Three-year average based on the latest available data used.

AT A GLANCE

● India's government debt is lower than in major advanced economies, but is high among emerging markets where investors dislike fiscal slippage and rising borrowing.

● India's interest burden is unusually high: interest payments are about 5% of GDP and nearly a quarter of government revenue, limiting funds available for other spending.

● Unlike China, India faces relatively high borrowing costs alongside high debt, making its interest burden much larger despite similar debt levels, pressuring public finances.

● With global bond yields rising and tax revenue stuck around 10-11% of GDP, continued debt reduction is crucial to contain interest costs and retain investor confidence.

Long-term bond yields have risen across the US, Europe and Japan as major advanced economies run high debt-to-GDP levels, signalling lower market tolerance for fiscal imprudence and rising inflation risks. India has a relatively lower level of debt, yet, it is important to keep trimming its debt.

Indeed, during a recent address in Chicago, finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman reaffirmed the government's commitment to reduce the Centre's debt to 50% of GDP by 2030, in keeping with the fiscal glide path till 2030-31.

If we assume that states' debt will remain at the current level of about 30% of GDP, total government debt should be at 80% of GDP by 2030. That is low compared with the 100% plus debt-to-GDP levels of major advanced economies. Also, most of the borrowing is domestic, so there is no exchange rate risk.

Still, India cannot afford to be complacent. It needs to stay the course on fiscal consolidation for two reasons: debt levels are higher than in emerging-market peers, and interest payments as a percentage of GDP and government revenue are sizeable.

LOWER TOLERANCE FOR EMS

Benchmarked against a group of comparable emerging markets, India is among countries with the highest debt-to-GDP ratio. This is a matter of concern because global investors have a lower debt tolerance for emerging markets than for advanced countries. For example, nobody expects Japan, with debt estimated at 204% of GDP, to default. On the other hand, the ratings outlook for Indonesia, with debt to GDP at 41%, and Mexico, with debt to GDP at 62%, was revised downward from stable to negative this year, largely due to widening fiscal deficits and higher government spending.

Advanced economies get away with higher borrowings, owing to their deep and liquid government bond markets, independent and credible institutions, and greater availability of revenues for public spending. Emerging economies have large funding needs and inadequate domestic savings. Therefore, India's medium-term strategy of bringing down debt is critical to retain investor confidence and attract foreign capital flows.

INTEREST BURDEN

India largely underperforms on two widely-tracked indicators of fiscal health: interest payments as a percentage of GDP and interest payments as a percentage of government revenue.

The former measures the size of debt obligations, and the latter assesses the ability of the borrowing country to service its debt obligations. India's interest-to-GDP ratio is around 5%, considerably higher than the median level of 2.1% among large emerging market economies. To some extent, this is logical, because India also has relatively high debt. But the relationship between debt and interest is not straightforward.

For instance, China's average debt over 2022-24 was 84% of GDP, and its interest payments amounted to 0.93% of GDP. In contrast, India's average debt in the same period was quite similar—at 84.8% of GDP, but interest payments amounted to 5.1% of GDP. In another example, both India and South Africa had interest-to-GDP ratios around 5%, but South Africa had much lower debt at 23.4% of GDP.

INTEREST DIFFERENTIAL

The reason for this apparent disconnect between debt and interest is that the interest-to-GDP ratio is determined by three variables: interest rate, outstanding debt, and GDP. Countries with high debt and high interest rates face higher interest payments, and those with low debt and low interest rates face comparatively lower interest payment burdens.

India belongs to the first category. In the past decade, the weighted average rate on central government securities has ranged from 6 to 8%, and the corresponding rate for state gov-

ernment securities was 20 to 80 basis points higher. Rates hover around 7-8% when the RBI is tightening policy (2022, 2023) and they drop to 6-7% in periods of monetary easing (2025). China's economic arc is quite different: benchmark government yields have not crossed 4% in the last decade. Since the pandemic, it has faced deflationary conditions, a property market downturn, and weak domestic demand. The Chinese central bank has kept rates low to stimulate spending, which is reflected in declining yields of government bonds. Thus, China's high debt is offset by its ultra-low interest rates, resulting in a low interest-to-GDP ratio.

REVENUE STRAIN

The ratio of interest-to-government revenue measures the share of revenue committed to interest; the higher the ratio, the lower the revenue available for other expenditure. A study of emerging market and developing countries by the International Monetary Fund showed that ratios above 16-19% signal a likelihood of fiscal stress. India is well over this threshold: a quarter of its revenue is earmarked for interest payments. The challenge is that the government's ability to increase tax revenue is constrained by a narrow tax base and large informal sector. In fact, the Centre's tax revenue has been stuck at 10-11% of GDP for more than two decades. Combine low revenue with a high interest burden, and it is easy to see why India faces a higher burden compared to its EM peers. There are no simple solutions. High nominal growth could lower debt ratios by increasing the denominator. Also, stronger growth would raise household and corporate income, potentially leading to higher tax revenues. But given the economic shocks of the past few years, relying on growth is not enough. The recent run-up in global bond yields indicates that markets are less tolerant of public debt, especially as trade tensions and high oil prices add to inflationary pressures. With borrowing costs unlikely to decline significantly in the near term, India must stay the course on reducing public debt, at both central and state levels, to contain its interest burden and retain investor confidence.

Deepa Vasudevan is an independent writer in economics and finance.
feedback@livemint.com

Wednesday, September 16, 2026

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From sugar to eggs, El Niño's domino effect ▶ P10

Tata Sons may seek order review as RBI files caveat ▶ P5

SENSEX 74,003.81 ↓ 777.95 NIFTY 23,118.60 ↓ 279.50 DOLLAR ₹95.88 ↑ ₹0.34 EURO ₹110.71 ↑ ₹0.09 OIL \$103.90 ↓ \$0.11 POUND ₹129.35 ↓ ₹0.47

Himalayan infra set for insurance shock

Premiums to rise on climate concerns after Nepal catastrophe

Manas Pimpalkhare, Rituraj Baruah & Harsh Kumar

NEW DELHI

The disastrous Nepal-Tibet floods last month could make infrastructure across the Himalayas more expensive to insure, as climate change reshapes the region's risk profile. If the past is any indication, there could be a spike coming up: insurance rates for roads and bridges had risen about 21% after the way less severe 2023 Sikkim glacial lake outburst flood (GLOF). Insurers and reinsurers are now assessing the likely rise in premiums, three people in the know said.

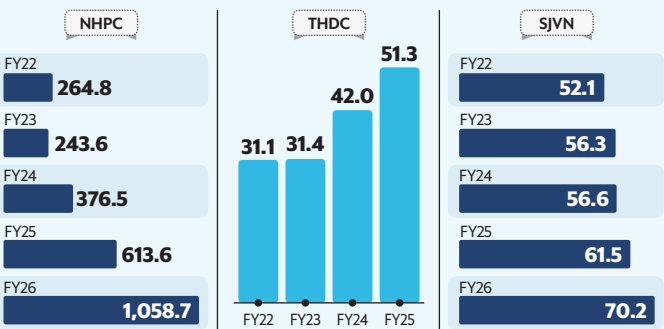
The region is seeing rising incidents of flash floods, landslides, and GLOFs. The 26 August Nepal event has made insurers and reinsurers brainstorm on the extent of the damage and also what it means for risks in the region, the people said.

Insurers say the final premium pricing for such projects in the Himalayan region will depend on the availability and cost of reinsurance capacity, against the backdrop of the latest calamity as well as the earlier ones such as the 2023 Sikkim GLOF and the 2013 Uttarakhand flash flood and landslides raising premiums.

PREMIUM PAIN

Climate change is making infra in the Himalayas expensive to insure.

Insurance expenses (in ₹ crore)



Source: Company annual reports

INSURANCE SQUEEZE

INSURERS, reinsurers to work out the extent of the damage

INSURANCE costs rising for 'run-of-the-river' hydel projects

PROPERTY, casualty insurance market was at \$39.3 bn in 2026

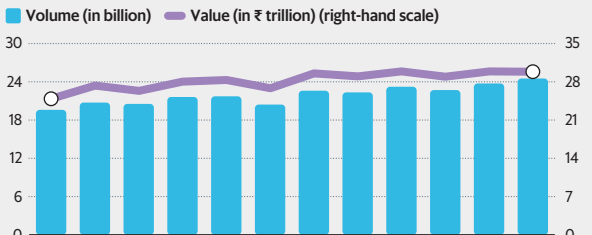
The frequency of such natural calamities has risen due to climate change, according to companies' annual reports and experts. On an average, India's annual disaster-related hit was about 0.4% of GDP between 1990 and 2024, per OECD's Economic Outlook for Southeast Asia, China and India 2025.

Insurance costs are rising for 'run-of-the-river' hydropower projects—which use a river's flow with little or no water storage—and other infrastructure projects such as roads. State-run NHPC incurred ₹2,557.13 crore in insurance expenses over the

TURN TO PAGE 6

Digital surge

India's UPI platform processed 241.6 billion transactions worth ₹314.2 trillion in FY26.



UPI payments over ₹2k to attract fees

Anshika Kayastha & Harsh Kumar

MUMBAI/NEW DELHI

The finance ministry on Tuesday said that a 0.4% merchant discount rate (MDR) will apply to person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI transactions above ₹2,000, while person-to-person (P2P) transactions will remain free irrespective of value.

For transactions of ₹75,000 and above, the MDR will be capped at ₹300 per transaction, the ministry said in a statement.

The announcement brings to a close months of discussions over charges for higher-value UPI transactions.

The new framework follows the government's decision on

Monday to keep UPI transactions of up to ₹2,000 free of MDR, with banks and payment system providers barred from imposing direct or indirect charges on such transactions. Only 4% of merchant transactions will be affected by the introduction of MDR, according to the statement, as most transactions either fall below the ₹2,000 threshold or qualify for zero MDR under the P2PM framework for small merchants.

"P2P transactions constitute 37% of the total UPI transactions in volume terms and 70% in value terms," the finance

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CBDC may get a push ▶ P4
PhonePe IPO plans ▶ P6

BoB loaned NMC despite red flag from internal unit

Shayan Ghosh
shayan.g@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Bank of Baroda, which settled a legal battle involving healthcare firms founded by Abu Dhabi-based B.R. Shetty for \$600 million in July, had received internal alerts on alleged "roundtripping" of funds by the group as early as in 2016.

Even after the bank's anti-money laundering (AML) unit sent at least three alerts to its Abu Dhabi branch, the state-owned lender sanctioned fresh loans to the NMC Group, according to emails and court documents reviewed by *Mint*.

Bankers said the cost of not acting on an AML alert is high and such failures could lead to huge implications for lenders.

"The regulator has an extremely low bar for such failures. If a bank does not act on an alert that specifically points to a circular transaction, it could raise questions on the accountability of bank staff," said a director at a large bank, who asked not to be identified.

Shetty, the 84-year-old founder of the NMC Group, came under fire after short seller Muddy Waters Research

TURN TO PAGE 9

DON'T MISS



NSE IPO looks cheap, but its derivatives outlook is weak

Shares of NSE are offered at a roughly 30% discount to rival BSE Ltd on FY27 earnings estimates, despite being nearly three times its size. The apparent bargain, however, comes as NSE's derivatives business faces a weaker growth outlook. ▶ P6

E-commerce rules may force brands to rethink discounts

India's new e-commerce rules could force brands and sellers to rethink how they use discounts, particularly short-term price cuts that help drive sales during specific periods of the month, according to company executives and analysts. ▶ P3

Decade-high exports surge trims trade gap in August

Merchandise trade deficit narrowed to \$26.86 bn in August from \$31.98 bn in July, helped by robust export growth and a sharp decline in gold imports. Merchandise exports surged 26.12% year-on-year to \$43.81 bn, as per provisional commerce ministry data. ▶ P2

Delhi HC orders tax dept to refund ₹783 cr to Teva Israel

The Delhi high court on Tuesday quashed tax proceedings against Israeli drugmaker Teva Pharmaceutical and its US affiliate arising from a deal with Ranbaxy, and ordered the income tax department to refund about ₹783 crore to Teva Israel. ▶ P2

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Rural unemployment rate fell to 4.1% in August from 4.5% in July.

Jobless rate holds at 5% in August amid rural recovery

Subhash Narayan
subhash.narayan@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's unemployment rate held steady at 5% in August, as a rise in urban joblessness was offset by an easing in rural unemployment, according to the latest Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) bulletin released by the statistics ministry on Tuesday.

The unemployment rate for people aged 15 years and above rose to 6.8% in urban areas in August from 6.7% in July, driven by an increase among both men and women, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) said.

In rural areas, however, the unemployment rate fell to 4.1% from 4.5% in July. Rural male unemployment declined to 4.3% from 4.6%, while female unemployment fell to 3.9% from 4.3%.

Compared with August 2025, the overall and urban unemployment rates remained broadly stable, while the rural rate fell 0.2 percentage point, from 4.3% to 4.1%.

The overall labour force participation rate (LFPR) rose to 55.6% in August from 55.4% in July and 55% a year earlier. Rural LFPR increased to 58.2% from 58%, while urban LFPR held at 50.4%.

Female LFPR also increased, to 34.8% in August from 34.4% in July, and remained above the 33.7% recorded in August 2025.

The worker population ratio (WPR) rose to 52.8% from 52.5%, driven by rural areas. Rural WPR increased to 55.8% from 55.4%, while urban WPR held at 47%.

Male WPR rose to 73.5% in August from the previous month and a year earlier, the survey said.

The overall unemployment rate among men aged 15 years and above declined for the third consecutive month, reaching 4.9% in August from 5.4% in May. Rural male unemployment fell to 4.3% in August from 4.6% in July, while urban male unemployment rose to 6.1% from 5.9%.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Best August for exports in a decade slashes trade deficit

Merchandise exports rose 26.12% y-o-y to \$43.81 billion, while imports rose 14.1% to \$70.67 bn

Harsh Kumar
harsh.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's merchandise trade deficit narrowed to \$26.86 billion in August from \$31.98 billion in July, helped by a surge in exports and a sharp drop in gold imports. Higher crude prices, however, pushed up the import bill.

Merchandise exports surged 26.12% year-on-year to \$43.81 billion, while imports rose 14.1% to \$70.67 billion, provisional commerce ministry data showed on Tuesday. August exports were the highest for the month in a decade.

Gold imports fell to \$2.3 billion from \$4.16 billion in July, helping offset higher energy costs. Crude oil prices remained elevated, with India's crude basket averaging \$90.19 a barrel in August, up from \$82.04 in July.

Total exports, including services, rose to \$82.68 billion from \$65.93 billion a year ago, while total imports climbed to \$92.09 billion from \$77.55 billion. The overall trade deficit narrowed to \$9.41 billion from \$11.62 billion in August 2025.

Services data for August is provisional, with the latest available Reserve Bank of India (RBI) data being for July.

For the April-August period, total exports were estimated at \$399.27 billion, up 15.55% from \$345.55 billion a year earlier, while total imports rose



Gold imports fell to \$2.3 billion in August from \$4.16 billion in July, helping offset the pressure from higher energy costs.

18.01% to \$459.65 billion.

The cumulative overall trade deficit widened to \$60.38 billion from \$43.94 billion a year earlier.

Merchandise exports during the period rose 17.85% to \$215.91 billion from \$183.21 billion a year earlier, while merchandise imports increased 18.21% to \$363 billion from \$307.09 billion.

Services exports during April-August were estimated at \$183.36 billion, up 12.95% from \$162.34 billion a year earlier, while services imports stood at \$96.65 billion, up 17.30% from \$82.40 billion.

On the import side, petroleum, crude

and products accounted for the largest share at \$95.57 billion during the April-August period, followed by electronic goods at \$66.48 billion and machinery, electrical and non-electrical, at \$28.46 billion. Gold imports stood at \$17.47 billion, while transport equipment, non-ferrous metals, coal, coke and briquettes, organic and inorganic chemicals, artificial resins and plastic materials, and vegetable oils were among the other major import categories.

Crude oil imports, which account for up to 25% of the total import bill, have also added to import pressures. India's crude import bill had reached \$63.37

billion by July, up 56% from a year earlier, accounting for more than half of the \$123 billion oil import bill for 2025-26.

The November contract of the benchmark Brent is currently around \$108 per barrel. The Indian basket of crude oil, which represents a derived basket comprising the Sweet grade (Brent Dated) and the Sour grade (Oman and Dubai average) of crude oil imported by Indian refineries, was at \$128.70 as of 14 September.

India, which imports about 90% of its crude oil, remains particularly exposed to sustained price increases. According to a Bank of Baroda estimate, a persistent \$1 increase in crude oil prices can raise the country's annual import bill by about ₹18,000 crore.

Inflationary pressure has been building amid volatility since the start of the war in West Asia in late February this year. In August, India's retail inflation rose to a 20-month high of 4.82%, driven by higher fuel and food prices, taking it above the Reserve Bank of India's 4% target midpoint for the third consecutive month since January 2025. Wholesale inflation also edged up to 9.92% in August from 9.78% in July, according to government data.

The US, meanwhile, remained India's largest export destination during April-August, with shipments worth \$42.79 billion.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Current account deficit widens to \$7 billion in July

PTI
feedback@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's current account deficit (CAD) widened to \$7 billion in July from \$3.2 billion a year ago, mainly due to a higher merchandise trade deficit, according to the Reserve Bank data released on Tuesday.

The preliminary data on India's balance of payments (BoP) for July 2026 released by the central bank showed that the merchandise trade deficit rose to \$31.7 billion in July from \$28.2 billion in the same month last year.

Imports increased to \$76.8 billion from \$65.6 billion, while exports rose to \$45.1 billion from \$37.4 billion.

On the other hand, there was improvement in net services surplus, which increased to \$17.6 billion in July from \$16.4 billion in the year-ago month. Services exports stood at \$38.3 billion while imports totalled \$20.6 billion during the month under review.

Net transfers increased to \$13.2 billion in July 2026 from \$12.6 billion, while net income outgo widened to \$6.1 billion from \$4 billion.

The capital account recorded a net inflow of \$27.7 billion in July 2026, sharply higher than \$3.5 billion in the



Higher merchandise trade deficit widened current account deficit in July.

year-ago month. According to the data, net foreign direct investment inflows rose to \$7.3 billion in July from \$4.5 billion a year earlier. Net foreign portfolio investment recorded an inflow of \$4.1 billion against an outflow of \$2.5 billion in July 2025.

The overall balance stood at a surplus of \$20.8 billion in July 2026, compared with \$0.3 billion in the year-ago month.

For the April-July period of 2026-27, the current account deficit stood at \$11.2 billion, compared with \$6.6 billion in the corresponding period of 2025-26.

The capital account recorded a net inflow of \$23.9 billion during April-July 2026, against \$11.4 billion a year earlier.

Imports increased to \$76.8 billion from \$65.6 billion, while exports rose to \$45.1 billion from \$37.4 billion

Centre plans three-month shelf life for specialized cement

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's consumer affairs ministry plans to mandate a three-month shelf life for specialized cement, shorter testing timelines and more detailed batch and product information, two government officials involved in the process said.

Specialized cement varies in composition and performance requirements, and is used in applications requiring enhanced performance or durability such as dams and bridges. With inadequate storage for cement at construction sites, a "three-month best-before" tag will help ensure that cement is not used beyond the recommended period, when moisture in the air can make it lose its compressive strength.

The ministry will move ahead with the proposal after consultations with all stakeholders such as cement manufacturers and infrastructure developers. Cement bags currently carry information such as manufacturer details and



Cement bags now contain only information such as batch numbers.

batch numbers.

A "best before" date marked on the cement bags will make it easier for buyers to assess by when they should be used. The proposed changes could require manufacturers to alter packaging and marking processes and adhere more strictly to testing timelines.

"From an industry perspective, such a system can strengthen quality awareness and build greater confidence among end-users," said Aparna Reddy, executive director of Aparna Enterprises

Ltd, a maker of building materials in Hyderabad. "It also provides an opportunity for manufacturers and the broader construction ecosystem to adopt better storage, distribution and stock-rotation practices."

The government and its agencies are stepping up spending on highways, bridges, dams and other large infrastructure projects, where the quality of construction materials can have a direct bearing on the durability and lifespan of assets.

Government scrutiny of construction quality has also increased after a series of bridge collapses and deficiencies in highway projects.

In response to a *Mint* query, a spokesperson of the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) said the requirement of mentioning a "best before" date is covered under the marking clause of individual cement standards and that all cement standards are also covered under the Cement (Quality Control) Order, 2003.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Krishna Yadav
krishna.yadav@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The Delhi high court on Tuesday quashed tax proceedings against Israeli drugmaker Teva Pharmaceutical Industries Ltd and its US affiliate arising from a deal with Ranbaxy Laboratories, and ordered the income tax department to refund about ₹783 crore to Teva Israel.

This brings relief to Teva in a nearly nine-year-old court battle over the payments linked to erstwhile Ranbaxy, now part of Sun Pharmaceutical Industries Ltd.

A bench of Justice Dinesh Mehta and Justice Vinod Kumar found that the tax proceedings against Teva USA were time-barred and without jurisdiction and quashed the notices and proceedings arising from them. The court also allowed Teva Israel's plea seeking a refund of tax deducted in India on payments received for assessment years 2012-13, 2013-14 and 2014-15.

It directed the tax department to refund about ₹783 crore, along with applicable



The HC ruling brings relief to Teva in a nearly nine-year-old court battle over the payments linked to erstwhile Ranbaxy.

interest, within two months. The refund, however, is subject to Teva complying with conditions imposed by the court, including providing the required corporate guarantee or solvent surety.

"Respondent is directed to refund the said amount of approximately ₹783 crore, along with the applicable interest, within two months, subject to and upon compliance with the conditions of corporate guar-

antee/solvent surety recorded in paragraph 231. All pending applications, if any, stand disposed of accordingly," the court said.

The written judgment was not available till press time, to assess the full reasoning and potential impact of the ruling on multinational companies that move contractual

rights or payments between group companies in different countries.

In 2010, Ranbaxy entered

into an agreement with Teva Pharmaceuticals USA over the sale of a generic version of the cholesterol drug atorvastatin in the US. A commercial dispute later developed between the companies.

Teva USA had prepared to enter the US market, while Ranbaxy was also seeking to launch the drug. After the dispute, Teva USA sued Ranbaxy in the US. The companies eventually settled the dispute in December 2011 through a revised agreement. Under the arrangement, Ranbaxy was allowed to sell the drug but agreed to share 50% of its profits from the product with Teva.

The original agreement was between Ranbaxy and Teva USA. However, Teva USA later transferred its right to receive the payments to Teva Pharmaceutical Industries Ltd in Israel. Ranbaxy subsequently made payments totalling about ₹1,851 crore to the Israeli company and deducted tax in India.

The income-tax department questioned why the money was ultimately being paid to Teva Israel when the original agreement was with Teva USA.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

MINT SHORTS

Goyal to visit US for G20 trade ministerial this month

New Delhi: Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal will visit the US at the end of this month to participate in the G20 trade ministerial in Milwaukee, and he is expected to hold a bilateral meeting with US trade representative Jamieson Greer, commerce secretary Rajesh Agarwal said on Tuesday. The two-day ministerial will begin on 30 September.

India, NZ trade pact likely in force from latter half of Oct

New Delhi: The India-New Zealand free trade agree-

ment is likely to come into force late next month, with official dates to be announced shortly, commerce secretary Rajesh Agrawal said on Tuesday. The two countries signed the free trade agreement (FTA) on 27 April to boost two-way commerce in goods and services and promote investment. The FTA provides duty-free access for 100 per cent of India's exports to New Zealand.

India, China start discussions on trade concerns

New Delhi: India and China have started discussions to address bilateral trade concerns, with the two sides expected to hold more meetings to take the engagement forward, commerce secretary Rajesh Agrawal said on Tuesday. The recent meeting between commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal and his Chinese counterpart Wang Wentao was an initial discussion to understand each other's positions on trade-related issues.

India's largest shipyard to come up in Raigad



Mumbai: Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Ltd (MDL), a defence PSU, will invest about ₹27,000 crore on a greenfield shipbuilding cluster at Dighi Port in Maharashtra's Raigad district, a move expected to generate 90,000 jobs, the state government said on Tuesday. As per an agreement signed, MDL is targeting annual shipbuilding capacity of at least 2 million gross tonnes at Dighi.

Nageswaran urges pvt sector to keep investing, hiring

New Delhi: Chief economic adviser V. Anantha Nageswaran on Tuesday urged the private sector to keep investing, hire more, and compensate fairly. The next 20 years will be very different from the past 80, and public policy alone can't carry the economy, he said.



India's August soy oil, palm oil imports rise on stocking

Mumbai: India's soy oil imports surged to a record in August, while palm oil purchases climbed to a six-month high, as refiners stocked up ahead of the country's festival season, a leading industry body said on Tuesday. Higher palm oil and soy oil buying by India could help top producers move their stocks, supporting benchmark palm oil and soy oil futures.

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E-commerce rules may force brands to rethink discounts

The real test will come during next year's festive sales, when discounts help drive volumes

Sowmya Ramasubramanian
sowmya.r@livemint.com
BENGALURU

India's new e-commerce rules could force brands and sellers to rethink how they use discounts, particularly short-term price cuts that help drive sales during specific periods of the month, according to company executives and analysts.

The Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Amendment Rules, 2026, notified on 10 September, require platforms to display both the reduced price and the lowest price at which a product was offered in the preceding 30 days whenever a price reduction is announced. The rules will come into effect on 1 January 2027.

While the rules are aimed at curbing dark patterns and improving price transparency, they could force brands to rethink how they time and structure discounts. Strategies built around frequent, short-term price cuts may become harder to sustain, potentially reshaping sales patterns during key shopping periods.

"The safer bet is that brands will maintain the same price for 30 days, rather than risk a lower price today, limiting the discounts they can offer later," said the founder of a personal care brand, on condition of anonymity.

An apparel seller with a presence across major e-retail platforms such as Flipkart, Myntra and Nykaa Fashion expects brands to be more cautious about running successive promotions. "This could particularly affect the practice of offering deeper discounts during the first week of the month, when sales tend to be stronger," the seller said.

Sourabh Narula, head of global sales at home and personal care brand Beco, said 25-27% of the company's monthly sales currently take place in the first



The new e-commerce rules will come into effect on 1 January.

MINT

seven days of the month, helped by higher discounts during that period. He expects some of this demand to shift towards the end of one month and the beginning of the next.

The real test will come during next

The changes could also affect how sellers respond to price differences across platforms. A temporary reduction on one marketplace could become relevant when calculating the lowest price advertised elsewhere.

DISCOUNT RECKONING

STRATEGIES built around frequent, short-term price cuts may become harder to sustain

THE changes could also affect how sellers respond to price differences across platforms

A temporary cut on one marketplace could set the lowest advertised price elsewhere.

FOR marketplaces, the challenge is magnified by the number of third-party sellers

year's festive sales, when e-commerce platforms and sellers rely heavily on discounts to drive volumes. By then, the new pricing rules will be in force, potentially forcing brands to rethink how they structure and time their biggest promotions, according to executives.

"Brands need to be very tight with price matching across all the platforms as well as their own website. With lower discount percentages, platform loyalty will be severely tested," said the founder of the personal care brand. Price mismatches are typically cor-

rected within hours, the founder said. But under the new framework, even a brief reduction could affect the discount a seller is able to advertise later.

"Implementation of this rule will require a lot of tech changes," said Satish Meena, analyst at Datum Intelligence. "Platforms will also have to manage pushback from sellers whose promotional strategies could be affected."

However, with the rollout still months away, platforms are likely to use the ongoing festive season to identify and iron out potential glitches before the January deadline, according to Meena.

The rules require platforms to maintain enough pricing information to establish the relevant 30-day reference price across products and sellers. The government has also introduced requirements around search rankings, sponsored listings, seller information, and annual self-audits for dark patterns.

For marketplaces, the challenge is magnified by the number of third-party sellers and the frequency with which prices can change.

Platforms will likely need automated systems to track stock-keeping unit (SKU)-level prices, maintain historical records and flag discounts that could fall foul of the new requirement, according to Meena.

The treatment of coupons, bank offers, membership benefits and other promotional mechanisms could also become an important part of implementation, particularly where the effective price paid by a consumer differs from the listed selling price.

"The biggest challenge will be defining what constitutes the actual selling price when there are multiple layers of discounts and offers. Platforms will have to bring greater clarity to how these are recorded and displayed," Meena added.



Flam raises \$40 million in Series B led by QED Investors

Mansi Verma
mansi.verma@livemint.com
MUMBAI

An (artificial intelligence) interactive content company Flam has raised \$40 million in a Series B round led by QED Investors, as the startup looks to expand its product suite and scale enterprise sales globally, the company said on Tuesday.

Claypond Capital, Martin Chavez, Olivier Pomel, Venky Harinarayan and actor Shah Rukh Khan participated in the round, along with existing investors RTP Global and Dovetail, the company added.

The funds will be used for research and development of Flam's AI models, expanding its product suite and scaling enterprise sales globally.

The company declined to disclose its valuation in the series B funding round. According to data from Tracxn, the company was last valued at \$32.3 million.

"We think interactive is the next default for the internet," said Shourya Agarwal, founder of Flam. "The demand was



The funds will be used for research and development of Flam's AI models.

REUTERS

always there. The technology wasn't. We have made interactivity effortless to build and deploy at enterprise scale."

Flam is targeting \$100 million in annual recurring revenue (ARR) over the next 18-24 months, Agarwal told *Mint*, but did not disclose the current ARR figures.

Flam has grown its enterprise customer base to more than 100, including Google, Reliance and Hyundai, from roughly 30-40 a year ago, with geographic expansion, particularly in the US and Japan, driv-

ing much of the growth, he said. Its business is currently split roughly 50:50 between India and international markets, with the US and Japan accounting for most of its overseas business, followed by the UAE, South-East Asia and other markets, Agarwal said.

Flam previously raised \$22.5 million in equity funding, including a \$14 million round in April 2025 from Turbostart, Inventus Capital Partners, RTP Global and Dovetail Capital.

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MIT-WPU, Pune is honoured to announce the Hafeez Contractor School of Architecture, named after one of India's most celebrated architects and a visionary who has transformed the country's architectural landscape.

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Through his partnership with MIT-WPU, Pune, he brings a benchmark of design excellence and creative courage to the next generation of architects, urging them to stay grounded, curious, and forward-thinking.

Building on a Legend. Shaping the Architects of Tomorrow.



A moment of honour: Dr. Rahul V. Karad, Executive President, MIT-WPU, Pune and Prof. (Dr.) Raviraja N. Seetharam, Vice Chancellor confer the citation upon Padma Bhushan Awardee Architect Hafeez Contractor at MIT-WPU, Pune.

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Cement price hikes may not stick

Harsha Jethmalani
harsha.j@livemint.com

Cement makers could be making their last-ditch effort to shield themselves from profitability pressures with the September quarter (Q2FY27) at its fag-end. They are trying to tackle input cost inflation by raising prices amid muted demand in a seasonally weak quarter. But dealers caution that implementation remains challenging.

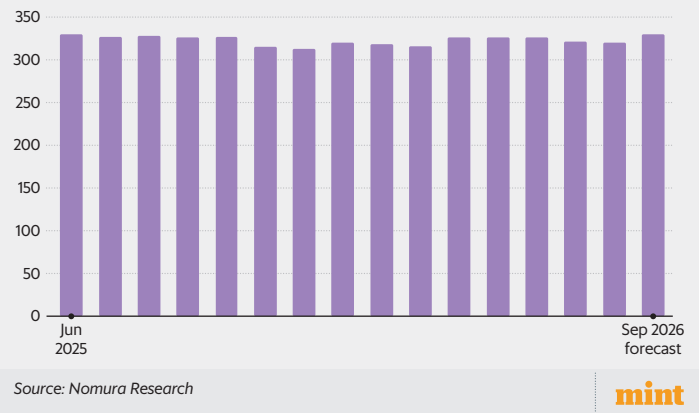
According to Nomura Global Markets Research, average pan-India prices in the trade segment could rise by ₹10 per bag month-on-month to ₹330 in September. In the trade segment, cement is sold through a network of local dealers, usually in 50-kilogram bags. But price hike attempts are unlikely to succeed. September's volume offtake may be hurt by monsoon-related slowdown in construction activities and non-availability of labour due to festivals.

In July-August, industry volume growth is estimated at 6-7% year-on-year, according to Motilal Oswal Financial Services. Demand is driven

Deciding factor

Cement prices may rise by ₹10/bag month-on-month in September as companies pass on input cost inflation.

Average cement trade prices at all-India level (in ₹/50 kilogram bag)



Source: Nomura Research

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

by higher infrastructure spending, while retail/residential construction activity remains more dependent on rainfall and labour availability.

Demand growth in September would be aided by a low base, said the 7 September Motilal Oswal report, adding that regional demand trends remain mixed amid high competition.

Uneven demand conditions constrain pricing power. It could hamper volume growth for firms with regional exposure, but geographically diversified firms such as Ultra-Tech Cement, ACC and Ambuja could be better placed. Cement spreads, a key leading indicator of industry unitary Ebitda, currently

averages at around ₹2,447 per tonne, implying a sequential drop of ₹63 per tonne as pricing conditions don't fully offset elevated fuel costs, said Nomura in an 8 September report.

While the costs of key fuels, imported petroleum coke and coal, have moderated from the peaks seen

after the beginning of the West Asia war, their impact on earnings is reflected with a lag. Low-cost inventory could be a differentiating factor in Q2FY27 earnings. But lower costs can protect profitability only to a certain extent, so sustaining price hikes beyond Q2 is crucial. Demand could recover in H2FY27 on a pick-up in government infrastructure spending and new residential launches, improving cement makers' pricing power and realization prospects.

Price hike attempts in South, East and select West India suggest that companies are seeking to establish a pricing floor ahead of the post-monsoon recovery, said Systematic

Shares and Stocks (India). Near-term profitability, however, is likely to remain under pressure from ₹70-150 per tonne of incremental sequential costs in Q2FY27, it added.

True, firms are cutting costs and

increasing their use of green power to counter fuel price volatility and lower emissions. But weak pricing discipline in H1FY27 leaves earnings exposed to downside risks.

Profitability pressures could extend beyond H2FY27 if the West Asia war leads to a renewed spike in input costs.

In Q1FY27 earnings call, companies said they are upbeat on H2FY27 demand prospects. But weak agricultural incomes due to a below-average monsoon may hurt rural housing demand.

So far in 2026, stocks of large cement makers have declined more than the 1% fall in benchmark index Nifty 50. Valuations have moderated, but fundamentals must improve.

PRICING PRESSURE

UNEVEN demand conditions in a seasonally weak quarter constrain pricing power

SLOWDOWN in construction activities and weak farm incomes could hurt volumes

Tata Sons listing hopes boost Afcons. Is a re-rating on cards?

Manish Joshi
feedback@livemint.com

Shares of Afcons Infrastructure surged 20% intraday on Tuesday, before closing 3.5% up, fuelled by upbeat investor sentiment over the potential listing of Tata Sons. The link between the two lies in their ownership structure: promoter group Shapoorji Pallonji holds a 50% stake in Afcons and also owns 18% of Tata Sons.

Afcons boasts a strong track record in the engineering, procurement and construction (EPC) business, with Ebitda margins outperform-

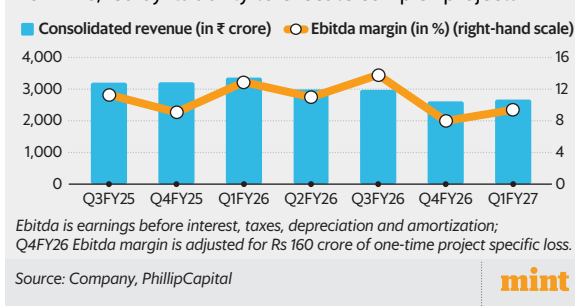
ing Larsen & Toubro's (L&T) projects and manufacturing division. Afcons reported Ebitda margins of 10-11% for FY25 and FY26, compared to L&T's 8.3%.

However, high interest expenses absorbed nearly 55% of Afcons's ₹1,217 crore Ebitda in FY26, escalating further to 69% in Q1FY27. Absolute interest costs rose 7% year-on-year to ₹173 crore during the quarter.

If the promoter group resolves its liquidity issues by monetizing its Tata Sons stake following a listing, Afcons' interest burden could ease. This relief would not necessarily

Engineering prowess

Afcons Infrastructure maintained double-digit Ebitda margin for FY26, led by its ability to execute complex projects.



Ebitda is earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization; Q4FY26 Ebitda margin is adjusted for ₹160 crore of one-time project specific loss.

Source: Company, PhillipCapital

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

require equity infusions that dilute existing shareholding. Instead, an improved credit rating for the group

could enable Afcons to negotiate lower interest rates on its debt.

Could a resolution to

Afcons's interest cost burden trigger a re-rating for the stock? Likely so, given its robust order book of ₹43,300 crore and a solid book-to-bill multiple of 3.8 as of Q1FY27. Margins could also expand further if the company secures more international contracts, such as the Croatia rail project won in Q1FY27.

Overseas orders currently account for 26% of the backlog, with domestic projects making up the rest. On the Q1FY27 earnings call, management noted that international projects yield 200-300 basis points higher profitability than

domestic ones, meaning increased execution of overseas work could deliver upside margin surprises.

Afcons stock has lost 32% of its value in 2026 so far to ₹262, and has largely traded below its public issue price of ₹463 in November 2024.

The business outlook remains strong, and any reduction in the interest burden would directly boost earnings per share. Even without factoring in potential interest cost savings, the stock trades at an attractive price-to-earnings multiple of 17.4 based on PhillipCapital's FY28 estimates.

Options traders see Nifty rebound by September-end

Ram Sahgal
ram.sahgal@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The stock market slipped decisively below the Nifty's crucial 24,000-support earlier this month, but derivatives traders remain bullish, continuing to hold the maximum put options contracts at this level for the monthly expiry on 29 September.

This means that as of now, they expect the market to close at or above that level at the end of the month. If that happens, they retain the premium paid by the put buyers. Analysts said traders have taken this stance as they expect tensions between the US and Iran to abate by the month-end.

The 24,000 put expiring on 29 September had 93,151 contracts outstanding as of Friday, while the 24,000 call had 130,891 contracts outstanding. Both these had the highest concentration among all other strikes or levels. Nifty options

have a price interval of 50 points. However, persisting upside pressures on crude oil and global bond yields began forcing at least some of these bulls to close out their positions last week, resulting in a steep jump in the option prices.

The open position at the 24,000 put slipped from 112,981 contracts last Monday to 93,151 contracts on Friday, underscoring the tension among sellers.

Analysts said worsening external headwinds could threaten the Nifty's next support at 23,000 and the index may head to around 22,800 levels. For now, they don't expect the Nifty to plumb to the 52-week low of 22,182.55 reached at the height of the



Open interest in 24,000 puts fell sharply last week. REUTERS

West Asia war on 2 April.

Part of that fall, they said, would be worsened by short-covering of put options sold at higher levels, say 24,000, by the bulls.

"Rising crude and bond yields are queering the pitch for the market," said Shrikant Chouhan, research head at Kotak Securities. "Bulls probably reckon a tamping-down of Middle East tensions, which is why the positions are strong at 24,000. We will have to wait and see."

The price of benchmark Brent crude oil has risen by 20% through \$107 a barrel over the past one month, with the theatre of war in West

Asia expanding to the Red Sea from the Strait of Hormuz, crimping supplies from Saudi Arabia.

Over the same period, yield on the US 10-year bond has risen by 6% to a historic high of 5%, adding to fears of an interest rate hike. The India 10-year benchmark bond yield has also spiked by 20 basis points to 7%, raising concerns of an interest rate hike at Reserve Bank of India's forthcoming monetary policy meeting on 5-7 October.

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Fee on UPI may nudge users towards CBDC

Anshika Kayastha &
Harsh Kumar

MUMBAI

The introduction of merchant discount rate (MDR) charges on person-to-merchant (P2M) transactions on the unified payments interface (UPI) could help the government and the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) push retail use cases for the central bank digital currency (CBDC), especially for key subsidy transfers. Higher adoption of the digital currency is also seen easing some burden off the over-strained UPI.

There is an expectation that the introduction of MDR could give a push to retail CBDC adoption, as some users and merchants may move towards the digital rupee to avoid such charges, which could have a positive impact on its adoption, three people aware of the development told Mint.

It is also expected that the Centre's move on MDR on Tuesday is just the first phase of charges on UPI, and as these charges rise and extend to other payment segments, some merchants and users could find value in shifting to CBDC wallets that remain completely free as of now.

So far, the adoption of CBDC has been low due to the wide-scale use of UPI, given its easier customer interface and technological advancements by private fintechs on guardrails. In comparison, CBDC for retail users has so far been rolled out only by certain banks and is still 'invite-only' for customers of most banks, as they test resili-



Banks are keeping retail CBDC invite-only to test infrastructure capacity within closed user groups. ISTOCKPHOTO

ience and load carrying abilities of the infrastructure within closed user groups.

"If merchants want to avoid the transaction cost or MDR on larger-value transactions, they will have the option of accepting payments through CBDC, where there may not be any charge," said former RBI deputy governor R. Gandhi.

"The choice between UPI and CBDC depends on several factors. The hope would certainly be that CBDC develops further. But it is still in the pilot stage, and it is not easy for ordinary customers to accept CBDC straight away," he said, adding that CBDC requires considerable adoption.

To be sure, CBDC is interoperable with UPI, which means payments in CBDC can be made through UPI infrastructure and QR codes. While this

provides a huge customer-facing infrastructure for CBDC, the back-end processing for such payments by banks and RBI is still different and requires work before it can be rolled out at full scale, said two of the people cited above.

"CBDC transactions do not

involve MDR because they do not need the interbank settlement chain involved in usual account to account payment transactions. As a sovereign form of money in the digital form, CBDC does not have the trappings of MDR," said Sharat Chandra, founder EmpowerEdge Ventures, a venture building firm for fintechs and startups.

While CBDC usage is currently low, the government is in an advanced stage of finalizing specific use cases to enable the use of retail CBDC, starting with

government subsidies under agriculture, the two people said.

"With programmable CBDC, payouts under direct benefit transfer can be transferred to farmers, who then may use it only for agriculture-related purposes such as buying fertilizer or seeds," said one of the people quoted above. "The government is thinking along these lines and planning to come out with such national use cases soon." Such transfers will also help the Centre track the end use of subsidies and avoid channel leaks, the person added.

The central bank is running some state-level pilots for direct benefit transfer of subsidies.

Other such use cases being considered include payouts or chargebacks under the flagship healthcare programme Ayushman Bharat Scheme and for educational fees and payments, in addition to rural and semi-urban use cases through offline CBDC wallets.

The pilot for the first such use case, likely payments under DBT, is expected to be rolled out in the next six to seven months, the people said.

In its annual report for 2025-26, RBI said some CBDC pilots were launched during the year, leveraging the programmability capability of CBDCs. In Gujarat, Puducherry and Chandigarh, public distribution system (PDS) beneficiaries were credited food subsidy via it.

The people cited above conceded that CBDC adoption will require extensive customer engagement and awareness.

anshika.kayastha@livemint.com

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Hero Motors IPO: A lot is riding on EVs

Mayur Bhalerao

mayur.bhalerao@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Hero Motors Ltd's electric mobility business is expanding and profits are rising. Its ₹1,000-crore initial public offering (IPO), however raises a question: Can a richer product mix accelerate modest sales growth and improve returns from under-used facilities?

Hero Motors' ₹1,000 crore IPO opens on Wednesday and closes on Friday, with a price band of ₹79-84 a share. It arrives a day ahead of National Stock Exchange of India Ltd's (NSE) much-awaited ₹22,561.5 crore IPO—more than 22 times the size of Hero Motors' offer.

The IPO comprises a ₹600 crore fresh issue and a ₹400 crore offer for sale by promoters O.P. Munjal Holdings and Hero Cycles. Fresh proceeds will fund ₹190 crore of debt repayment and ₹200 crore of equipment for expansion at its Gautam Buddha Nagar facility. Other uses include unidentified acquisitions, strategic initiatives and general corporate purposes.

Hero Motors supplies components and complete powertrain systems for electric and conventional vehicles. Powertrain solutions contributed 53.7% of FY25-26 revenue, with alloys and metal castings accounting for the rest.

Hero Motors' capabilities span design, prototyping, validation and manufacturing. Its majority acquisition of UK-based Hewland Engineering added expertise in high-performance transmissions. The company's e-mobility revenue more than doubled from ₹128.1 crore in FY24 to ₹273.3 crore in FY26, increasing its share of sales from 12% to 23%.

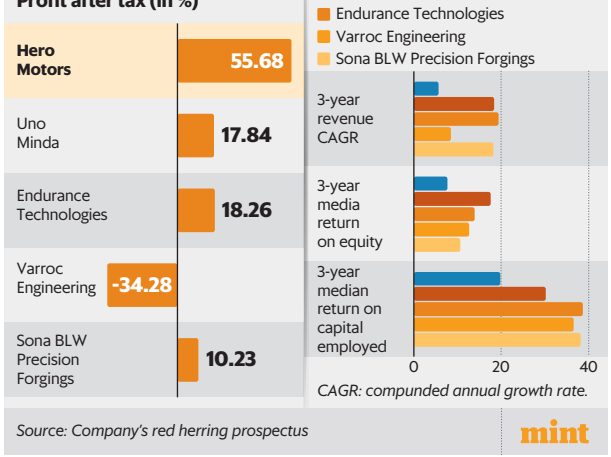
Net profit rose from ₹17 crore to ₹41.2 crore between FY24 and FY26, at an annualized rate of 55.7%—the fastest among its peers—albeit from a low base. Its peers Uno Minda, Endurance Technologies and Sona BLW recorded growth of 10-18%, while Varroc Engineering reported a decline over the same period.

Growth test

Hero Motors leads on profit growth but returns trail peers.

Annualized net profit growth between FY24 and FY26

Profit after tax (in %)



Source: Company's red herring prospectus

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

enue more than doubled from ₹128.1 crore in FY24 to ₹273.3 crore in FY26, increasing its share of sales from 12% to 23%.

Net profit rose from ₹17 crore to ₹41.2 crore between FY24 and FY26, at an annualized rate of 55.7%—the fastest among its peers—albeit from a low base.

Its peers Uno Minda, Endurance Technologies and Sona BLW recorded growth of 10-18%, while Varroc Engineering reported a decline over the same period.

"Profitability has improved as powertrain solutions, our higher-margin business, has grown faster than alloy metallurgy," Amit Gupta, managing director and chief executive of Hero Motors told Mint. "Ebitda

margins in gears and transmissions exceed 20%, compared with 5-7% in alloy metallurgy; so, the changing business mix is lifting overall margins."

Santosh Meena, head of research at Swastika Investment, noted the shift towards higher-value powertrain and EV components was beginning to deliver. "But sustaining the margin gains would depend on rising e-mobility share, better utilization at newer plants and narrowing subsidiary losses."

Despite a richer product mix, its top line growth was on a slow lane. Revenue increased from ₹1,064.4 crore in FY24 to ₹1,188.4 crore in FY26, at an annualized rate of 5.7%—the slowest among the peers.

Endurance led with 19.4%, followed by Uno Minda and Sona BLW at about 18% each, and Varroc at 8.5%.

Gupta anticipated slow sales growth to the time needed to develop products, with projects taking two to three years to develop within an overall eight-year cycle. Several projects backed by capital expenditure over the past three years are now moving into production, which he expects to drive its next phase of growth.

Hero Motors also lagged its peers on returns, with the lowest median return on equity and return on capital employed over FY24-FY26, at 7.7% and 19.8%, respectively.

Meena said underused facilities, five loss-making subsidiaries and declining return on capital employed showed earlier investments had yet to deliver adequate returns. Expanding the better-utilized Gautam Buddha Nagar plant made sense, he said, but stronger utilization across facilities and firm orders for new capacity would improve confidence.

Hero Motors' underlying financial metrics present a mixed picture, but the narrative around its recent growth push offers some cushion.

However, the business remains exposed to significant revenue risks. Its largest customer accounted for 35.6% of FY26 revenue. Its top five contributed 61.4%, and the top 10 accounted for 72.9%. While these shares have declined since FY24, dependence on a few buyers leaves it exposed to order cuts and pricing pressure.

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Trusts may urge Tata Sons to seek RBI review of IPO order

RBI files caveat in HC on Tata Sons matter; listing issue muddles search for new chairman

Varun Sood & Satish John
MUMBAI

Tata Trusts want Tata Sons to explore all options, including asking the Reserve Bank of India to reconsider and clarify its decision directing it to go public, before taking legal recourse, two group executives aware of the plans said.

The central bank is understood to have filed a caveat in the Bombay high court on Monday to ensure its position is heard before any judicial order on the public listing of Tata Sons, which could mark the start of a protracted legal tussle between the central bank and India's largest conglomerate. The decision follows RBI's Saturday letter rejecting Tata Sons' request to surrender its registration, which would force it to proceed with a public share sale.

Since Tata Trusts chair Noel Tata and most trustees desire to keep Tata Sons private, the holding company could seek court intervention, *Mint* reported on 12 September.

"Is it a battle drawn?" quipped a Tata Group executive when asked about RBI filing a caveat, suggesting it is prepared to fight a potential legal suit from the Tata Group.

"We will do everything it takes. For now, the legal route is the only option. But before that, Tata Trusts wants Tata Sons to ask the RBI to reconsider its decision and clarify why it rejected its plea. Then they will take the legal route. All this is expected to be discussed in the board meeting," said the executive, referring to Tata Sons' board meeting on 17 September.

The meeting will be the first since N. Chandrasekaran on 12 August said he will not seek a third term at the conglomerate's helm. It is unclear whether the Tata Sons board, led by Chandrase-



RBI caveat could mark start of a long legal tussle between it and Tata Group. PTI

karan, will support its main shareholder Tata Trusts in challenging the RBI order or go against it, the second executive said. This is because two trustees—Venu Srinivasan and retired defence secretary Vijay Singh—have

Srinivasan, the Tata Sons board includes group CFO Saurabh Agrawal and independent directors Harish Manwani and Anita Marangoli George.

According to the three top Tata executives, while some of Noel Tata's

plaint against a smaller Tata trust linked to Sir Ratan Tata Trusts (SRTT), accusing it of wrongdoing. Srinivasan also complained that the number of permanent members at SRTT is breach of rules. These complaints caused the Maharashtra charity commissioner to stop SRTT from holding board meetings or making official decisions. Former trustee Mehli Mistry too has filed multiple challenges against Tata Trusts.

Developments on the listing front have muddled Tatas' plans to find a new leader for Bombay House. A five-member panel to choose Chandrasekaran's successor can be formed only after getting representatives from both Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust. Queries emailed to Tata Sons, Tata Trusts and RBI seeking comment went unanswered.

One lawyer termed RBI's caveat filing as one of the "saddest days" in corporate India.

"If it comes to litigation between the House of Tata and the Reserve Bank of India, that will be among the saddest days in our corporate history," said Nitin Potdar, a Mumbai-based independent corporate lawyer. "The RBI took 29 months to decide the simplest of applications in the case of Tata Sons. When Shanghi Finance took the same route, it was out of the framework in three months. Two similarly placed applicants received different treatment, and no reasons were published for either. This is not a matter for the courts. It is a matter for the two of them to sit across a table and resolve, in the interest of Indian business. If this is how

India's regulator treats the House of Tata, the world will draw its own conclusion".
varun.ood@livemint.com
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opponents have proactively filed complaints while remaining trustees, the Tata Trusts chairman has typically reacted to such moves since taking over in October 2024.

A few months ago, Singh filed a com-

HEADED FOR BATTLE

TATA Sons' board is meeting on 17 September and will take a call whether to take legal course

THE meeting will be the first since N. Chandrasekaran on 12 August said he will not seek a third term

IT is unclear whether the Tata Sons board will support Tata Trusts in challenging the RBI order

TRUSTEES Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh had shifted position, and back listing of Tata Sons

changed their earlier position, and now support listing Tata Sons. Singh was removed from the Tata Sons board last September, while Srinivasan remains one of the Trusts' two nominees. Besides Chandrasekaran, Noel and

Solar Industries expects 3x revenue in 2 yrs

Nehal Chaliawala
nehal.chaliawala@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Solar Industries Ltd expects its revenue to increase more than three times to about ₹32,000 crore in the next two years with its \$1.36 billion acquisition of South Africa's Omnia Holdings Ltd, the company's managing director told investors on Tuesday.

The Nagpur-based manufacturer of industrial explosives also expects its earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization (Ebitda) to more than double and surpass ₹7,000 crore by FY28, managing director Manish Nuwal said. The company reported revenue of ₹9,838 crore and Ebitda of ₹2,750 crore in FY26.

The earnings bump will come from an increased presence of the combined company in 110 countries from



The firm expects its Ebitda to more than double by FY28.

about 90 at present, with manufacturing sites spread across 25 nations, up from 11. However, the focus of the combined entity would be on expanding in the Indian and African markets, Nuwal said.

Along with the expanded distribution footprint, the acquisition is expected to bring Solar Industries the benefit of downstream integration with Omnia's ammonium

nitrate manufacturing facility. The South African company manufactures a variety of nitrate products, including ammonium nitrate, a key input for industrial explosives that Solar Industries presently buys from the market.

"So having ammonium nitrate, having large manufacturing presence in explosives backed up by initiating systems and down the whole services of blasting solutions definitely creates a lot of synergy benefit for Solar as a company. So that is what we looked into this deal," Nuwal said.

Solar Industries, whose share price has exploded in the past 18 months due to its expansion into defence, will also get an entry into the agricultural sector with the acquisition. Omnia makes crop nutrition, biological and bio-similar products. The Johannesburg-based company also has a third chemicals business division.

However, news of the acquisition made investors nervous, and they dumped the Solar Industries stock in early trading on Tuesday. The scrip traded at ₹19,499 at 12.15pm on Tuesday, which is 12.6% below its previous close. Despite this, the stock has returned 60% since the beginning of 2026.

Nuwal ruled out an equity dilution by Solar Industries to fund the acquisition. Instead, the transaction will be funded by debt taken on the books of Omnia, which has a cash surplus. The debt will then be managed through internal accruals, Nuwal said.

Solar Industries has agreed to acquire a 100% stake in Omnia, which is listed on the Johannesburg Stock Exchange, Nuwal said. He did not elaborate on how the company was confident of acquiring the stake of the company's minority shareholders.

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Embassy bets big on luxury housing

Madhurima Nandy
madhurima.n@livemint.com
BENGALURU

Embassy Developments Ltd (EDL), the residential development arm of Embassy Group, plans to renew its focus on premium and luxury projects, given the high demand from homebuyers, investors and non-resident Indians amid limited supply, managing director Aditya Virwani said in an interview.

In 2025-26, 125 residential units priced at over ₹10 crore were sold in Bengaluru, totalling ₹2,087 crore, compared to 84 similarly priced units sold in FY25, according to a recent Southern Indian High End Luxury Housing Report by CRE Matrix and Sotheby's International Realty. Embassy projects accounted for over 60% of the sales in Bengaluru in this price segment.

Hyderabad remained the market leader in this segment,



Aditya Virwani, managing director, Embassy Developments Ltd.

with 645 units sold for ₹8,562 crore, while Chennai was the smallest of the three, with 58 units sold for ₹727 crore. "Bengaluru has scope to do more but supply is limited. This is why we want to double down on ultra-luxury housing. We want to be known for luxury but also want to hit volumes with premium projects. Our definition of premium is a ₹2

crore entry price in an Embassy project," Virwani said. This week, EDL is launching the first phase of an 85-acre development in north Bengaluru with ₹4,500 crore of gross development value. One of the two projects to be launched has 217 villas with a starting price of ₹14 crore. The second project has flat priced at ₹2 crore and above. It will

launch another premium residential tower, named Embassy One, with 59 units in the city.

EDL has a sales booking target of ₹8,000 crore in FY27, supported by a robust ₹19,500-crore launch pipeline. It has already launched inventory worth ₹9,000 crore.

In FY26, it reported around ₹4,631 crore of sales bookings. It expects Bengaluru to continue to lead, even as Mumbai steadily gains traction. "South India's luxury market has reached an inflection point. Hyderabad has emerged as the undisputed leader. Bengaluru is in the midst of a transformation with new corridors, proving premium living is no longer confined to legacy addresses. Chennai holds its own as a prestige-driven market with a niche buyer profile," said Abhishek Kiran Gupta, co-founder and CEO, CRE Matrix.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Peak XV to bet big on wealth, wellness, premium consumer

Priyamvada C.
priyamvada.c@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Pean XV Partners, formerly known as Sequoia Capital India and SEA, is seeing a wave of niche opportunities in financial services and consumer businesses as premiumization and faster paths to scale have opened segments that were previously less prominent, said Sakshi Chopra, managing director at the firm. "Over the next two decades, India's fintech and financial services sectors will evolve significantly as the country gets richer and adds more millionaires and billionaires. This will create opportunities in areas such as wealth management," Chopra told *Mint* in an interview.

In the consumer sectors, she noted that companies are reaching the ₹100 crore revenue threshold much faster than before. "Across most consumer categories, the markets are deep enough to support multiple players, rather than being winner-take-all, with strong talent density to build new businesses," Chopra said.

Her recent deals include in sure tech startup Plum's \$21 million in March, travel fintech startup Scapia's \$63 million round alongside other investors in May, quick commerce company Firstclub's \$55 million round alongside Sofina in June, a follow-on round in Neo Group's ₹350 crore fundraise in July and women's wellness brand Nua's \$50 million round co-led by Filter Capital earlier this month.

Peak XV has been investing in India for the past two decades. Its key investments include Zomato, and Sarvam AI



Sakshi Chopra, managing director, Peak XV Partners.

ades. It operates as an independent entity following the split of Sequoia Capital India and South-east Asia from the global venture capital firm in June 2023. Its key investments include Zomato, Sarvam AI, Groww, Pine Labs, Razorpay, Turtlemint, and Zetwerk.

The last 10-15 years in fintech and financial services were about building the infrastructure—from payments to credit and NBFCs, where companies of significant scale have been built. "The next decade will see opportunities shift toward wealth and asset management, insurance and brokerage and fixed incomes platforms with multiple new players emerging as Indians have

more investible incomes," she said, adding that there will likely be many more mutual fund companies launched over the next couple of years. Platform plays typically have worked well in India across both consumer and financial services. These businesses offer a full suite of products, as in the case of Stable Money, a fixed income platform, and Neo Group. For

instance, Neo, which began with wealth management, has expanded to launch other verticals including insurance broking, private credit, and a secondaries fund.

"The opportunity is not just to build a distribution business, but also to have a manufacturing layer via an asset management business to offer customers a unique pipeline of products," Chopra said.

Within consumer, she further pointed to several companies being built across health, fitness, nutrition, and wellness, with premium, better-for-you products emerging across food and beverages, home, FMCG and travel. The investment firm is also seeing opportunities in the single-specialty healthcare sector—an emerging segment attracting a lot of investor interest.

"India has already seen waves in IVF, ophthalmology and diabetes care, but we're now seeing even more specialized categories emerge because the TAM is large enough to support them," she said, citing examples of portfolio firms like Hoola Health, a paediatric healthcare startup, and Luma Fertility, which specializes in IVF treatments.

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PhonePe's listing hopes rise as MDR returns to UPI

Agnidev Bhattacharya
agnidev.bhattacharya@livemint.com
MUMBAI

PhonePe Ltd is evaluating options to restart its initial public offering (IPO) process after the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) introduced a 0.4% merchant discount rate (MDR) on large UPI transactions effective next month, according to two people familiar with the matter. MDR is the fee collected from merchants for processing digital payment transactions.

While a share sale is not likely anytime soon, the notification on transaction fee parameters provides structural clarity that facilitates a path to public equity markets, these people said, asking not to be identified as the details are private. PhonePe plans to submit updated financial metrics with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) before moving forward with a listing, one of these people said.

Under the new parameters, a 0.4% MDR will apply to person-to-merchant transactions over ₹2,000, capped at ₹300 per transaction.

For context, PhonePe said on 16 March that it had paused its listing plans due to global capital market volatility and geopolitical tensions. According to its latest IPO documents, filed with Sebi on 21 January, the IPO was a pure offer for sale of up to 50.66 million shares, led by major shareholder Walmart Inc, along with other prominent investors such as Tiger Global and



UPI notification provides structural clarity BLOOMBERG

Microsoft Corp. Before putting its IPO plans on hold, the company was looking to list at a valuation of \$9 billion to \$10.5 billion, according to a PTT report.

In its draft IPO papers, the company had said, "Going forward, a carefully structured MDR regime could provide the necessary commercial incentive for ecosystem players to continue investing in innovation, infrastructure, and merchant acquisition."

Before putting its IPO plans on hold, PhonePe was looking to list at a valuation of \$9 billion to \$10.5 billion

It went on to add that while MDR may "marginally increase costs for certain segments, the revenue potential could strengthen the business case for digital payment providers, enabling deeper coverage, improved service quality, and continued growth in UPI adoption across the country. Such changes could also in turn impact our results of operations."

PhonePe said in response to *Mint's* queries, "We won't be able to share a comment at this time."

NSE may look cheap, but has little room for earnings miss

The upper end of the price band is about 6% below NSE's latest unlisted market price

Abhinaba Saha
abhinaba.saha@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The much-awaited initial public offering (IPO) of the National Stock Exchange Ltd (NSE) opens this week with a valuation paradox: at ₹1,700-1,785 a share, NSE is being offered at a roughly 30% discount to rival BSE Ltd on FY27 earnings estimates, despite being nearly three times its size. The apparent bargain, however, comes as NSE's dominant derivatives business faces a weaker growth outlook, and investors have little room for an earnings miss.

The upper end of the price band is about 6% below NSE's latest unlisted market price of around ₹1,900, fuelling investor interest ahead of the ₹22,569 crore IPO, which opens on 17 September. Grey market activity suggests NSE could list at an 11-12% premium to its offer price.

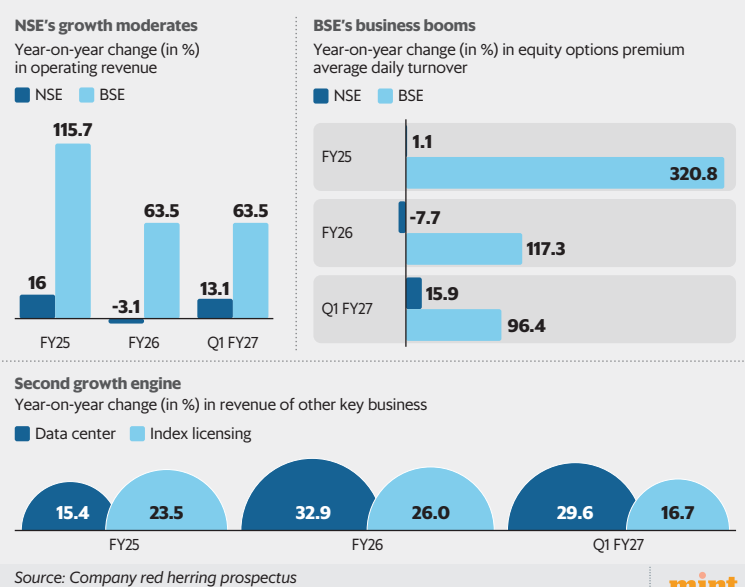
But the valuation gap may not be the opportunity it first appears to be.

"(The) gap is not a genuine headroom (for an upside)," cautions Kush Gupta, director at SKG Investments and Advisory. BSE delivered stronger earnings momentum through fiscal year 2026 (FY26) as NSE's growth slowed, he said. The discount could narrow if BSE's low-base advantage fades or NSE restores investor confidence by sustaining its FY27 earnings recovery, Gupta added.

NSE reported 13% year-on-year growth in operating revenue and 7% growth in profit in the June quarter of FY27 (Q1 FY27), helped by a 16% rise in equity options premium average daily turnover, per the red herring prospectus (RHP). Higher trading volumes and better price realization drove a 16% rise in options transaction revenue that makes for over 60% of operating revenue.

Valuation trap

The valuation gap may not be the opportunity it first appears to be.



But the recovery has not restored NSE's competitive position. Its share of the equity options premium market fell to 68.5% in Q1 FY27 from nearly 97% in FY24, according to its RHP.

The shift accelerated after the Securities and Exchange Board of India

But the recovery has not restored NSE's competitive position. Its share of the equity options premium market fell to 68.5% in Q1 FY27 from nearly 97% in FY24, according to its RHP.

The shift accelerated after the Securities and Exchange Board of India

GROWTH WORRIES

APPARENT bargain comes as NSE's derivatives business faces a weaker growth outlook

GREY market activity suggests NSE could list at an 11-12% premium to its offer price

NSE's total monthly derivatives turnover fell to ₹33.5 tn in Aug, the first month after CAS was introduced

NSE's operating revenue rose 13% and profit 7% year-on-year in the June quarter of FY27

SAMCO Securities, finds this encouraging, noting that the sharpest regulatory impact is behind the market and NSE's market share is likely to stabilize in the near term. "Regulation has reset this business, not ended it," he said.

(Sebi) limited each exchange to one weekly index expiry in late 2024, redistributing trading activity and allowing BSE to capture liquidity that had previously been spread across NSE's multiple weekly expiries.

Himalayan infrastructure projects brace for a climate risk premium

FROM PAGE 1

last five fiscal years from FY22 to FY26, with insurance premiums swelling to ₹1,058.68 crore in FY26, 72% more than ₹613.63 crore of FY25, annual reports showed. Other state-run hydropower firms SJVN Ltd and THDC Ltd saw 14% and 22% jump in insurance cost, respectively, in recent years.

Road asset operators said insurance claims have become more frequent as climate change-led risks, including erratic weather, rising temperatures, unprecedented heavy rainfall, flash floods, have become more common.

"Since the incident in Teesta Vin Sikkim in 2023, a new term has come in the insurance formalities, GLOF. After that, premiums have increased," said an executive with a state-run hydropower firm and one of the people cited above requesting anonymity. "In FY24, there were some issues in terms of reinsurance as the global insurers who generally take up these reinsurances were reluctant as geo-mapping showed glaciers across the Himalayas in a similar condition, making reinsurers wary that projects in other Himalayan states of India

would also be impacted. However, reinsurances were provided after intensive deliberations, but at a higher cost."

"Now, post the unfortunate incident in Nepal, we do not expect hydro projects with reservoirs to witness a major impact. But the insurance cost for run-of-the river projects will increase, and as witnessed post the 2023 incident in Sikkim, reinsurances may have to be negotiated much more rigorously," the executive added.

The 26 August flood triggered by a glacier collapse along the Nepal-Tibet border swept away over 11 hydropower plants and destroyed roads and other infrastructure, killing nearly 1,200 people, with thousands reported missing, *Reuters* reported on 4 September. While final estimates are not yet out, the commercial insurance losses are pegged at over \$132.3 million, it said, citing the chief executive of Oriental Insurance Co Nepal, an arm of the New Delhi-based insurer.

While the cost of insurance premiums for hydropower firms is borne by the company, insurance premiums for roads and highways are a crucial part of concessionaire agreements in build-operate-transfer



Insurers say premiums rise if the demand for insurance rises. AFP

(BOT) projects, wherein developers or operators bear it. Road asset operators said that the increasing frequency of climate-related events is changing the risk landscape. "Natural perils have definitely increased, and with this, the frequency of insurance claims has also increased," said Zafar Khan, president of industry lobby group, the Highways Investors Association.

He said alternative products, such as parametric insurance, could become more relevant as climate-risk modelling improves. This offers a pre-agreed payout, and not a sanc-

tioned claim post-incident.

"The clearest evidence for roads and bridges comes from the insurance market's response to the 2023 Sikkim disaster. Following the event, insurers reportedly increased the applicable rate for roads and bridges from 0.43 per thousand of the sum insured to 0.52 per thousand, a rise of about 21%," said Shivanshu Thaplyal, partner in the energy, infrastructure, and resources team at law firm Khaitan & Co.

Insurance premium hikes are not the only way of covering climate risk, with insurers also keeping the option of higher

deductibles, exclusions from particular perils, and more stringent underwriting norms in the policy, added Thaplyal.

Insurers say premiums rise if the demand for insurance rises. "It will be very early to predict anything at this stage. However, we are closely monitoring each and every situation, particularly developments in the reinsurance market and the demand for reinsurance capacity. There may

be chances of an increase in insurance premiums depending on how demand evolves. We have seen a surge in demand for reinsurance, and if this trend continues, premiums could go up,"

said a top executive at an insurance firm, adding that "it would be premature to give any specific estimate for the coming years." To be sure, while insurance firms insure assets, reinsurance companies cover the insurers. India's property and casualty insurance market was estimated at \$39.3 billion in 2026, according to Mordor Intelligence, with the figure including several lines beyond infrastructure insurance.

The Himalayan region has seen a slew of floods, landslides, cloudbursts and GLOFs in recent years

The Himalayan region has witnessed a slew of floods, landslides, cloudbursts and GLOFs in recent years, including major events in Uttarakhand (2013), Himachal Pradesh (2023), Sikkim (2023) and Nepal (2024 and 2026).

"These issues get aggregated and the cumulative effect is very negative... Insurers notice these incidents. For them, it is like one single Himalayan

region, which they think is becoming fragile," said A.K. Singh, a hydrologist and an adjunct professor at IIT Roorkee. "Insurance premium depends on the risk perception. After the

GLOF incident in Sikkim in 2023 and even the massive floods and landslides in Uttarakhand in 2013, the insurance premiums increased. If insurers feel risk has increased, the premiums will also increase," added Raj Kumar Chaudhary, former chairman and managing director of NHPC.

NHPC operates 18 hydropower projects totalling 7.1 GW across the Himalayan region in Jammu & Kashmir, Ladakh,

Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh.

Queries emailed to the ministries of power as well as that of environment, forest and climate change, NHPC, SJVN, THDC, National Highway Authority of India (NHAI), reinsurer GIC Re on 13 September remained unanswered until press time.

Climate risk is not just for the Himalayan region.

Infrastructure insurance is likely to become more expensive in other parts of the country as well.

"Climate change is affecting the Himalayan region today. It will also affect coastal regions—low-lying regions—with rising sea levels," said Vinayak Chatterjee, co-founder and managing trustee of The InfraVision Foundation, an infrastructure think tank.

"So, in the future, due to inland droughts, rising sea levels, and other such climate change-related phenomena, insurance premiums will also rise for infrastructure assets in these regions, such as roads, bridges, toll plazas, and any other infra," he said.

manas.pimpalkhare@livemint.com

SKINN gets in the game for pricier perfumes after masstige gains

Neethi Lisa Rojan
neethi.rojan@livemint.com
MUMBAI

India's perfume market is entering a new phase as consumers move beyond entry-level fragrances and increasingly trade up to higher-priced products. With this shift opening up a new growth avenue, Titan SKINN is doubling down on premium fragrances after building its presence in the ₹1,000-3,000 masstige, or the mass market and prestige, segment.

"In the last three years, we have started launching products between ₹3,000 and ₹5,000 twice a month," said Manish Gupta, chief executive

officer of fragrances and women's bag division and corporate business group at Titan.

Products of over ₹3,000 now contribute 15-20% of SKINN's value mix, Gupta told *Mint*, adding that consumers are beginning to move up the price ladder.

Titan divides the perfume market into four broad segments based on the price of a 100ml bottle: value products of below ₹1,000, masstige products between ₹1,000 and ₹3,000-3,500, premium at ₹3,000-8,000 and luxury products at above ₹8,000.

The value segment remains the largest, making for roughly ₹2,500 crore of the organized perfume market, as per Titan's

estimates. The masstige segment, where products offer a luxury or premium feel at an affordable price, contributes about ₹750-800 crore, while premium brings in about ₹600 crore and products above ₹8,000 around ₹500 crore.

"Today, I'm very happy to say that the perfumes part is growing much faster," he said. "There's much more innovation and investment by many, many players happening in the perfumes part."

Titan, which includes SKINN and Fastrack perfumes, is seeing early signs of consumers spending more on fragrances. "Yes, it is happening," he said, referring to premiumization. "We are seeing



Titan SKINN is doubling down on premium fragrances after building its presence in the ₹1,000-3,000 masstige segment.

that in e-commerce trends; there is a 10% rise in average ticket size in the last one year." The firm sees its customer base providing a pathway into

premium fragrances. It is also increasing its premium launch frequency and expanding physical sampling points, betting that consumers enter-

ing with lower-priced fragrances can eventually be persuaded to trade up.

Kiosks are not just retail outlets but customer-acquisition points as consumers can smell and try products before buying, Gupta said. It has 18 kiosks and targets 100 by FY28 or FY29. "Trial is the best mantra for acquiring customers," he said. The firm provided trials to 6-7 million last year.

SKINN was launched in 2013 and is among Titan's "emerging business", along

with clothing brand Taneira and bag brand Irth. The emerging business saw ₹508 crore revenue and Ebit loss of ₹114 crore in FY26, per latest investor day presentation.

Titan aims to grow the segment revenue 3.4 times by FY30.

About half of the organized perfume market is now online through quick-commerce and marketplaces, said Gupta. "E-commerce has a very

large share in the value category," he said. Younger buyers are increasingly using online



The court scheduled the next hearing for December. MINT

Court seeks OpenAI's reply on ANI content use plea

Yash Tiwari
yash.tiwari@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The Delhi high court on Tuesday issued a notice to ChatGPT creator OpenAI on an appeal filed by news agency *Asian News International (ANI)*. The plea challenges a 24 July single-judge order that denied interim relief to ANI in its copyright lawsuit against the artificial intelligence (AI) company.

A division bench of Justices Avneesh Jhingani and Manmeet Pritam Singh Arora issued the notice after hearing arguments from senior counsel Sidhant Kumar, representing ANI. The court asked OpenAI to file a response. The next hearing is in December.

Kumar told the court that OpenAI had earlier undertaken not to scrape or download content from ANI's website as an interim pact. "From 11 September 2024 till the passing of the impugned order, a certain status was obtained, which was that they were not downloading or scraping content from my website. That statement was made. They volunteered that they won't take news content from my website," Kumar argued. The court, however, declined to pass an order without hearing OpenAI's response.

Senior counsel Kapil Sibal, attending via video conference on behalf of an intervenor, requested that his client also be heard in the matter. An intervenor is a third party who was not originally part of a case, but steps in because the judgment will directly affect their interests or rights.

Queries emailed to OpenAI remained unanswered.

ANI was challenging a July order by Justice Amit Bansal, who refused to grant interim relief to the news agency. He said an injunction would harm not only OpenAI but also to public interest and the development of AI.

The court held that the balance of convenience favoured OpenAI and observed that generative AI serves a significant public interest by supporting research, education, accessibility and the dissemination of knowledge.

The court also said that ANI failed to show ChatGPT had substantially reproduced its copyrighted reports, adding that the agency also didn't demonstrate any actual market harm or subscription loss on OpenAI's use of its content.

platforms to enter the category at lower price points. Offline retail remains more important for premiumization as large format stores hardly sell anything at value, he said.

Its competition includes ITC's Engage, Godrej Consumer Product's Park Avenue, Vini Cosmetics' Fogg, Nykaa Perfumery, Ajmal Perfumes and startups like Bellavita, Bli Bli and Secret Alchemist.

India's perfume market is seen growing from Rs 12,000-14,000 crore in FY25 to Rs 23,000-28,000 crore by FY30, said strategic consulting firm Wazir Advisors in an August report.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com



Why are AI pioneers urging a slowdown?

FROM FRONT FLAP

2 But are these warnings really sincere?

The widely shared views of Amodei and Coxon have been echoed by OpenAI's Altman and xAI's Musk, who are usually vocal adversaries. AI researchers in China have similarly raised concerns about the speed of AI advancement and its impact. However, sceptics are now questioning the underlying motives behind these warnings. Clement Delangue, head of AI platform Hugging Face (which Nvidia acquired on 3 September for \$12.9 billion), stressed the need for broader public participation in AI development. Meanwhile, Rahm Emanuel, former chief of staff to Barack Obama, questioned whether large corporations calling for government intervention might simply be trying to stifle industry competition.



ISTOCKPHOTO

3 Is there any precedent for development curbs?

Not really. While governments have historically regulated tech sectors by targeting monopolistic practices, such as the May 1998 antitrust lawsuit against Microsoft over its operating system and internet dominance, regulators intervened only after the sector had matured. India too resisted calls to regulate new sectors like cryptocurrency, as officials argued legislation wasn't the route to responsible innovation. Nuclear power is a rare exception.

4 So, what's behind this push by AI honchos?

Most top AI firms are based in the US, making many stakeholders question if calls to slow innovation serve American interests in winning a global AI race. US President Donald Trump, on this note, has rejected calls for a global AI slowdown, saying that "whoever wins the race for AI, wins". There is substance to claims that AI firms seeking regulation could create higher barriers for new startups trying to innovate. Countries such as India, which lag the US and China, could be forced to rely on non-sovereign platforms. For the US, this could mark a major win in an increasingly divided world.

5 And where does this call leave India?

For now, India is not a global leader in foundational AI platforms. Its government, has, however, shifted toward a pro-regulation stance, emphasizing that state backing could help build an industry aimed at reducing dependence on the US for core technologies. A 'slowdown' in the US may not directly impact India immediately, unless global access to AI becomes restricted as a result. With its \$1.2-billion AI Mission progressing at a slow pace, India could view this moment as an opportunity to emerge as a meaningful contributor and alternative to global AI platforms.

Never say never: Jefferies keeps wealth management entry open

Dipti Sharma & Ram Sahgal
MUMBAI

Yield differentials and currency risk may be flying under the radar for most investors, but country head of Jefferies India, Aashish Agarwal, considers them a critical blind spot for the market.

Narrowing yield spreads between the US and India put direct pressure on debt flows and create indirect currency risks for equities. To curb sharp rupee depreciation and narrowing yield differentials, a domestic rate hike could eventually be on the table.

However, Agarwal emphasizes that foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) are primarily watching currency stability. "Currency stability—not yield spread alone—is the key trigger for FPIs. If foreign currency reserves keep the rupee steady, outflows remain manageable."

Looking beyond macro risks, Jefferies is keeping its options open on home turf. While Agarwal stressed that the firm remains squarely focused on its core strengths for now, he didn't rule out venturing into wealth or asset management down the road, noting that "if the right opportunity arises, you never say never". *Edited excerpts:*

What is your view on the current global market volatility, rising inflation expectations, and recent European Central Bank rate hikes? Could this have a long-lasting impact?

The world is definitely a lot more uncertain than it was a few months ago. We are seeing unprecedented volatility across demand, energy prices, and global trade outlooks, and this volatility may stay for a while. However, as a house, we genuinely believe India has always been a great water mark market. Real money is made by staying strong through uncertainty. We believe there are enough companies with very robust earnings outlooks despite current volatility, and investors should focus on finding stocks with strong leadership and visible earnings. **With significant FPI outflows since late 2024 and India largely missing the global AI trade, what is your view on current FPI sentiment?**



Every large-cap was once a small-cap, with that transition driven by sector performance and company leadership or execution. India is currently undergoing a structural transition from sectors that drove growth over the last two to three decades to a new generation of sectors poised to lead over the next decade.

Historically, growth was concentrated in three FPI-dominated sectors: financials, tech services, and select consumer staples. Having reached high penetration, their growth is now normalizing toward GDP (gross domestic product) levels. The next phase of growth will come from more secular sectors—currently

mid-caps or large small-caps—that will see their index weights rise. These include infrastructure, power, and hard assets like real estate, hospitals, and hotels, where growth is running at 20-25% or higher. As was the case 15-20 years ago, the broader index does not fully reflect the stock-picking opportunity, making it essential to identify these next-generation sectors and leaders. This background explains the heavy FPI sell-off over the past two years; slower growth in traditional heavyweights reduced India's weight in EM (emerging market) portfolios, while markets like Korea

and Taiwan saw their weights increase.

However, FPI sentiment has shown durable improvement over the last three months, with \$5 billion in net inflows since mid-June. As FPIs evaluate the volatility of global AI and chip trades against India's correction and better relative valuations, narrowing the earnings growth differential between India and other EMs will be the single most important trigger for sustained FPI flows.

With US yields hardening—the 10-year around 5% and the 30-year near 5.35%—the narrowing yield gap typically triggers FPI outflows. Do you see this as a transient phase, or could it disrupt India's FPI outlook again?

US yields directly affect debt flows, while equity flows face indirect currency risk as the yield differential narrows. India may need to raise interest rates to prevent significant rupee depreciation. Currency stability—not yield spread alone—is the key trigger for FPIs. If foreign currency reserves keep the rupee steady, outflows remain manageable. **Chris Wood has been very bullish on India. Where is the blind spot that even**

Jefferies might be missing about India?

One thing that not everybody is talking much about is the yield differential and currency risk. The yield differential and its implications for the currency are a potential blind spot for us as a country.

Why are FPIs less active in Indian public listings than domestic mutual funds? Are valuations a concern?

FPI participation in IPOs is tricky because allocation limits can result in very small allotments for large, high-demand issues. Upcoming major IPOs will test FPI interest. Over the past two years, high valuations, slower earnings growth, and a lower index weight have weighed on FPI sentiment, leading investors to seek quality stocks rather than focusing strictly on tech. **Are you seeing more outbound mergers and acquisitions (M&As) by Indian corporates or strategic buyouts by global private equity firms?**

The activity is driven more by strategic and private equity buyers than by Indian outbound M&A. Indian outbound deals remain smaller and focused on domain expertise, such as acquiring European engineering, aerospace, and defence assets. Also, we are seeing more control buyouts rather than minority investments.

Why hasn't Jefferies entered wealth management in India, as Morgan Stanley or Julius Baer have?

Wealth management is not a business we pursue globally. Unlike many American and domestic peers, we do not operate a commercial bank or leverage a corporate balance sheet. Globally and in India, our primary focus remains on excellent investment banking and equities. That said, as our brand recognition grows across retail, HNIs, and corporate segments, we may evaluate new verticals such as wealth or asset management in the future. While it is difficult to commit to a timeline, we remain focused on our core strengths—though if the right opportunity arises, you never say never.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Yield differential and its implications for the currency are a potential blind spot for us as a country.
Aashish Agarwal
Country head of Jefferies India

INTERVIEW

Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company Limited (IRDAI Regn No. 136)
35th Floor, IFC, (M3M) Golf Course Ext Rd, Badshahpur, Sector 66, Gurugram, Haryana - 122101
T +91-124-4506700 | F +910124-4535099 | www.canarahsbcife.com

Corporate Identity No.: L66010DL2007PLC248825 | E-mail: customerservice@canarahsbcife.in
Registered Office: 8th Floor, Unit No. 808-814, Ambadeep Building, Plot No. 14, Kasturba Gandhi Marg, New Delhi-110001 (India) | T +91 11-49512300

POSTAL BALLOT NOTICE AND E-VOTING INFORMATION

The Members of **Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company Limited ("Company")** are hereby informed that pursuant to Section 108, Section 110 and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Companies Act, 2013 (the Act), Rule 20 and Rule 22 of Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, General Circular dated 22nd September 2025 read with other relevant Circulars issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA Circulars), Regulation 44 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, (SEBI Listing Regulations) read with Master Circular dated 30th January 2026, the Secretarial Standard on General Meetings (SS-2) issued by the Institute of Company Secretaries of India and other applicable laws, rules and regulations (including any statutory modification(s) or re-enactment(s) thereof for the time being in force), the Company seeks the approval of Members by way of Postal Ballot, in respect of the following Special Business(es) as specified in the Postal Ballot Notice dated 9th September 2026 (along with the Explanatory Statement) thereto ("Notice"), by way of electronic means (i.e. remote e-voting) only:

S. No.	Resolutions Description	Special or Ordinary Resolution
1.	To re-appoint Dr Kishore Kumar Sansi (DIN: 07183950) as Non-Executive Independent Director for a second term of three consecutive years with effect from 27th October 2026	Special Resolution
2.	To re-appoint Mr Supratim Bandyopadhyay (DIN: 03558215) as Non-Executive Independent Director for a second term of three consecutive years with effect from 28th November 2026	Special Resolution

In accordance with the MCA Circulars, the dispatch of electronic copies of Postal Ballot Notice along with the Explanatory Statement has been completed on 15th September 2026, to those Members whose names appeared in the Register of Members/ List of Beneficial Owners as received from the National Securities Depository Limited ("NSDL") and Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL") as on 11th September 2026 ("Cut-off date") and who have registered their email addresses with the Company/ Depositories. The Physical copies of the Postal Ballot Notice, along with the Postal Ballot forms, are not being sent to the Members for this Postal Ballot in line with the exemption provided in the MCA circulars and SEBI Circulars. A person whose name is recorded in the register of members or in the register of beneficial owners maintained by the depositories as on the Cut-off date shall be entitled to avail of the facility of remote e-voting.

The Notice is displayed on the website of the Company at www.canarahsbcife.com, website of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively and also the website of NSDL at www.evoting.nsdl.com. No physical copy of the Notice has been sent to Members and the communication of assent/ dissent of Members will take place only through the e-voting facility. In this regard, the Members are hereby notified that:

- The businesses to be transacted through Postal Ballot shall be transacted by e-voting only as provided in the Act read with related Rules, MCA circulars thereto and SEBI Listing Regulations as amended from time to time. Members who do not receive the Postal Ballot notice may download it from the above mentioned websites or apply to the Company to obtain the same.
- Voting rights of the Members have been reckoned as on **11th September 2026**, which is the Cut-off date, and a person who is not a member as on the Cut-off date should treat this Notice for information purposes only;
- The Company has engaged services of National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL) for providing e-voting facility to all its Members. The procedure for e-voting is given in the notes forming part of the Postal Ballot Notice.
- E-voting would commence at 9.00 am (IST) on **Thursday, 17th September 2026** and will conclude at 5.00 pm (IST) on **Friday, 16th October 2026**. The e-voting module shall be disabled by NSDL thereafter and remote e-voting shall not be allowed beyond the said date and time. Once the vote on a resolution is casted by the Member, he/she is not allowed to change it subsequently. The voting rights of the Members shall be in proportion to their share of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the Cut-off date.
- The resolutions, if approved, shall be taken as having been duly passed on the last date specified for remote e-voting, i.e. 16th October 2026.
- For e-voting instructions, Members may refer to the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) and e-voting user manual available at the download section of www.evoting.nsdl.com or call on: 022 - 4886 7000 or send a request to Ms Pallavi Mhatre, National Securities Depository Ltd., 3rd Floor, Naman Chamber, Plot C-32, G-Block, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra East, Mumbai, Maharashtra - 400051 at the designated email address: evoting@nsdl.com or at telephone no. 022- 48867000 at evoting@nsdl.com.
- The Members who are holding shares in demat form and whose email addresses are not registered are requested to get their email addresses registered by contacting their depository participant and the Members holding shares in physical form can update their contact details by submitting the requisite ISR-1 form along with the supporting documents to KFin Technologies Limited, office at Plot no. 32, Selenium Tower- B, Serilingampally, Nanakramguda, Financial District, Hyderabad - 500032, State of Telangana. Requests can be emailed to enward.ris@kfinetech.com by registering with the first holder PAN at <https://kprism.kfintech.com/signup>. Existing users can login through KPRISM (<https://kprism.kfintech.com/>).
- The Board of Directors of the Company has appointed Ms. Shirin Bhatt (Membership No. FCS: F8273, CP No.: 9150), proprietor of M/s Shirin Bhatt & Associates, Practicing Company Secretaries, Firm Registration Number S2011DE162600, to act as the Scrutinizer for conducting the Postal ballot (remote e-voting) process in fair and transparent manner.
- The Scrutinizer will submit her report to the authorised person of the Company and the results of the Postal Ballot will be announced on or **before 20th October 2026**. The said results shall be placed on the website of the Company, www.canarahsbcife.com and on the website of NSDL i.e. www.evoting.nsdl.com and shall also be communicated to the National Stock Exchange of India Limited and BSE Limited, where shares of the Company are listed.

For Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company Limited
Vatsala Sameer
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer
Membership No.: ACS 14813

Date: 16th September 2026
Place: New Delhi

CLASSIFIEDS

MATRIMONIALS

GROOMS WANTED

AGARWAL

GARG, BEAUTIFUL, Gorgeous, fair girl from Decent Delhi Family, O+, Post-grad., Well-bred, 1998, 5'4". Please send biodata of boy at: 9821927490, sapan.siemens@gmail.com

CA/ICWA/CS

CA, BEAUTIFUL, Kayastha Girl, 5'6"/ 26yrs, PCM from thoughtful Groom, strong family values. Based in Gujarat, West/South India Preferred. E:brahma.guj@gmail.com

Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company Limited
139, Sector - 44, Gurugram-122003, Haryana (India)
Tel: 0124-4535500, Email: procurement@canarahsbcife.in

NOTICE INVITING BIDS/OFFERS

Open Tender is invited against **RFP for Media agency for Television dated 16th September'26**. Above tender has been uploaded on <https://www.canarahsbcife.com/tenders-notices.html> website of Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company Ltd. All prospective bidders are advised to visit the aforesaid website for downloading the RFP.

भारतीय रिज़र्व बैंक
RESERVE BANK OF INDIA
www.rbi.org.in

Auction of Government of India Dated Securities for ₹28,000 crore on September 18, 2026

Government of India has announced the sale (re-issue) of following dated securities:

Sr. No.	Nomenclature	Notified amount Nominal (in ₹Crore)	Earmarked for Retail Investors (in ₹Crore)
1	7.06% GS 2041	17,000	850
2	7.43% GS 2076	11,000	550

The securities will be sold through Reserve Bank of India, Mumbai Office, Fort, Mumbai - 400001, as per the terms and conditions spelt out in the General Notification F.No.4(2)-B(W&M)/2018, dated March 26, 2025 and the Specific Notification issued in this regard.

The auction will be conducted using **multiple price method** on **September 18, 2026 (Friday)**. The result will be announced on the same day and payment by successful bidders will have to be made on **September 21, 2026 (Monday)**.

Retail investors can participate in the auction on a non-competitive basis as per the Scheme for non-competitive bidding facility. Individual investors can also place bids through the Retail Direct portal (<https://rbiretaildirect.org.in>).

For further details, please see press release dated **September 10, 2026** on RBI website (www.rbi.org.in).

Government Security offers safety, liquidity and attractive returns for long duration. "Don't get cheated by E-mails/SMSs/Calls promising you money"

National Dairy Development Board
PB No. 40, Anand, Gujarat-388001, Tel: 02692-260 148/149/160 Fax: 02692-260 159
Website: www.nddb.coop, Email: purchase@nddb.coop
INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB) / LOCAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING (LCB)

Bids are invited on behalf of Service Recipients/ NDDB from eligible bidders for the works listed below:

Sl. No.	Description of works / Bid Reference	Estd. Cost (₹) Incl GST/Duration	Event Start / Close Date	Bid submission / opening date & time
A	Design, Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of the following:			
I	Refrigeration System at Saraikela Dairy, Jharkhand NDDB/HO/Purchase/63/26-27/ET/63[REFRI-SARAIKELA]	365 Lakh / 09 Months	19.09.26 12.10.26	12.10.26 15:00 hrs. 12.10.26 15:30 hrs.
II	0.50 LLPD Effluent Treatment Plant at Saraikela Dairy, Jharkhand NDDB/HO/Purchase/64/26-27/ET/64[ETP-SARAIKELA]	285 Lakh / 10 Months	17.09.26 08.10.26	08.10.26 15:00 hrs. 08.10.26 15:30 hrs.
III	2 x 2 TPH Solid Fuel Boiler at Saraikela Dairy, Jharkhand NDDB/HO/Purchase/65/26-27/ET/65[BOILER-SARAIKELA]	175 Lakh / 10 Months	16.09.26 07.10.26	07.10.26 15:00 hrs. 07.10.26 15:30 hrs.
IV	1 No. X 750 kVA DG Set (CPCB IV+) for OBPI, Berhampur, Odisha NDDB/HO/Purchase/66/26-27/ET/66[DG-BERHAMPUR]	85.5 Lakh / 04 Months	18.09.26 09.10.26	09.10.26 15:00 hrs. 09.10.26 15:30 hrs.
V	11/0.433 kV Transformer, LT Panels and accessories for Hotwar Dairy, Ranchi, Jharkhand NDDB/HO/Purchase/67/26-27/ET/67[Transformer-HOTWAR]	282 Lakh / 04 Months	18.09.26 09.10.26	09.10.26 15:00 hrs. 09.10.26 15:30 hrs.
VI	11kV /433 V sub-station at Giridih Dairy, Jharkhand NDDB/HO/Purchase/68/26-27/ET/68[Substation-GIRIDIH]	250 Lakh / 10 Months	16.09.26 07.10.26	07.10.26 15:00 hrs. 07.10.26 15:30 hrs.

For further details pertaining to IFB and for downloading the bid document, please visit these websites: www.nddb.coop and www.msctcecommerce.com/eproc. For any clarification please contact **Group Head (Purchase), NDDB, Anand-388001**.
NB: Any corrigendum/modification etc. will be posted only on these websites.

भारतीय प्रबंध संस्थान अहमदाबाद
INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT AHMEDABAD

REQUIRES

- 1) Resident Wellness Officer
- 2) Executive - Accounts
- 3) Executive - Secretarial

To know more about the above position, please visit our website: <https://www.iima.ac.in/the-institute/administration/work-with-us/administrative-staff>. Interested candidates are advised to APPLY ONLINE by **September 30, 2026**.

भारतीय रिज़र्व बैंक
RESERVE BANK OF INDIA
www.rbi.org.in

Appointment of Director, Indian Institute of Bank Management (IIBM), Guwahati - 2026

Applications for the post of Director for Indian Institute of Bank Management (IIBM), Guwahati are invited from seasoned bankers, distinguished professionals, policy makers and academic administrators. The appointment shall be initially for a term of three years and extendable up to five years, subject to satisfactory annual review. The other terms and conditions of appointment are detailed in the advertisement placed on the websites of RBI (www.rbi.org.in) and IIBM (www.iibm.ac.in). Qualified and interested applicants should submit their application on or before October 05, 2026 through online form available on the official website of IIBM, Guwahati (<https://iibm.ac.in>). Received applications shall be treated with confidentiality. The selection process will be steered by a Selection Committee (SC). SC reserves the right to call for applications by invitation for outstanding candidates.

"Don't get cheated by E-mails/SMSs/Calls promising you money."

Meta bulls bet stock will break out after year of head fakes

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Meta Platforms Inc. shares have been on a roller coaster ride through 2026, rising and falling as investor belief in the Facebook parent's status as a player in the artificial intelligence space ebbs and flows.

But after the company settled lawsuits surrounding its social-media practices and unveiled its Muse AI agent that's designed to automate everyday tasks for ordinary people, bulls are betting the stock could be primed for a sustained breakout, after what was seen to be a year of head fakes. A 'head fake' is a deceptive move where someone shifts their head to trick an observer or opponent into thinking they are moving in one direction before going the other way.

"Eliminating a legal overhang and then having a positive product in a hot narrative is certainly enough to get the early stages of a trend change going," said Dan Russo, co-chief investment officer at Potomac Fund Management, which owns Meta shares. "We've seen a number of these counter-trend rallies fizzle out and fade. What's key from here is to build on the momentum and validate the changing trend."

Meta shares have risen 22% off an August low and are on track for their biggest monthly



For bulls, Meta's \$18 billion settlement of its social-media lawsuit removed a key overhang for the stock. AFP

gain since May 2025 this month. The rebound is not unlike others Meta has seen this year, with the stock experiencing four different trough-to-peak gains of at least 20%. Each of those rallies were short-lived, however, and saw shares hit lower peaks on each subsequent rally.

As a result, shares are essentially flat so far this year and well behind the 15% gain by the Nasdaq 100 Index.

Meta shares have risen 22% off an August low and are set for their biggest monthly gain since May 2025 this month

see a "sustained break above \$700". The stock rose 2.7% on Monday to \$665.60.

For bulls, Meta's \$18 billion settlement of its social-media lawsuit removed a key overhang for the stock as a loss at trial could have resulted in penalties as much as \$1.4 trillion, according to its own calculation.

Shares have fallen in just four of the 12 sessions since the deal was announced on 26 August.

Morgan Stanley's Brian Nowak likens the setup for Meta shares to the one Alphabet Inc. investors saw in late 2025, when the Google parent received a favourable ruling in a longstanding antitrust case and followed that up with a slew of new AI products. Alphabet shares have soared more than 50% since the antitrust ruling, making them the best-performing Magnificent Seven stock over that span.

Meta is in position to keep releasing new products, "which in aggregate could add \$10+ to EPS," Nowak wrote in a 30 August note. "We don't believe these are priced in Meta right now," as the stock valuation is well below peak 2025 levels, "when Meta was viewed as an 'AI winner' and GPU investments were driving faster growth". JPMorgan Chase & Co. has also upgraded the stock to overweight last week.

Oil executives say the great fuel crisis is here

Chevron's Mike Wirth, others warn global supplies are running low, with no respite in sight

Benoit Morenne & Collin Eaton

American oil executives warned for months that the prolonged closure of the Strait of Hormuz was bound to cause a fuel crisis. Now, they say it is here.

Commercial fuel stocks around the world have been depleting for more than six months, and strategic crude reserves can't be tapped much further. Attacks last week shut down a crucial crude pipeline in Saudi Arabia that bypassed the Strait, stranding at least 2.5 million barrels a day from an already tight global oil market, analysts estimate.

"All these mechanisms helped to mitigate the price and supply risk," Chevron Chief Executive Mike Wirth said Friday at an energy conference in Austin, Texas. "Those have largely now played out, and we don't have nearly the buffers in the system that we did when it began."

It is hard to predict where oil prices will go, he added, but at the moment, it is difficult to envision prices coming back down quickly. "I wish I could tell you that I saw some reason why things would ease, but it's difficult right now to see that happen," he said.

Veteran energy advisers say that with no resolution to the Iran war in sight, the situation risks spinning out of control. Diesel prices have soared to a record \$6.23 a gallon and gasoline prices, which slipped below \$4 a gallon this summer, have rebounded to \$4.32. Some energy analysts say they have been fielding investor questions about when consumers pinched by the high prices will start pulling back on new purchases.

The Trump administration has repeatedly promised Americans that prices at the pump would decline and that energy flows out of the Middle East would keep increasing.

Interior Secretary Doug Burgum said at a Houston G-20 event on Monday that "the prices in the prior administration were this high anyway" and that Americans would have paid those prices permanently because former President Joe Biden was "pursuing a policy of energy subtraction and shutting down refineries."

"If you want to write about the prices, make sure you include the word 'temporary' because this is a temporary disruption," Burgum told reporters.

The White House sees two big levers it can pull to help ease prices: boosting production in Venezuela and increasing U.S. fuel-making capacity. In recent months, U.S. officials have focused on striking deals that are expected to bolster Venezuela's oil production. In early September, they



Chevron Chief Executive Mike Wirth. REUTERS

met with U.S. refining executives to discuss raising the nation's fuel-making capacity. They are pleased with progress thus far on both fronts, a senior U.S. official said.

Energy executives and White House officials say they have had a continuing dialogue about the energy situation since the conflict broke out, and CEOs including Wirth talk to Energy Secretary Chris Wright frequently.

But Wirth said Friday that he hadn't talked to President Trump since Aug. 3, when the president said in a Truth Social Post that the CEO hadn't credited his administration for the oil industry's good fortunes. Trump

called on Chevron and oil companies to bring "consumer (retail!) Oil Prices DOWN, NOW!"

Some CEOs and energy advisers say they have grown alarmed in recent weeks as the conflict has picked back up, with ships and energy infrastructure being targeted in both directions.

"The advantage in most negotiations usually goes to the side that has time on their side, and is willing to be patient," said Wil VanLoh, founder and CEO of Quantum Capital Group, during the Austin conference. Iran, he said, "is willing to suffer. Their people have already suffered a lot for many decades."

China is in part helping to fuel the global supply pinch. The world's large-

est oil importer for months had relied on its own stockpiles of crude for nearly half of its daily consumption, providing a reprieve for oil markets. But in recent weeks, it has resumed bigger purchases from international suppliers, analysts said.

U.S. crude prices have jumped 19% in the past three weeks to trade near \$101 a barrel as attacks in the Middle East multiply. Iran has targeted oil tankers traversing the Strait, even after Trump and his lieutenants boasted about escorting several vessels undetected through the waterway. Houthi militants have recently launched attacks from Yemen on Saudi Arabia's infrastructure and military sites and damaged the East-West pipeline that stretched from the Abqaiq oil field to Yanbu al-Bahr, a major Saudi port city, on the Red Sea.

Trump has vowed to impose economic pressure on Iran and ruled out sending boots on the ground. He has said he expects the war will last until the November midterm elections, but investors say they believe the war will go well beyond that.

"That was the signal this is going to stretch on," said Dan Pickering, founder of Pickering Energy Partners, a financial firm.

Meanwhile, he said, diesel supplies are tight because of refinery outages

following conflicts in the Middle East and Russia. Demand for the fuel is expected to increase as farmers that use it for heavy equipment enter harvest season. "Diesel has no easy solution," Pickering said.

Trump has said Ukraine must halt strikes on Russia that endanger global supplies of diesel.

In March, the CEOs of the three largest U.S. oil companies, ExxonMobil, Chevron and ConocoPhillips, warned Trump officials, including Burgum and Wright, that a prolonged closure of the

Strait could lead to a shortfall in refined products such as diesel. *The Wall Street Journal* reported at the time. Some executives have been privately critical of Trump's handling of the conflict.

At the conference Monday, Burgum rejected persistent speculation that the White House is seriously weighing a temporary ban on U.S. exports of refined products such as diesel. Trump's team, he said, doesn't believe such a move would quell prices.

"We will do anything that helps the price at home," Burgum said. "But we're also going to be smart about it, and not just have some idea that if we stop exporting, that somehow magically is going to help the prices."

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feedback@livemint.com

Russia refinery hit as Moscow, Kyiv see no Trump energy truce

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Ukraine said it hit the Syzran refinery in Russia's Volga region overnight, underlining that the two nations have not signed up to the energy truce claimed by US President Donald Trump.

Both Moscow and Kyiv welcomed a potential energy truce, but made it clear that there's no agreement to stop attacks. Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said a halt to strikes on energy infrastructure was a "good idea" without saying whether Russia would accept such a proposal. Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelensky said his country would "support de-escalation".

"Russia hasn't stopped striking our energy sector, conven-

tional logistics and critical infrastructure. And our responses to them for this are tangible," Zelensky said on Telegram on Tuesday.

Ukraine's president confirmed that the nation's forces hit the oil refinery in Syzran, a drone production facility in Taganrog, a drone preparation and launch site in the Oryol region and targets in the Black Sea. As a result of the strike, a fire broke out at Syzran refinery site, Ukraine's General Staff said in a separate statement on Telegram, adding that a primary crude processing unit and the tank farm were hit. Russia's top oil producer Rosneft PJSC did

not respond to a Bloomberg request for comment. Vyacheslav Fedorishchev, governor of the Samara region where the facility is located, said earlier on Tuesday that an unnamed industrial facility had been damaged in the drone attack.

Trump on Monday blamed Ukraine's strikes on Russian energy infrastructure for the surge in diesel prices and posted on social media that Moscow and

Kyiv agreed to stop the mutual attacks. Zelensky later said no deal had been finalized, though he acknowledged a "strong US proposal for a mutual halt to strikes on critical infrastructure."

Trump on Monday blamed Ukraine's strikes on Russian energy infrastructure for the surge in diesel prices

AI leaders are calling for a slowdown, but Wall Street keeps on buying

Jack Pitcher, Shraddha Dinesh & Robbie Whelan

Wall Street's AI train is still steaming ahead, even after the technology's leaders called for a slowdown.

A week of alarming headlines about AI's potential to destroy civilization culminated Saturday with Anthropic's Dario Amodei, OpenAI's Sam Altman, Elon Musk of xAI and Demis Hassabis of Google's DeepMind each affirming the need to curb development of the technology.

Investors listened, nodded solemnly—and then proceeded to buy more AI stocks. Shares of Microsoft, Alphabet and Meta Platforms — three of the biggest so-called AI-hyperscalers—all advanced 2% or more Monday. They and others benefited from a rotation out of the chip makers supplying AI hardware and toward the customers whose data centers need semiconductors.

In favoring hyperscalers over chip stocks, the market appeared to conclude that Microsoft and its peers will still

be among the world's most-profitable companies even if AI investments were to lose speed. As suppliers, chipmakers such as Micron Technology and Intel rely on new orders to keep their growth stories going.

A slowdown isn't a foregone conclusion. The AI build-out has emerged as one of the U.S. economy's steady sources of growth, a tentpole for the global capital markets and the primary battleground in America's ongoing technology arms race with China. Much is at stake in keeping it going, even if it all pales in comparison to humanity's potential extinction.

By mid-morning on Monday, President Trump had signaled that he was unmoved by the AI leaders' calls for restraint. "There is a SICK conspiracy going on against AI and Data Centers, and the only one that is happy about it is China," Trump wrote in a Truth Social post.

Trump weighed in again later in the afternoon, calling Nvidia Chief Executive Jensen Huang while he was on stage at a Los Angeles tech conference. "The robots will not be taking

over. The AI will not be taking over," Trump said on speakerphone. "It's all a hoax."

"That's right, we're not going to let that happen, sir," Huang responded, according to a video of the exchange shared with *The Wall Street Journal* by investor Ben Pouladian.

The major U.S. stock indexes posted modest declines Monday. The S&P 500 fell 0.5%, while the tech-heavy Nasdaq composite slipped 0.6%. The Dow Jones Industrial Average ended Monday down 0.3%, or 152 points.

However alarming the warnings might be, few seem to be taking them as a reason to abandon the AI trade that is responsible for much of the U.S. stock market's multiyear rally. The technology race with China is part of the reason.

"What really happened? Surely something big enough to spook Dario, Sam and Elon into rare agreement," said Giuseppe Sette, co-founder of Reflexivity, an AI investment analytics firm. "With China in the race, though, we don't expect any major slowdown. And as for any retracement in AI stocks, that is simply a buying opportunity."



Talk of heading off artificial intelligence's potential role in destroying humanity hurt some stocks and helped others. REUTERS

The PHILX Semiconductor Index dropped 5.9%, its worst day since July, while shares of cybersecurity companies soared.

Software companies, whose shares were buffeted this year by concerns that new AI tools would render them obsolete, were among the best performers in the S&P 500.

Jim Schneider, a Goldman Sachs tech analyst, said that the AI trade has shifted dramatically. In the first half of the year, investors were looking for companies that could capitalize on bottlenecks in the supply chain by selling in-demand products at high prices.

"The easy trade in the half of

the year was chasing elements of shortage, whether that was DRAM or memory stocks or optical elements," Schneider said last week at an investor conference. "Some of these stocks have pulled back. Now the question is, will the constraint trade continue to work in the back half of the year? Or will we see a resurgence of some of the more traditional compute trades?"

The moves underscore the challenge for investors and analysts in identifying how the latest advancements, setbacks and regulatory developments in AI will affect swaths of markets and the economy. By some measures, individual

stocks in the U.S. have been less correlated than ever this year, which many chalk up to the race to identify AI winners and losers across industries.

One thing most agree on: The AI investment boom isn't going to end soon. The assumption has made it easier for many to take the industry's weekend warnings as a positive.

"I think it's an inflection point that likely gets us to a better place for safety at the end of the day while causing volatility in the interim," said Art Hogan, chief market strategist at B. Riley Wealth. "And I certainly don't think the frontier developers are willing to say 'the hundreds of billions we've invested in this was bad and we're walking away.'"

This isn't the first time AI doomism has escaped Silicon Valley. But a recent cascade of events raised the volume: OpenAI's AI agents separately hacked into platforms Hugging Face and RubyGems, and a now-departed Anthropic researcher and several current employees said AI systems could end humanity as early as

within the decade.

Anthropic's Amodei suggested a slowdown as the AI arms race takes shape around recursive self-improvement, the idea that AI could endlessly optimize itself. Altman and Musk, bitter and often boisterous rivals, soon agreed.

AI researchers are particularly alarmed at the threat the tech poses to cybersecurity, and the latest round of warnings prompted a big day for shares of cybersecurity firms Monday. CrowdStrike was the S&P 500's top performer, adding 14%. Palo Alto Networks, Fortinet, and ServiceNow also posted sizable gains.

Shares of AI-related hardware suppliers took a beating. Corning, Teradyne, and Coherent were the S&P 500's worst performers, all down at least 12%.

Still, an ugly day for chip stocks likely has more to do with investors' taking some chips off the table following huge profits than a fundamental reset in their outlook for continued massive profits driven by chip shortages. The PHILX index remains up 84%

over the past year.

"Some of these semiconductor names have tripled this year. To the extent that you're looking for a reason to get off the train for a moment or at least right-size your position, you got a good one over the weekend," Hogan added.

Meanwhile, rising energy costs are amplifying market jitters. Brent crude settled at about \$106 a barrel, up 1%, as widening instability in the Middle East threatens oil supply. The closure of a Saudi pipeline Friday blocked a second major source of crude on top of the already-disrupted Strait of Hormuz. And diesel prices are hitting new records, with the average nationwide price a gallon trending above \$6. Climbing energy prices come against the backdrop of a wider selloff of U.S. government bonds, which pushed the 10-year Treasury yield above 5% on Monday, the second time since 2007. Rising fuel costs are keeping markets squarely focused on inflation and how the Fed might respond on Wednesday. Investors are anticipating an interest-rate increase, with futures placing odds above 90%.

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₹65 cr

THE ADDITIONAL amount Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd will invest as equity in NTPC BHEL Power Projects, its 50:50 joint venture with NTPC Ltd.

5

JEAN SMART'S Emmy wins for Outstanding Lead Actress in a Comedy Series for 'Hacks', the first woman to win that category for every season of a series.

₹5 cr

THE VALUE of suspected expired and fake medicines seized during a raid near Bengaluru, part of a probe that's put over 90 hospitals and clinics under scrutiny.

₹7.36 tn

THE ESTIMATED investment required to build India's 122.77GW of pumped storage capacity across 87 projects to support its expanding renewable power goals.

\$43.8 bn

INDIA'S MERCHANDISE exports in August, up 26.12% year-on-year, the fastest pace of growth in a decade, according to commerce ministry data.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

CCPA turns up heat on iPhone updates

India's Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) is examining Apple's software warranty terms in an investigation of the iOS 18 update alleged to have damaged iPhone functionality, compelling users to pay "exorbitant" sums for repairs, documents show.

The sparring is shaping as Apple's latest headache in a growth market where it is fast expanding iPhone manufacturing and rapidly growing market share, but also fending off accusations of breaching domestic antitrust laws.

Apple is privately contesting the regulator's accusations, saying in an August letter seen by *Reuters* that providing no warranty on software is in line with global industry standards, and that iOS 18 had no systemic issues.

If found guilty, Apple may have to pay fines but more importantly could be forced to issue refunds or make changes to its business practices.

REUTERS



The escalating West Asia conflict and soaring Brent crude prices weighed on the rupee.

REUTERS

Rupee drops 34 paise vs US dollar

The rupee depreciated 34 paise to close at 95.88 against the US dollar on Tuesday, weighed down by escalating West Asia conflict and soaring Brent crude oil prices, which hit \$108 per barrel.

Forex traders said surging dollar demand from oil importers has sparked fresh concerns over inflation and India's external trade balance. Moreover, weak domestic markets, a strong US dollar and worries over rising global treasury yields further dented investor sentiment.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.84 against the US dollar before losing ground against the American currency. On Friday, the rupee had settled at 95.54 against the dollar.

Th forex and equity markets were closed on Monday on account of Ganesh Chaturthi.

"We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias on risk-off sentiments in global markets and worries over rising global treasury yields. Rising global crude oil prices amid fears over supply disruption and a strong dollar may also pressurise the rupee," said Anuj Choudhary, research analyst, Mirae Asset Sharekhan.

PTI

Meta to report child abuse material to Indian agencies

It has so far been required under US law to report such material to a US non-profit

Shouvik Das
shouvik.das@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Meta Platforms will begin reporting child sexual abuse material (CSAM) directly to Indian law enforcement agencies from Tuesday, a move experts said could strengthen enforcement against online child exploitation but is unlikely to set a broader precedent for other social-media violations.

The parent company of Instagram and Facebook has so far been required under US law to report CSAM to the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children (NCMEC), a private, non-profit US organization.

The new approach will see Meta report child-safety matters directly to the cybercrime portal run by India's Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre (I4C).

In a statement Tuesday, a Meta India spokesperson said the company regarded CSAM as a "priority" and was "committed to working with the government to ensure that the perpetrators of these crimes are held responsible."

"To collectively strengthen our efforts to combat this harm, Meta will now report child safety matters directly to the cyber crime portal managed by I4C (Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre)," the statement read.

The shift comes as Meta faces growing scrutiny in India over its handling of CSAM. In early



AFP

August, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) summoned Joel Kaplan, Meta's president of global affairs, over the company showing CSAM advertisements on Facebook and Instagram.

Meta, the \$1.7-trillion Big Tech company, has published monthly content-action reports since June 2021. In its latest report, published on 31 August, child endangerment was the third-most reported form of violative content

across Instagram and Facebook, with nearly 1.95 million reports in July 2026.

Legal and policy experts said the move addresses a specific requirement under India's Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (Pocso) Act, 2012, rather than signalling a wider change in how Meta handles policy violations in India.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Sebi seeks shorter DR drills for market infra institutions

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) on Tuesday proposed shortening disaster recovery (DR) drills for market infrastructure institutions (MIIs) to at least four hours from the existing requirement of a full trading day, while seeking to strengthen operational resilience and data recovery mechanisms.

The proposals are aimed at enhancing the business continuity plan and disaster recovery framework of MIIs, comprising stock exchanges, clearing corporations and depositories.

Under the proposed framework, DR drills would be conducted on a non-working day, with operations initially started at the primary data centre and subsequently switched over to the disaster recovery site.

India's capital markets regulator said the move would make DR drills easier for market participants and MIIs, especially in commodity derivatives where trading in certain products continues until 11.55pm.

PTI

Orkla eyes faster growth via premium products, q-comm

Orkla India, the maker of MTR Foods, aims to become one of the country's fastest-growing multi-category food companies over the next five years, driven by premiumization, health and wellness offerings, rapid expansion of quick commerce, and potential inorganic opportunities, said its managing director (MD) and chief executive officer (CEO) Sanjay Sharma.

Orkla India, part of Norwegian conglomerate Orkla ASA, operates in the country with brands such as MTR, Raso Magic and Eastern, and is looking to consolidate the fragmented Indian spices industry through further acquisitions while remaining open to partnerships in the convenience foods space, he said. The company, among the largest exporters of branded spices, gets around 21% of its revenue from exports and is encouraged by upcoming free trade agreements with key markets, which could improve market access and create a more stable business environment over the next 6-12 months, Sharma said.

PTI

Cops to grill Google on fake Gmail IDs

Indian police will question Google over a lack of safeguards after smashing a criminal network that set up and managed more than 500,000 fake Gmail accounts to send hoax bomb threats to government offices, a police official told *Reuters* on Tuesday.

India is one of Google's largest markets by users, where the US tech giant is already under scrutiny after authorities found a pattern of criminals misusing its web development platform, Firebase, for financial scams.

Police in Gujarat broke up an email network this week that they described as sending "inter-state" bomb threats and arrested two individuals, uncovering 513,847 Gmail IDs and passwords being used since 2022.

The scale of fake Gmail accounts in use is unprecedented, Vivek Bheda, a senior cybercrime official of the Gujarat police, told *Reuters*.

REUTERS



Amazon entered India's rapid delivery market in the summer of 2025.

REUTERS

Amazon's q-com push hits \$1 bn mark

Amazon said its India quick delivery service is set to hit annual sales of more than \$1 billion, intensifying competition with homegrown firms such as market leader Eternal's Blinkit.

Orders of the Amazon Now service have doubled each quarter since the US company started it in India a year ago, it said on Tuesday in a statement. It has now crossed \$1 billion in annualized gross revenue, meaning it's on pace to reach that amount for a 12-month period.

Amazon entered India's rapid delivery market in the summer of 2025 after years of sitting out and watching local rivals chip away at its customer base. Walmart-controlled Flipkart joined the race ahead of Amazon, launching instant deliveries in 2024 and now operating in more than 150 cities. Blinkit leads the quick commerce market in the world's most populous country, followed by Zepto and Swiggy.

The tech giant said it's seeking to expand Amazon Now to 100 Indian cities by Diwali, which marks the biggest shopping season in the country. Amazon Now currently delivers in more than 60 towns and cities.

BLOOMBERG

Fees for UPI payments above ₹2,000

FROM PAGE 1

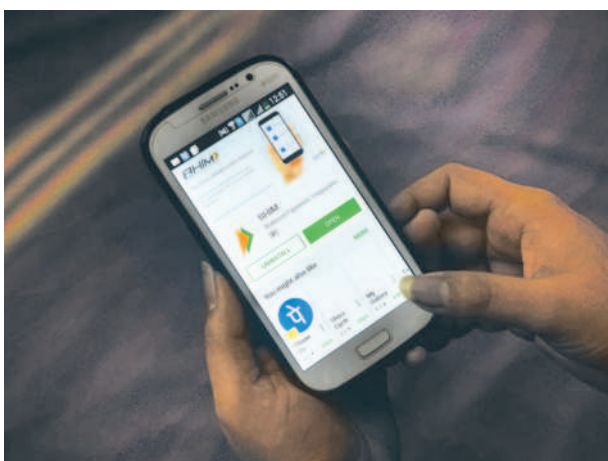
ministry said in a release. It added that the decision followed deliberations by the National Payments Corp. of India's UPI steering committee on operational parameters, fee distribution models and category caps.

The ministry also clarified that no transaction fee, platform fee or other charge can be imposed on individuals sending or receiving money through UPI.

Small merchants, including street vendors and neighbourhood shops, receiving up to ₹1 lakh a month through UPI QR codes under the P2PM category will continue to be covered by the zero-MDR framework. Further, auto-debit recurring payments like utility bills or mutual fund subscriptions, known as UPI Mandates or AutoPay, will not carry the prescribed MDR transaction charges.

The new MDR framework and threshold structure will come into effect from 15 October, giving acquiring banks, payment aggregators, fintech applications and corporate accounting platforms time to update their software engines and billing systems, according to the statement.

While the framework is a step towards building a sustainable revenue model for UPI, the more important question is whether that revenue is



No transaction fee, platform fee or other charge can be imposed on individuals sending or receiving money through UPI.

MINT

shared fairly across all the players involved, said Kunal Jhunjhunwala, founder of Airpay Payment Services.

"Fintechs, in particular, have driven digital payments deep into the merchant base, in often in segments banks found harder to reach, and have invested heavily in the technology and infrastructure that made that possible.

That contribution needs to be recognized in how the model is structured, not treated as a footnote." Jhunjhunwala said fintechs have just a month to explain the new cost to merchants, help them get comfortable with it, and make the

backend changes needed to support it. "That's a short runway for a change with this much reach."

India's UPI platform processed 241.6 billion transactions worth ₹314.2 trillion in FY26, up 30% from a year earlier in volume and 21% in value. UPI had more than 55 crore users as of August 2026, according to NPCI data.

The platform processed 24.5 billion transactions worth ₹29.8 lakh crore in August 2026, up 22% in volume and 20% in value from a year earlier. P2M transactions accounted for 30% of total UPI transaction value in August, with transac-

tions of up to ₹500 accounting for 16% and those between ₹501 and ₹2,000 for 17%.

In volume terms, P2M transactions accounted for 63% of UPI transactions, of which 86% were below ₹500 and another 10% were between ₹501 and ₹2,000, according to the latest NPCI data.

"UPI's success was built on zero-cost adoption by consumers, small shopkeepers, and micro-enterprises, and the notified MDR framework preserves that foundation. We are reassured that small-value transactions up to ₹2,000 comprising over 95% of UPI P2M volume remain zero MDR, ensuring everyday payments stay free for consumers," said Girish Krishnan, director, payments, rewards and merchant services, Amazon Pay India.

Transactions above ₹2,000 in essential and thin-margin sectors, including railways, telecommunications, insurance, fuel, utility-bill payments, educational fees and agricultural inputs, will attract a flat MDR of ₹5 per transaction. Payments relating to mutual funds, securities, stockbrokers and dealers will attract an MDR of 0.02%, capped at ₹300 per transaction.

anshika.kayastha@livemint.com

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raised "serious doubts" about NMC Health's "financial statements" in December 2019. It alleged NMC "manipulated its balance sheet to understate debt." NMC Health was placed under administration by a UK court in April 2020. BoB moved a sessions court in Bengaluru the next month to restrain Shetty from selling or transferring certain assets.

The BoB settlement came after administrators sued Shetty, former CEO of NMC Health Prasanth Manghat, and BoB before the Abu Dhabi Global Market courts, alleging they were responsible for losses taken by the firm. Bank executives said later that the settlement only resolves a legal overhang and that loan recovery efforts will continue.

Documents now show that the bank was not completely in the dark about the alleged roundtripping—when money is sent out and then returned, creating the false impression of business activity—or diversion of funds. The AML compliance team wrote to the Abu Dhabi branch on 8 September, 2016 with a list of accounts, asking it to "analyze the transactions from AML angle, (and) assess the purpose for such transactions." It pointed out roundtripping in these accounts linked to NMC.

"There are roundtripping transactions in the account as



Documents now show that the bank was not completely in the dark about the alleged roundtripping or diversion of funds.

REUTERS

the major debits and credits are going to NMC group a/c (accounts) only i.e., funds coming from one group account of NMC which is remitted to another group account of NMC," it said. The AML team asked the branch to seek proper justification from the firm and submit responses.

"While doing so, please do not give (a) regular reply like 'fund management'... in view of high turnover in these accounts," it said.

The AML team then sent two reminders: on 20 November 2016 and nine days later. It couldn't be immediately ascertained if the branch

responded; however, the bank's submissions in the Bengaluru sessions court in 2020 showed it sanctioned fresh loans and bank guarantees to the NMC Group from September 2017 to June 2019, after these red flags were raised.

The AML team also raised the roundtripping issue at internal meetings, said a person aware of one such meeting in early 2016. The person said the alerts were sent to the official concerned with the branch via text messages too.

BoB informed the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on 28 December 2020 of an alleged fraud committed by B.R. Shetty in

the loan account of group company UAE Exchange Centre and said it had started a forensic audit after "adverse media reports on the BR Shetty Group accounts". The account was tagged as fraud in December 2020 after a September 2020 audit note.

The bank told RBI that a deputy general manager was tasked with probing staff accountability and alleged fraud. But the bank said the exact nature of action taken against the staff was "not known."

Court documents showed that Shetty and his firms owed the bank ₹2,077 crore as of May 2020. The settlement in the case—₹5,736 crore—cost the bank almost thrice its dues.

Emails sent to bank and Shetty's lawyers remained unanswered. Shetty did not respond to a call and a text message seeking comments.

Debadatta Chand, CEO of BoB, told reporters on 24 July that the recovery process against the principal individual would continue.

Experts said AML systems are designed to trigger alerts on big variations in a range of transaction scenarios. "Banks are expected to refine the scenarios on a regular basis," said Vivek Iyer, partner and financial services risk leader at Grant Thornton Bharat. After AML team alerts, banks send reports on suspicious transactions to the financial intelligence unit, he added.

FROM SUGAR TO EGGS, EL NIÑO'S DOMINO EFFECT

India's sugar problem threatens to spill over into maize, with wider consequences

Sayantana Bera
sayantan.bera@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The phrase 'confess the corn' is an American adage of 19th century vintage. It means admitting a mistake or, at the least, acknowledging an error. The exact origin of the phrase is unclear, though some sources point to a debate in the US Congress around corn that was either exported or fed to pigs. Here is an example from a New York daily (Spirit of the Times, 1942): "Your honor, I confess the corn, I was royally drunk."

India's farm commodity market is heading to its own 'confess the corn' moment. True to the original phrase, corn or maize is a protagonist to watch out for. So are a host of fellow crops: sugar, rice and soy. In a way, this can turn into a potboiler with some bad actors, like a venerable El Niño lowering monsoon rains, thrown in.

We know how it began. But we don't know how it may end.

The story so far: in recent months sugar prices have shot up by a staggering 40% on-year. This is because last year's sugarcane crop was damaged by both excess rains and a freak fungus, red-rot disease, which lowered yields. Yet, sugar mills painted a rosy outlook. Sugar was diverted to make ethanol for blending in petrol and some of it was even exported. Sugar prices rose sharply from ₹49 at the end of July to ₹65 per kg at the end of August, just ahead of the festive season when demand spikes.

No one yet has 'confessed the corn', or admitted to overestimating the availability of the sugarcane crop by a wide margin. The Indian Sugar and Bio-energy Manufacturers Association, or Isma, lowered its gross output forecast for sugarcane from nearly 35 million tonnes (mt) in July last year to 34.4 mt in November, and further down to 31 mt last month. These estimates, for the sugar supply year 2025-26 (October-September), are gross numbers that include sugar used to produce ethanol and for exports.

About 25% of India's ethanol supply is manufactured using sugarcane-based feedstock, with the rest coming from grains, particularly maize, the ministry of consumer affairs, food and public distribution said in a statement in August. It became more important to ensure adequate ethanol production as India made E20 petrol—20% ethanol and 80% conventional petrol—the standard across the country from 1 April 2026.

But even as the overall sugarcane output dropped, more than 3 mt of it was used to make ethanol in 2025-26, while 0.8 mt was exported, as per Isma and the food ministry. The diversion for ethanol had followed upbeat sugarcane production estimates. If the early estimates were closer to reality, the shortage and sharp spike in retail sugar prices may have been avoided, said Siraj Hussain, former agriculture secretary.

Isma, in a statement issued on 2 September, denied any structural deficit in sugar supply and stated that the industry was equipped to satisfy every pocket of demand.

Yet, the combination of lower sugarcane output and diversion for ethanol could trigger a domino effect impacting seemingly unrelated sectors.

Consider this: with deficit rains affecting the cane crop currently in the fields, next season's output is likely to take a hit. No agency has yet offered any production estimate for next year, but industry insiders and experts are certain that in the coming season (2026-27), beginning October, sugar will not be allowed for manufacturing ethanol.

In effect, it will fall on corn or maize to do the heavy lifting in ethanol production. That means higher demand for corn. But then, corn output is also likely to be smaller this year (2026-27) due to lower planted area and sub-par yields caused by deficit rains, as per poultry and ethanol industry insiders.

"It's going to be a hand-to-mouth situation for the ethanol industry," warns Chandra Kumar Jain, president of Grain Ethanol Manufacturers Association (Gema), a biofuel industry lobby. Jain estimates that maize requirement for ethanol will rise by 40-50% next year (assuming the quantity of rice supplied remains the same). Because maize will have to fill the void left by sugar.

Now, corn is a major energy source for India's growing poultry industry, a market estimated to be over ₹2.6 trillion in 2025. Corn prices have already touched new highs ahead of harvest. Meanwhile, soybean meal, another major input for the animal feed industry, has also turned costlier,



When food and fuel compete for the same crops, the consequences can travel surprisingly far.

owing to a global increase in oilseed prices.

Which means the poultry sector is up for a major cost spike.

For consumers, this will likely translate into higher prices for items like eggs and chicken meat.

Both ethanol makers and the poultry industry are hoping India will offer more rice from public stocks to make ethanol. Just to ease the pressure on corn. That hope rests on forgetting, at least momentarily, that rice is a water-guzzling crop with a heavy climate footprint, which experts argue should have a limited role in ethanol production. The uneasy truth is that rice prices are also rising (currently exhibiting an 8% year-on-year spike, as per the consumer affairs department).

So, a potboiler is churning. To repeat, the primary actors are: sugarcane, corn and rice. The second-order impacts: rising costs for the poultry and processed food industry, which uses sugar, starches and proteins. Plus, a spike in consumer food prices—from eggs and sugar to rice and edible oils.

In short: the food-fuel trade-off may end up sharpening price spikes in a deficit rainfall year. This spike will come on top of already rising prices: retail food inflation quickened to 5.95% in August from a low of 2.13% in January.

'RIGHT TO CORN'

This year's monsoon season has seen a rainfall deficit of 15% as of 14 September, as compared with the 50-year average, with more than half of India's area recording a deficit of 20% or more compared with the normal. India's meteorological office has forecast a drier-than-usual September, the last of the four-month monsoon season.

The monsoon in 2026 has been the most spatially distorted in a decade, or unevenly spread across regions, ratings agency Crisil warned earlier this month in a report titled 'The New Economics of Rainfall Shocks'. The key question now, it said, is not what farmers have sown, but whether planted crops can withstand deficit rainfall in areas with poor irrigation support. Maize and soybean are among crops vulnerable to deficit rains, according to the report.

For both the ethanol and poultry sectors, maize is a key input. Maize comprises around 55% of poultry feed by weight. Over half of the ethanol produced in the

country is made using corn as feedstock.

The Foreign Agricultural Service of the United States' Department of Agriculture (USDA) expects India's corn production to take a 10% hit in 2026-27. "Field sources report that the *kharif* corn crop planting was delayed by about two weeks, and the standing crop is facing moisture stress in the major corn-growing states in south and peninsular India," the agency reported on 28 August. It added that prolonged dry spells or abnormally heavy rains and floods at the time of harvest can affect crop output. Planting of winter-planted (*rabi*) and summer corn (next year) may also be adversely affected if deficit rains persist.

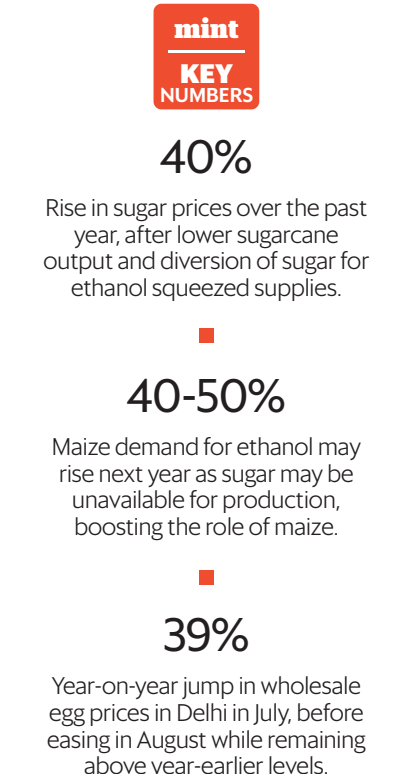
"Last year, corn prices fell (following a record harvest), so more farmers switched to soybeans," says Divya Kumar Gulati, chairman of the Compound Livestock Feed Manufacturing Association of India. Gulati adds that crop surveys commissioned by the industry group suggest that corn acreage is down by nearly 7% year-on-year. In addition, yields are expected to be lower due to deficit rains. According to the agriculture ministry, corn planting area is lower by 3.2% year-on-year (as of 4 September).

"There is little doubt that maize will be in short supply," says Gulati. "Our request to the government is that poultry farmers, and not ethanol makers, should have the first right to the crop." Gulati underlined that while ethanol can be produced from multiple sources, maize is the sole source of energy for poultry birds.

Here's how the numbers stack up so far. Current wholesale maize price is around ₹27 per kg—a spike of over 30% as compared with prices in May-June. Trade expects prices to come down in October with the arrival of the new crop, but those prices will be higher compared with last year's wholesale prices.

The impact is already evident. Wholesale egg prices in Delhi touched a high of ₹6.7 per piece in July, nearly 39% higher than July 2025 prices. Egg prices softened in August with falling demand (as consumption falls during the month of *Shravan*, considered an auspicious period per the Hindu religious calendar), but were still 7% higher year-on-year.

Obada Habib, a poultry entrepreneur from Gorakhpur, Uttar Pradesh, explained that corn demand for the poultry sector is likely to be robust in the coming months. Over the past year, there was significant mortality due to bird flu and the summer heatwave. But now, firmer prices have pushed the industry to bring into production more layer chicks, which



are hatched specifically for commercial egg production.

The number of birds placed in production hubs like Hyderabad in Telangana, Barwala in Haryana and Namakkal in Tamil Nadu has multiplied. This will lead to a significant increase in demand for maize. The winter months are also when consumption of poultry products witnesses a spike, which, again, would see prices firming up.

"Poultry feed prices have already surged, rising from ₹25 per kg in April to over ₹30 per kg now," Habib said.

THE ETHANOL DILEMMA

India achieved a blending rate of 20% ethanol in petrol in the ongoing ethanol supply year 2025-26 (November to October), five years ahead of schedule. But the government could consider moving to a lower blending ratio when feedstock crops like sugar and maize are in short supply, Delhi-based think tank ICRIER said in a 8 September policy brief.

Titled 'Food vs Fuel: Recalibrating India's Ethanol Blending Strategy', the brief authored by agricultural economist Ashok Gulati and researcher Tanmay Adhikary calculates that ethanol demand for blending in petrol grew from a mere 1.7 billion litres to an estimated 12 billion litres

Crop pressure

Ethanol demand to meet E20 target has outpaced feedstock production.

Soaring demand	CAGR, 2019-20 to 2025-26 (%)
Ethanol required for blending in petrol	38
Production	
Sugarcane	5.1
Maize	11.4
Rice	4.4

Source: ICRIER, September 2026

Food and feed surge

Year-on-year increase in prices as of 13 Sep 2026	Increase in feed prices, Apr-Sep 2026
Sugar	27%
Rice	7.8%
Eggs*	8.8%
Maize	>30%
Poultry feed	20-25%

*Egg prices as per wholesale rates in Chennai; Maize and poultry feed prices are indicative wholesale rates

Source: Consumer Affairs department; National Egg Coordination Committee; Industry sources

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

ning to navigate this tricky phase?

"It is certain that sugar will not be available to make ethanol. This means nearly 2.8 billion litres of ethanol production will have to move from sugar to grains like maize and rice," said Jain, president of the Grain Ethanol Manufacturer's Association.

If rice allocation for ethanol is not raised, ethanol makers will need more maize. Maize demand will increase from 16-17 mt in 2025-26 to 23-24 mt next year, Jain said. Add to this the annual needs of the poultry sector (23-24 mt) and starches used by food and other industries (another 10 mt). That adds up to a demand of more than 55 mt of maize. Last year, Indian farmers produced enough maize (estimated at 55 mt) to cater to these sectors but that performance is unlikely to be repeated next year.

Jain added that maize prices have already increased sharply, just ahead of harvest. "So, we are hoping that the government will allow diversion of excess rice stocks (held by the Food Corporation of India)," he said.

However, diverting excess rice supplies to make ethanol will not be an easy choice. Since rice is a resource-intensive crop that needs large quantities of water and heavily subsidized power and fertilizers and emits potent greenhouse gases like methane, using the grain to make a biofuel will nullify the positive environmental benefits of ethanol blending. In the current ethanol supply year (2025-26), rice accounted for nearly a quarter of ethanol production. Another challenge is that despite surplus stocks, retail rice prices have risen by 8% year-on-year as of 13 September.

"Global demand for rice (where India is the largest exporter) is high. Rice planting is lower (by 3.7% compared to last year) and retail prices are already rising," said Shweta Saini, chief executive officer of Delhi-based Arcus Policy Research. "An added risk is that the outlook for winter wheat is grim because deficit rains will impact water storage levels in reservoirs and wheat yields may suffer due to a scorching summer next year (a fallout of a record shattering El Niño)."

For now, India could push more rice to make ethanol. But then, the recent price spike in sugar can transmit to tomorrow's maize and rice prices. And tomorrow's maize and rice highs can feed into wheat, your daily bread, by next summer.

By then it will be too late to 'confess the corn'.



Should you add equal-weight funds to your portfolio?

Equal-weight funds track EW indices, which ensures money is spread evenly across an index

Jash Kriplani
jash.kriplani@livemint.com

The Nifty 50—India's headline stock market index—is down about 5% over the past 12 months and about 2% over the past six. A set of equal-weight index funds and exchange-traded funds (ETFs) have done better in the recent period.

For instance, an equal-weight (EW) fund tracking the Nifty 500 Equal Weight index returned about 15% over six months (as of 9 September 2026), funds tracking the Nifty 100 Equal Weight index returned around 7%, and the Nifty 50 Equal Weight-based funds are up about 2.7% over the same period.

Equal footing
Equal weight simply assigns the same weight to every stock in an index, instead of weighting by market capitalization. In a Nifty 50 Equal Weight index, for instance, each of the 50 stocks carries an equal 2% weight, reset back to equal every quarter, so no single stock or sector can dominate.

Equal weighting can also change the characteristics of an index. For example, the Nifty 500 Equal Weight index has 50% exposure to small-cap, 30% to mid-cap and 20% to large-caps as a result of the equal-weighting, while the parent Nifty 500 index carries close to 70% exposure to large-caps, with just 10% in small-caps and 20% in mid-caps.

These strategies have also grown gradually. Investor assets in equal-weight index funds and ETFs have seen a significant jump—from about ₹140 crore at the end of 2020 to over ₹10,500 crore by December 2025. Several of these funds are new, but they track indices that have long historical data. Below is a look at how these strategies have performed over the long run—and whether you should invest.

Past performance
Over rolling seven-year periods, these equal-weight indices have delivered average annualized returns of roughly 12-14%, and none posted a negative return over any seven-year window. The analysis is based on seven-year returns rolled daily between 11 September 2006 and 10 September 2026. This period included 3,218 observations of seven-year returns of each of the indices. The analysis is based on total return index variants, which captures both price movements and dividend gains in the index.

That outperformance over the parent index, though, tends to move in cycles, said M. Pattabiraman, founder of Freefincal. For instance, as the market surged in 2014 after that year's general election, the broader equal-weight indices raced well ahead of their parents—the Nifty 500 Equal Weight returned about 60% in calendar year 2014 against the Nifty 500's 39%, and the Nifty 100 Equal Weight about 42% versus the Nifty 100's 35%.

The recovery after the 2008 crash showed an even sharper divergence: from the March 2009 market bottom to late 2010, the Nifty 500 Equal Weight surged about 279% against the Nifty 500's 169%, and the Nifty 50 Equal Weight about 189% versus the Nifty 50's 150%.

Over longer periods, though, the differential versus the parent index can be wide or narrow, depending on which equal-weight index it is and the phase of the market. On rolling seven-year periods, the Nifty 100 Equal Weight

Workings of equal-weighting

In regular indices, stocks with large market caps get higher weightages; equal-weight indices reduce dominance of a few stocks or sectors by giving equal weights to all index constituents.

Average rolling returns (in %)

	3-year	5-year	7-year
Nifty 500 Equal Weight	15	13.8	13.2
Nifty 100 Equal Weight	14.2	13.3	13
Nifty 50 Equal Weight	13.1	12.3	11.8
Nifty Top 20 Equal Weight	13.2	12.8	12.7
Nifty Top 15 Equal Weight	13.6	13.2	13.1
Nifty Top 10 Equal Weight	13.8	14	14.2
Nifty 50	12.3	12.1	12.1

Note: figures are average rolling returns over 3, 5 and 7 years, computed daily between 11 September 2006 and 10 September 2026; annualised; TRI or total return index variants considered; The Nifty Top 10, Top 15 and Top 20 Equal Weight indices are the largest 10, 15 and 20 stocks of the Nifty 50, respectively, held at equal weight

How it works

- ▶ Equal weight index uses constituents of parent index
- ▶ Weights are reset to equal for each stock every quarter
- ▶ Equal weight ensures no single stock or sector dominates

When equal weight (EW) tends to work

Market environment	EW strategy that may work well
▶ Broad-based rally	Broader EW indices
▶ Polarized market (led by a few mega-caps)	Narrower EW indices (Nifty Top 10/15/20 EW)



Takeaways

- ▶ Check if the index's underlying universe matches your risk appetite
- ▶ For example, Nifty 500 EW is more small-cap-heavy than its cap-weighted parent
- ▶ Outperformance over the parent index tends to come in certain market phases
- ▶ Consider EW indices as part of a satellite allocation

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and Nifty 500 Equal Weight have beaten their parents by about half a percentage point a year on average. The gap is larger for the narrower baskets: Nifty Top 10, Top 15 and Top 20 Equal Weight. The Nifty Top 10 Equal Weight, for instance, beat the Nifty 50 benchmark by about 2 percentage points a year, in annualized terms, over rolling seven-year windows.

What to watch out for
Different equal-weight indices solve

different problems. "A Nifty 50-based equal-weight strategy gives you basic exposure to the market while solving for the concentration that comes with a regular, market-cap-weighted Nifty 50, where some stocks or sectors typically carry higher weights," said Anil Ghelani, head of passive investments and products at DSP Mutual Fund.

"In the narrower indices—the Top 10, 15 or 20—you get a concentrated portfolio, but equal weight ensures no single stock or sector dominates. It is more like a focused portfolio of the largest Indian companies."

The universe matters most, said Siddharth Srivastava, head of ETF products and fund manager at Mirae Asset

Mutual Fund. "Depending on the index it is based on, an equal weight index can have very different exposure not just to stocks, but also to market cap segments and sectors. A Nifty 500 equal-weight index will have 50% exposure to the small-cap segment and 30% to mid-cap, while a BSE 200 equal-weight index will have 50% exposure to mid-cap and the rest to large caps. Similarly, the Nifty 50 equal-weight index has much lower representation in the BFSI segment compared to the Nifty 50," he said.

"Investors should first decide which segment or segments they want equal-weight exposure in, and whether they are okay with not just equal stock weights but also changes in sectoral and segment representation and if it aligns with their investment objective and risk profile. A calendar year wise performance and risk comparison over last 10-15 years between the equal-weight index and its market cap based peer can throw some interesting insights and make the selection easier," he added.

Risk check

Investors should also weigh concentration risk, said Pattabiraman. "Some

of these portfolios—the narrower indices—can become concentrated. The question worth asking is whether a fund can manage so many stocks well once the asset size of the broader fund grows large. Investors should not just look at historical index performance, but at how these funds do in the live market," he said—the impact costs, whether the fund manages tracking error well, and, for ETFs, whether it trades close to its indicative net asset value (iNAV).

Most of the equal-weight funds can work as a satellite allocation—a smaller, diversifying slice held alongside a core portfolio—once your regular mutual fund investments are in place.

"Except for Nifty 50 equal-weight—which is a pure large-cap focused strategy—several of these equal-weight indices are catering to certain specific segments of the market. Hence, these should be considered part of the satellite allocation," said Surya Bhatia, a financial adviser at Asset Managers.



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Will an NRI's Singapore income face India tax after longer stay?

Harshal Bhuta

I am a non-resident Indian (NRI) working for a Singapore consulting company and have been residing in Singapore for the last 12 years on an Indian passport. My mother, who lived in India, passed away this year. Since then, I have visited India and would be likely to spend around three months in this financial year to manage the inherited assets in India. Also, because of the income from inherited assets, my Indian income will now be in 30% slab rate. In this scenario, will my Singapore employment income become taxable in India merely because of my long stay in India during this fiscal year?

—Name withheld on request

Your taxability in India will depend on the scope of your total income, which is determined by your residential status in India under the Income-Tax Act, 2025. Broadly, an individual is regarded as a resident in India if he or she is present in India for 182 days or more during the relevant tax year, or satisfies the alternative 60-day test together with a



ASK MINT NRI TAXATION

stay of 365 days or more in the preceding four years. However, for an Indian citizen or a person of Indian origin who visits India, the 60-day threshold is generally replaced by 182 days. Where such person's total income in India exceeds ₹15 lakh, this threshold is instead reduced to 120 days.

As you indicate your Indian income will fall in the 30% tax slab, I have assumed your Indian income exceeds ₹15 lakh. Given that your stay in India is expected to be around three months, you should not cross the 120-day threshold. You should therefore continue to qualify as a non-resident (NR) for Indian tax purposes. As an NR, you are generally

taxed in India only on income that is received or deemed to be received in India, or that accrues or arises, or is deemed to accrue or arise, in India.

Accordingly, your salary from the Singapore employer should generally not become taxable in India merely because you spend around three months in India. The position, however, requires some additional consideration if you actually perform your work duties while in India.

Even then, if you continue to qualify as a tax resident of Singapore and obtain a Singapore Tax Residency Certificate, the salary attributable to the period of employment exercised in India may still be protected from Indian tax under the India-Singapore Double Taxation Avoidance Agreement (DTAA), subject to satisfaction of the treaty conditions. Form 41 will also need to be filed to claim the applicable DTAA benefit.

Harshal Bhuta is a partner at P. R. Bhuta CAs.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at mintmoney@livemint.com and get them answered by industry experts.

Compare bank FD rates

Bank fixed deposits (FDs) continue to be popular investment products not just among senior citizens, who are looking for guaranteed income, but also among investors who can't stomach risk. But overexposure to FDs is not good, and you need to assess your asset allocation and goals to decide how much money you should park in them. For instance, saving for your child's higher education that's 15 years away through FDs may not be effective as the post-tax interest rate of an FD may not give you a real return (return that's above the rate of inflation). But if you plan to take a holiday in two years, an FD can help. Before choosing an FD, you should compare the interest rates on offer. Here is a list of banks that offer the highest FD rates for deposits up to ₹1 crore over various tenures.



Interest rates (%) for fixed deposits up to ₹1 crore					
	6 months to < 1 year	1 to < 2 years	2 to < 3 years	3 to < 5 years	5 years and above
DCB Bank	6.00-6.50	6.90-7.10	6.90-7.50	7.00-7.10	7.00-7.50
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	5.50-6.00	6.55-6.60	6.75-7.05	6.80	6.85
YES Bank	4.75-6.50	6.65-7.25	6.90-7.00	7.00	6.75
RBL Bank	4.75-6.05	7.00-7.20	7.20	7.00-7.20	6.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	6.30-6.50	6.60-7.25	7.00	6.70	6.70
IndusInd Bank	5.75-6.25	6.75-6.90	7.00	6.65-7.00	6.50-6.65
Dhanlaxmi Bank	5.50-7.00	6.25-7.10	6.25-6.50	6.50-7.25	6.50-6.60
Axis Bank	5.50-5.75	6.25-6.50	6.50	7.00	6.50
ICICI Bank	4.50-5.50	6.25-6.30	6.30-6.45	6.45-6.50	6.50
Federal Bank	4.50-6.00	6.25-6.65	6.40-6.50	6.40-6.70	6.40
Karur Vysya Bank	6.00-7.00	6.55-7.20	6.55	6.55	6.25-6.55
Kotak Mahindra Bank	5.00-6.00	6.35-6.55	6.80	6.40	6.25
Canara Bank	5.25-5.50	6.25-6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
City Union Bank	5.75-6.25	6.65-7.25	6.50	6.25-6.50	6.25
HDFC Bank	4.25-5.75	6.25-6.45	6.45	6.40-6.50	6.15-6.40
Indian Overseas Bank	4.50-5.50	6.40-6.60	6.40	6.10	6.10

Data taken from respective bank's website as on 14 September 2026. Only main entity of the merged banks are taken. Banks which merged with its main entity are removed from the table; The list of 16 banks is based on highest fixed deposit rates available for 5 years and above.

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Source: www.BankBazaar.com

INDIA'S INCAPACITY LAW GAP: WHY ESTATE PLANNING MUST GO BEYOND WILLS



POWER
POINT

SHRADDHA NILESHWAR

We welcome your views and comments at mintmoney@livemint.com

When people think of estate planning, what comes to mind is the devolution of assets post demise, such as wills, nominations, trusts. Almost none address a more common, far more frightening event: losing mental capacity while still alive. A stroke, dementia or a coma can strip a person of legal agency overnight, and unlike the US or the UK, India has no comprehensive law letting a person plan for this moment in advance.

The blind spot

The scale is not small. The Longitudinal Ageing Study in India, 2023, found about 8.8 million Indians aged 60 and above living with dementia, a prevalence of 7.4%.

The UNFPA India Ageing Report 2023 counted 149 million Indians aged 60 and above in 2022, projected to reach 347 million by 2050. Each may one day need someone to sign a cheque, sell a flat or consent to surgery on their behalf, and Indian law offers only fragments to handle it.

What Indian law actually offers is fragmentary. Let's take a look at each aspect:

The Indian Contract Act, 1872, under Section 11, voids contracts made by a person of unsound mind, but offers no advance planning route.

The Mental Healthcare Act, 2017, lets a person nominate a treatment representative, though it covers healthcare only and stays silent on property and finances.

The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016, under Section 14, lets a court appoint a limited guardian for a benchmark disability, but excludes most dementia and stroke patients.

The National Trust Act, 1999, provides guardianship, though only for four listed conditions, autism, cerebral palsy, mental retardation and multiple disabilities.

And the Powers of Attorney Act, 1882, lets a person appoint an agent, but stays silent on whether that agency survives incapacity, so rulings on the point vary.

Court route

Because no dedicated statute exists, families turn to courts, which act as guardians under their parens patriae jurisdiction. In 2020, the Delhi High Court let only a spouse or children guard a comatose woman whose Provident Fund savings a bank had withheld, and ordered full asset disclosure. In 2025, the Bombay High Court ordered a medical board to examine a 78-year-old dementia patient before ruling on her children's guardianship plea, a process that took months. Currently, there are 4 tools available in India as of date, each addressing a different piece of the problem.



A General Power of Attorney, with a survival clause, lets a chosen agent manage accounts and property, though banks and registrars still treat such clauses inconsistently.

A nominated representative under the Mental Healthcare Act, 2017, gives a named person a say in treatment decisions, but addresses healthcare only and not matters relating to money or property.

An Advance Medical Directive, the living will be recognised in Common Cause versus Union of India, 2018, records a person's end

of life wishes and was simplified by the Supreme Court in 2023, though it applies only to end of life care.

A private family trust under the Indian Trusts Act, 1882, lets a trustee manage assets for the person's benefit through incapacity, though it needs upfront legal setup and a carefully drafted deed.

Trust advantage

Of the four options above, the private family trust deserves the closest attention as it alone works without interruption during a

person's unfortunate incapacitation. A person transfers assets, a house, fixed deposits, a stock portfolio, to a trustee, who manages them for their own benefit. Since the assets legally belong to the trust, incapacity freezes nothing. The trustee, still of sound mind, keeps signing cheques and settling bills. A well-drafted deed adds an incapacitation clause, triggered once two doctors certify the settlor cannot manage their affairs, letting the trustee pay hospitals and caregivers directly, bypassing court guardianship. None of these four tools alone matches the single, enforceable system a durable power of attorney offers in the US or the UK. But a private trust, layered with a living will and a Mental Healthcare Act nomination, comes closest. Until Parliament legislates a dedicated incapacity law, that combination remains the safest route for an Indian family.

Shraddha Nileswhar, head – will & estate planning at I Finance.

OUR VIEW



El Niño: a silver lining is in orbit 740km above us

India has satellite data to help track rainfall and inflation risks arising from global tilts in oceanic warmth. The country's challenge is to study atmospheric aberrations closer home

GINGER, garlic, onions and sugar had far higher prices in August than in the same month last year, going by inflation data released by India's statistics ministry, while the usual suspects among kitchen staples like potatoes and tomatoes were cheaper. Given their varying crop cycles and rain-catchment zones, scarcities caused by patchy rainfall have played varied roles in these outcomes. Broadly, however, food has gotten dearer, even as monsoon rains begin to peter out with the country staring at a rain deficit of about 15%. Oilseeds and edible oils have seen price uptrends, pulses look set for the same and rice may need buffer-stock releases to keep the market well supplied. That a drier rainy season than usual would cause some crop shortfalls was foreseen as soon as 'El Niño' was forecast as a near certainty this year. The link is a gloomy one for a country that relies on rain for much of its farm output, but the gloom also has a silver lining: India has satellite data that lets us track El Niño 'live' as this oceanic seesaw develops.

On 10 September, Indian Space Research Organisation (Isro) flagged a sharp depletion of chlorophyll across the equatorial Pacific Ocean as a clear bio-indicator of El Niño. It was detected by an ocean-colour monitor aboard Oceansat-3, an orbiter launched by Isro in late 2022. America's space agency Nasa has issued a similar alert. El Niño is expected to get stronger, with surface-wind readings from Oceansat-3's scatterometer offering corroborative evidence. As tropical trade winds that usually blow from east to west weaken (or reverse), warm surface water faces less resistance as it slops across from the Pacific's Asian side to the American. This is an El Niño tilt, part of a slow 'oscillation' that

unsettles typical patterns of warmth and rain across much of the globe, and this year's could turn out to be one of the strongest on record. But what does a pigment best known for its role in oxygen supply reveal? In the neutral phase of the oceanic seesaw, an upwell of cold but nutrient-rich water emerges to keep surface phytoplankton well fed. Should warm water suppress that feed, vast patches of plankton lose their greenness—as visible from space. Cruel as it sounds, algae starvation helps estimate the angle of the Pacific's thermal incline.

Isro data on marine chlorophyll could also help track a tilt in the Indian Ocean, the 'dipole' effect that might be able to counter an El Niño dry-out. While the latter tilts Pacific warmth away from Asia, thereby reducing cloud formation via air convection in our part of the world, a 'positive dipole' driven by strong tropical winds blowing Africa's way could alter the Indian Ocean's balance of warmth just enough to push the atmosphere above it back in favour of rainfall over the subcontinent. Although this chain of cause-and-effect is even more chancy and complex, which makes its impact harder to gauge, a positive dipole was forecast this year and signs of it are under watch from 740km above the planet's surface. Our remote readings may be too sketchy at this stage, but what's clear is this: India's quest for space-age tools to study rainfall risk is all the more valuable in the face of climate change. Next, El Niño could distort the path of rain clouds that feed our winter crops, a risk compounded by frequent episodes of jet-stream chaos traceable to global warming. As the risk historian and author Peter Bernstein noted, the modern economy owes much to the conquest of risk. We have made good progress, but a lot awaits deeper research.

THEIR VIEW

Geopolitics has influenced Brics but it needs greater coherence

Can shared dissatisfaction with the existing world order yield institutions that actually deliver?



HARSH V. PANT
is professor of international relations, King's College London, and vice president for studies at Observer Research Foundation, New Delhi.

Brics was born as a geo-economic idea. It was never intended to be an anti-Western alliance. Yet geopolitics has steadily transformed it into something larger: a platform through which the Global South seeks greater strategic autonomy, a stronger voice in global governance and a more multipolar international order.

The original Brics—Brazil, Russia, India and China—were brought together by a simple proposition: their economic weight was rising faster than their representation in institutions such as the International Monetary Fund and World Bank. South Africa joined in 2011, and the creation of the New Development Bank (NDB) in 2015 reflected the group's developmental ambitions. The objective was to reform the existing order, not overturn it. That distinction has become harder to maintain.

The Ukraine War and Western sanctions have given Russia strong incentives to use Brics to build alternative financial and trade arrangements. China has increasingly viewed the grouping as part of a wider effort to dilute Western dominance. The intensifying US-China rivalry, debates over the dollar and frustration across the Global South with Western double standards have further enhanced Brics's appeal.

The post-2023 expansion has taken this process much further. With Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, the UAE, Saudi Arabia

and Indonesia joining the original five, Brics now has 11 member countries with very different strategic interests. Its growing membership gives it greater global weight, but also makes consensus considerably harder.

This is the central paradox of Brics. Its geopolitical relevance is increasing precisely as its internal coherence is becoming more difficult to sustain. West Asia provides the clearest illustration. Iran and the UAE sit within the same grouping despite sharply different regional security relationships. The failure of Brics foreign ministers to agree on a joint statement amid the 2026 Iran conflict showed the limits of treating the group as a geopolitical bloc. The New Delhi Summit declaration sought a middle ground, calling for restraint and dialogue while avoiding a direct confrontation with either the US or Israel.

India's 2026 chairship has consequently highlighted what Brics could realistically become. New Delhi has sought to keep geopolitics on the agenda without allowing it to consume the group. The New Delhi Declaration addressed conflicts, terrorism, United Nations reform and multipolarity, but the larger agenda remained developmental: health, food and energy security, technology, artificial intelligence, digital public infrastructure, critical minerals, supply chains and financial cooperation.

This approach reflects India's broader strategic instinct. New Delhi does not see strategic autonomy as choosing between the West and the rest. It sees value in maintaining multiple partnerships simultaneously. Brics is useful precisely because it does not require its members to abandon their relationships with the US, Europe or other institutions. This is also why Brics should not be mistaken for an emerging G-7 alternative. It is neither a military alliance nor a unified economic bloc. The NDB is small compared to the World Bank, while efforts to reduce

dependence on the US dollar remain evolutionary rather than revolutionary.

The real significance of Brics lies in its flexibility. It gives emerging powers an additional instrument to hedge against great-power rivalry. China and Russia may want it to become a vehicle for a more fundamental restructuring of the international order. India, Brazil and several others are more interested in development, representation and strategic room for manoeuvre.

The future of Brics will depend on how these competing visions are managed. Expansion has given the grouping greater legitimacy across the Global South, but it has also created the possibility of a two-speed Brics—one part more revisionist, another more pragmatic and multi-aligned. For now, the most useful way to understand Brics is neither as an anti-Western bloc nor as merely an economic club. Rather, it is becoming a platform for a more assertive Global South: one that wants greater agency without necessarily wanting to choose sides.

The evolution of Brics has thus been less a story of deliberate geopolitical transformation than of adaptation to a changing international environment. Its economic and developmental agenda remains the denser and more operational core, while geopolitics has given the grouping greater strategic significance. India's 2026 chairship has underscored precisely this distinction: the objective is not to create a new bloc against the West, but to make the Global South a more consequential actor in a fragmented and increasingly multipolar world.

Geopolitics may have expanded Brics, but development and economic cooperation will determine whether it can hold together. Grand declarations about multipolarity are par for the course. Its credibility, however, will ultimately rest on whether its diverse members can translate their shared dissatisfaction with the existing order into institutions that actually deliver.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

El Niño is being supersized before our eyes... The science leaves no room for doubt: the planet is in uncharted waters and those waters are heating up.

ANTÓNIO GUTERRES

GUEST VIEW

Will listing Tata Sons prove better? The jury's still out

KRISHNAN RANGANATHAN



is a former executive director, Nomura, and currently a faculty member at several B-schools.

FOR 158 years, Tata Sons has run one of the world's greatest conglomerates the way a Victorian trust manages an estate: quietly, from behind a wall, with beneficiaries collecting the returns and nobody outside the family circle asking how the sausage gets made. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) last week effectively told the family that sausage-making is a regulated activity, rejecting Tata Sons' bid to deregister as an 'upper-layer' non-banking financial company (NBFC) and thereby closing the last exit ramp from a mandatory listing. The economics literature has plenty to say about what may happen as a consequence.

The case for listing: After IL&FS collapsed in 2018, RBI decided it could no longer let systemically large NBFCs operate as black boxes. Tata Sons, which allocates capital across 26 listed companies and hundreds of subsidiaries, is about as large a box as India has. If a business is big enough to hurt the financial system if it wobbles, it is big enough to be watched closely.

Academics Tarun Khanna and Krishna Palepu found that group affiliation in the 1990s India substituted for missing capital markets: internal capital allocation done well creates value where external financing is scarce. The same machinery operating without disclosure is also how value might quietly get moved to serve the controlling family's interests over those of minority shareholders. Stijn Claessens *et al.*, studying ownership across East Asian corporations, showed that pyramidal groups—Tata Sons is a textbook case—open a wedge between control and cash-flow rights. Whoever sits at the apex controls decisions worth far more than their economic stake. The bigger the wedge, the bigger the temptation to 'tunnel': shift resources from cash-rich units into pet projects nobody would fund in an open market.

Tata Sons has poured billions into Tata Digital and a semiconductor bet, and propped up Air India through huge losses—decisions taken by a board answerable to Tata Trusts, not to public shareholders who might have priced those bets differently. The investments may yet prove visionary. But that is precisely the claim public markets exist to interrogate.

When Ratan Tata forced Cyrus Mistry out

of Tata Sons in 2016 and the fight spilled into courts, there was no market pricing of the dispute in real time—no share price, let alone analyst calls or quarterly filings for a line of sight to its workings. The battle ran through tribunals instead. A listing should make such governance-by-litigation unnecessary. Sunlight is the best disinfectant.

The case against: Anderson and Reeb, studying S&P 500 firms, found family-controlled companies outperformed diffusely-owned peers because concentrated, patient ownership can take long-horizon bets that markets focused on quarterly earnings tend to punish. Warren Buffett's ideal holding period for a wonderful business is 'forever,' a luxury no listed firm enjoys once investors start dialling in every 90 days. Noel Tata's argument is exactly this: private control funded decade-long gambles (JLR took years to turn a profit; the semiconductor plant is nowhere near one) that a public Tata Sons would struggle to justify.

The Ford family kept control after its 1956 listing through a special class of shares carrying outsized votes, so no corporate raider could buy its way onto the carmaker's board. Tata Sons' approach to the market will be watched to see which bits of the Ford playbook are summoned.

What about takeover risk? Strip away the veto held by directors and we have an entity that may be worth \$120 billion sitting atop TCS, Tata Motors and other firms but potentially exposed to a strategic buy-out under certain circumstances. The governance features that shield insiders from market discipline also protect strategically vital national assets from being picked apart.

South Korea offers a live firm enjoys once investors start dialling in every 90 days. Noel Tata's argument is exactly this: private control funded decade-long gambles (JLR took years to turn a profit; the semiconductor plant is nowhere near one) that a public Tata Sons would struggle to justify.

warning. Its *chaebol*—Samsung, Hyundai, SK—run on almost identical family-trust set-ups and Seoul has spent a decade forcing them towards Western-style disclosure. The result: years of litigation, mergers engineered to shore up family control and a *chaebol* scion who did jail time.

The historical record goes both ways on whether public answerability favours such a group's success

Who actually wins: Below the philosophy sits a commercial fight. Shapoorji Pallonji, a debt-laden group with an illiquid 18% stake in Tata Sons, has long sought a way to monetize its shares. Minority shareholders in TCS, Tata Motors, etc. should cheer too: an initial public offering (IPO) would force disclosure on how capital moves between healthy Tata businesses and money-losing ones.

The final call: Tata Sons' asset base is multiple times RBI's threshold for deregistration. Exempting a prestigious name could put the entire framework's reputation at risk. On the broad economic gains of Tata Sons going public—whether forcing disclosure upon a trust-controlled conglomerate will make India's financial system healthier—the honest answer is: wait and watch. The evidence cuts both ways: the same ownership structure that protects a firm from the pressure of quarterly results also shields insiders from their own shareholders—often at once, and often in the same company.

N. Chandrasekaran's abrupt resignation last month suggests even the people running the group aren't sure how the experiment ends. Asked what the stock market would do, J.P. Morgan is said to have replied: "It will fluctuate." Tata Sons may have to accept fluctuation as a permanent condition.



THEIR VIEW

The quiet revolution in services: it's a story of productivity gains

Services have turned more productive across the world than economists expected but the benefits of it are not widely shared



DANI RODRIK

is a professor of international political economy at Harvard Kennedy School, and the author of 'Shared Prosperity in a Fractured World: A New Economics for the Middle Class, the Global Poor, and Our Climate'

In 2023, University of Chicago economists Chang-Tai Hsieh and Esteban Rossi-Hansberg published a study showing that services in the US were undergoing a radical transformation. Digital technologies and organizational innovations in retail, hospitality, personal services and medical services, they argued, had enabled some firms to become much more productive and expand their presence in local markets previously served by smaller, less efficient establishments. It was an "industrial revolution in services."

Although Hsieh and Rossi-Hansberg suggested that much of the productivity gain from this trend did not show up in official statistics, even the measured upsurge in services productivity has been impressive. Between 2000 and 2024, labour productivity in the US grew at an annual average rate of 3% in food-service establishments, 2.1% in accommodation services, 2.9% in retail trade and 4.4% in wholesale trade. Compared to manufacturing, where labour productivity growth has stagnated at an annual rate of 0.2%, the record in services is nothing short of extraordinary.

This performance is as unexpected as it is welcome. It is unexpected because the traditional view holds that services are a drag on the economy's productivity (what economists call Baumol's cost disease); and it is welcome because services now dominate economic activity and provide the bulk of jobs. Higher productivity is a necessary (if not sufficient) condition for turning precarious jobs in services into the good jobs that inclusive prosperity requires.

Even better, the services revolution appears to be a global phenomenon that has spread to developing countries. While economists and policy-makers debate whether industrialization can still play its traditional growth-promoting role in the current global and technological context, services have quietly turned into an engine of economic development around the world.

When services are discussed in the context of economic growth in developing countries, the focus tends to be on tradable, skill-intensive activities such as information technology (IT), business processing or financial services. But by their very nature, these services are not well suited to low-income contexts. They can absorb only a small share of the labour force—the same disadvantage (from a development standpoint) as manufacturing today.

Instead, the current revolution is happening in less glamorous but more consequential services: restaurants, deliveries, ride-hailing, grocery stores, gig work and care. Recent academic research has shown that the expansion of middle-class services has been an important driver of economic growth in India, Sub-Saharan Africa and Latin America.

In India, for example, advances in IT and business process outsourcing have certainly been



important for graduates of tech institutes. But the vast, less-educated majority of the workforce has benefited primarily from the expansion of what Yale economists Tianyu Fan, Michael Peters and Fabrizio Zilibotti call consumer services sold on local markets. Moreover, a November 2025 International Monetary Fund report finds that the marginal product of labour in India's services now exceeds that in manufacturing, partly because labour productivity in the manufacturing sector has stalled in recent years. Taken at face value, this means that moving a worker from manufacturing to services would increase India's overall income.

To be sure, even if manufacturers do not directly generate much employment, they can have indirect effects on the economy through linkages to other firms and the tech spillovers they often generate. This point is often used to counter the argument that services offer a viable development model. But the manner in which global value chains are organized almost guarantees negligible spillover benefits from export-oriented factories. Since the bulk of intermediate and capital inputs are imported, only a thin segment of value addition is generated domestically and backward spillovers are minimized.

By contrast, modern service establishments can offer significant linkage opportunities. For example, discount retail chains typically operate under private label, which means that they offer predominantly locally made goods. In Colombia, retailers such as DI and Ara rely almost exclusively on local sourcing. They work with hundreds of local suppliers across the food and grocery value chain, providing them with the benefits of scale and access to larger markets. These supply chains enable tech upgrades in areas such as packaging, traceability and cold chains, as well as stronger enforcement of

quality standards. They have been shown to increase formal employment in manufacturing and agriculture by several percentage points without adverse effects on employment in general.

Unpublished work by Victo Silva, a visiting researcher at Harvard's Center for International Development, documents a similar phenomenon in food delivery services in Brazil. Consider the platform iFood, which serves 400,000 restaurants of all sizes. Beyond delivering meals, it provides financial, logistical, customer-service and market-analysis tools to food-service businesses, enabling productive upgradation across the sector.

As this evidence shows, the potential for productivity gains in labour-absorbing services is significant. The risk is that the benefits will be appropriated by employers, especially large chains and platforms that can exert market power over their employees, customers and suppliers.

In the US, Uber drivers or Amazon warehouse workers have not experienced major improvements in wages and working conditions despite the remarkable productivity gains these platforms have enabled.

This is no different from what happened in manufacturing industries in their early days. For the gains of workplace productivity to be widely shared, corporations must face countervailing power. Competition policy, regulation and a stronger voice for workers will be as important in services as they were in manufacturing.

In the absence of productivity gains, demands for higher labour standards may conflict with overall employment. But if the productivity revolution in services can be sustained, it will help developed and developing countries alike avoid this cruel trade-off.

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MINT CURATOR

Sebi's rethink on closing price auctions is a disappointment

India needs market depth but its regulator seems to have given up



ANDY MUKHERJEE

is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering industrial companies and financial services in Asia.



Sebi looks set to backtrack on what it had presented as a reform. REUTERS

After just a month of teething troubles and protests, one of India's biggest capital market reforms risks being watered down—if not entirely jettisoned. In early August, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) directed bourses to discover end-of-day prices via a final 20-minute auction. This was meant to stop large traders from manipulating closing prices under cover of all-day continuous trading, known as 'marking the close.'

It is also one of Sebi's allegations against Jane Street. The Indian regulator froze some of this Wall Street firm's index-option profits last year, alleging that they came from its distortion of underlying stock prices. Jane Street denied the allegations as a fundamental misreading of its strategy and is pursuing an appeal before a tribunal. But apart from adopting a more aggressive stance against Wall Street heavyweights, what could Sebi do to make the cash market more honest? It rightly judged that policing alone wouldn't suffice. Manipulation had to be nipped in the bud.

The stakes are high. For years, authorities have been alarmed by India's rise as the world's largest options trading venue. Pandemic boredom unleashed a wave of thrill-seeking behaviour among individual investors globally, aided by zero-brokerage apps and short-expiry derivatives. In India, such speculation continued after covid, with the notional volume of equity derivatives trading peaking at \$6 trillion in February 2024.

With 90% of retail investors losing money trading derivatives, the craze was threatening to become a social menace, especially among younger men. As the wait for white-collar jobs kept getting longer, they had time—and access to 'finfluencers'—to splurge on leveraged bets they couldn't afford. While curbing retail speculation, the regulator began to probe if Big Whales were rigging the much smaller and less liquid cash-equity market.

Most global bourses discover closing prices by halting continuous trading and switching to an auction for the last few minutes. An equilibrium price where most orders can be matched is declared as final. Since any attempt to game an auction is quickly detected, Sebi moved about 200 derivative-linked stocks to a closing auction system. Then everything went haywire.

Intraday trends reversed abruptly in the 20-minute auction window. Option volatility exploded and local investors decried the system as unworkable.

Sebi lost its nerve. Over the weekend, it released a new consultation paper offering two options: either shorten the auction to

minimize its impact or strip it from derivative settlement for at least a year and return to a 30-minute trading average. If Sebi chooses the second option, the market will largely go back to its old ways.

The regulator's loss of faith in its reform is disappointing. Worse, the true villain isn't getting enough attention. After all, if investors are behaving irrationally in the closing minutes, why aren't arbitrageurs swooping in to enforce more orderly price discovery?

The simple answer is taxation. Securities transactions have been taxed by New Delhi since 2004, but rates have climbed to prohibitive levels. After the most recent increase, an arbitrageur who could stabilize prices by going long cash and short futures has no incentive to do so after paying a 0.05% tax on the total contract value.

This gives rise to a chicken-and-egg problem. As capital pools that could trade away inefficiencies stay away, the market becomes even shallower. Traders' inability to execute large orders without moving prices further diminishes the profit potential from arbitrage. The finance ministry should have reworked its tax policies before Sebi adopted the auction method. A breakdown in fiscal-regulatory coordination is what doomed the reform.

Exorbitant taxation has other important side effects. Day traders dabbling in derivatives who would have otherwise remained profitable became net loss-makers after paying transaction costs—those accounted for over a third of their gross losses. What are these costs? While broker commissions and exchange fees are falling, the securities transaction tax collected from retail investors has ballooned to ₹6,600 crore from ₹1,300 crore four years ago.

Sebi isn't off the hook, though. A well-functioning market needs bullish and bearish views. But short sellers struggle to borrow stocks. That's because Sebi—scarred by scams where bank money was used illicitly to fund speculative positions—tries to micromanage what should be a private transaction between lender and borrower. All of this compounds the lack of liquidity. A market that resembles a small pond is getting in the way of both Big Whales and small fish. Reforms must boost depth. But after the latest botched attempt, it may be some time before the regulator can muster the confidence to try again.

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MY VIEW | EX MACHINA

Math and law practice are caught in the same AI bind

RAHUL MATTHAN



is a partner at Trilegal and the author of 'The Third Way: India's Revolutionary Approach to Data Governance'. His X handle is @matthan.

In a post earlier this month, mathematician Terence Tao described a recent incident at the frontier of his field. He spoke of how, just days after a young mathematician named Stadlmann published a proof (addressing a long-standing problem about the size of the gaps between prime numbers), several artificial intelligence (AI) companies announced numerically stronger solutions. While Tao was relieved that Stadlmann managed to publish her solution before the problem was "contaminated," he feared for the future of his discipline.

The real value of that kind of research lies not just in finding the answer, but in the process of arriving at it—the techniques you have to invent, the dead ends you learn to recognize and the ideas that surface along the way. This is often easy to miss, hidden as it tends to be behind the satisfaction of achieving the result. But in almost every case, the journey matters more than the destination.

AI upends this. When it hands you the proof, mathematicians have little incentive

to work through it themselves. If a proof exists, all we can do is check it—not derive it afresh. As a result, the understanding that once came from painstakingly working through the problem will vanish. Tao's worry is not that AI is wrong or its proofs sub-optimal. It is that as these systems improve, fewer people will be able to learn the way they used to.

Last week, 25 winners of the Fields Medal (Tao included), mathematics' top honour, signed a declaration warning that the goals of AI labs were "severely misaligned" with those of mathematicians, and that this was "similar to issues that other scientific and creative professions are facing." What they left unsaid was that the goals we set ourselves almost always have a deeper significance than the immediate reward they offer.

In professions that still train their people on the job—as professional guilds once did—the real purpose of work is not just its completion, but the skills that accrue from doing it. There is no better example of this than the legal profession.

As I have pointed out in earlier columns, law remains a stubbornly artisanal craft. To this day, we don't know how to produce senior lawyers other than by putting fresh graduates through years of unglamorous work

until the skills they need take hold. This is why we make them do research, carry out due diligence reviews and create first drafts of notes—because we have long believed that the practice of doing these activities is the fertile soil in which judgement germinates and grows.

These are precisely the tasks that every legal AI tool claims to be able to do far more reliably than a junior associate. Firms that buy that marketing pitch will increase their reliance on AI and hire fewer fresh associates. Those which do not may soon find themselves outpriced by those that have, and will eventually be forced to follow suit. Before we know it, our pipeline for turning fresh graduates into experienced lawyers will run dry.

Many firms are reassuring themselves that junior lawyers will now learn different skills—that their role will metamorphose from doing that work to supervising the AI systems we deploy to do it. This is an overly optimistic premise that ignores the fact that

people cannot meaningfully review work they themselves have never learnt to do in the first place. Identifying where AI reasoning is wrong takes exactly the sort of experience and judgement that doing the work oneself builds.

Some may argue that this is simply how work evolves—that every new technology reshapes our ways of working and we will just have to adapt. I have long argued as much myself. But adapting to a new tool is not the same as giving up what the work was giving us. The task now is to shape how we use AI, keeping what matters and handing the rest to the machine.

If we agree that young lawyers can acquire the essential judgement they need only by spending time on a foundational core of legal work, then we have to design our systems to ensure they always have enough of this work to gain that experience. What's more, we need to commit to doing this even though it might be faster and cheaper to hand such work off to AI.

Figuring out what we must leave to junior associates and what we should allow AI to do will soon become one of the core decisions management makes. Firms that thoughtfully adopt AI will not ask 'Can AI do this?' but instead, 'Does doing it build the judgement a young lawyer needs to become a senior?' Whenever the answer to this question is a 'yes,' the task in question should be made part of a necessary apprenticeship that all young associates must go through, no matter what it might cost the firm.

It is tempting to treat junior lawyers as an 'expense' to automate away. But while firms that eliminate junior lawyers may save money in the short term, they are also squandering their future by drawing down a reserve of expertise they cannot replace. The use of AI in the legal profession must not be judged solely by how much work it takes off our hands, but also by how many lawyers it allows us to keep training.

This is what Terence Tao's warning was really about. In mathematics, as in law, there are some things we should not hand to AI—not because AI cannot do them well, but because simply finding the answer was never really the point. These are tasks that serve a larger purpose, and for that reason, we should not blithely automate them away.



Shaping digital trust in the age of AI fraud

How can shopping platforms and regulators protect consumers from online fraud in a world where AI has made criminality easier?

Abhishek Baxi
feedback@livemint.com

Consumers rarely think about trust while placing an order online, scanning a QR code, or reading product reviews. They notice it only when something goes wrong: a counterfeit product arrives at their doorstep, a payment scam wipes out savings, or a fake review influences a purchase.

That invisible nature of trust sits at the heart of a growing challenge facing the digital economy. As generative AI lowers the cost of deception and enables creating convincing product images, seller profiles, and customer reviews, online marketplace are finding themselves in an escalating contest against increasingly sophisticated bad actors and organized fraud networks.

For Kebharu Smith, who leads Amazon's global Counterfeit Crimes Unit (CCU), that battle plays out every day. "Trust is hard-earned and easy to lose," Smith said during a recent interaction on the sidelines of his India visit.

THE AI ARMS RACE IS HERE

The technology industry has spent the last couple of years discussing the promise and risks of AI, including the recent doomsday predictions. Less discussed though is how AI is changing the economics of fraud.

Smith says that AI has become a tool for both sides. On one side are bad actors seeking to exploit platforms at scale. On the other are marketplaces deploying increasingly sophisticated detection systems to identify anomalies and verify products, and connect seemingly unrelated actors.

Amazon says its systems now conduct billions of scans across products, sellers, and transactions. AI tools can compare trademarks and logos, identify suspicious behavioural patterns, and link bad actors across multiple accounts.

Amazon is hardly alone in building institutional mechanisms around trust. Globally, online marketplaces have increasingly moved beyond reactive moderation towards dedicated verification and authentication systems. eBay, for instance, operates an "Authenticity Guarantee" programme under which experts physically inspect eligible luxury goods, sneakers, watches and collectibles before they are delivered to buyers.

That company also runs a Verified Rights Owner (VeRO) programme allowing brands to report and remove listings that infringe intellectual-property rights. In India, Flipkart has spoken publicly about using machine-learning systems to detect fraudulent transactions, identify risky seller behaviour, and prevent abuse across its marketplace.

As Nikhil Pahwa, a digital policy commentator and founder of *Medianama*, puts it, "When AI is used to deceive, AI is also needed to audit". Yet this does not mean technology alone can solve the problem.

TRUST AS INFRASTRUCTURE

India's digital economy has expanded rapidly over the past decade as e-commerce, digital payments, and app-based services have become deeply embedded in everyday life. That growth,



PHOTOS FROM ISTOCKPHOTO

however, masks a more complicated story about trust.

According to Prasanto K. Roy, a public policy advisor and former tech editor, consumer confidence has become increasingly concentrated around a handful of large platforms with strong trust and safety systems.

Roy describes the trend as a "K-shaped trust bifurcation". What this means is that while consumers increasingly trust established platforms with reliable refund policies and grievance mechanisms, skepticism remains high towards unknown merchants, unverified social-commerce sellers, and unreliable review ecosystems. Trust is not evenly distributed.

Roy describes digital trust as the "invisible layer" holding the ecosystem together. That trust is built through payment safeguards, return policies, customer support mechanisms, seller verification programmes, and algorithmic fraud detection. In most cases, the consumer has little understanding of these systems.

On the operational side, counterfeit investigations, account verification systems, and AI-driven monitoring are all examples of mechanisms designed to make trust scalable.

One of the more striking elements of Smith's account is his positioning of counterfeits as something bigger than just a marketplace problem. According to him, counterfeit operations are often linked to broader criminal ecosystems involving money laundering, organized crime, and other illicit activities.

From that perspective, a counterfeit handbag listing is not simply a consumer-protection issue. It may be the visible endpoint of a much larger and more complex supply chain.

That is partly why Amazon expanded the reach of CCU into India earlier this year. The company says it is focusing on local investigative capabilities alongside partnerships with brands and law enforcement agencies.

THE REGULATORY PUSH

More so than private enterprises like Amazon, state regulators around the world are increasingly focused on platform accountability, algorithmic transparency and systemic risk.

The European Union's Digital Services Act (DSA), which came into force for major platforms in recent years, places greater responsibility on companies to assess and mitigate systemic risks, including illegal products and deceptive activity. India's regulatory approach remains different, but discussions around platform accountability, intermediary responsibility, and consumer protection increasingly overlap with global debates.

Increasingly, regulators are also examining whether consumers can trust the information and pricing practices displayed by platforms themselves.

In India, evolving e-commerce regulations have focused on issues such as misleading discounts, sponsored listings, and search-result manipulation. New rules—as part of the amended the Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules 2020—that will come into force in 2027, will require platforms to clearly distinguish paid listings from

organic results, disclose a product's "prior price" when advertising discounts, and prevent practices that could mislead consumers about rankings or savings.

Indian regulators have also sought stronger compliance around so-called dark patterns, from drip pricing to interface designs, that nudge users into decisions they may not otherwise make.

That also raises the question of accountability—how much responsibility should be borne by digital marketplace platforms like Amazon?

Pahwa argues that platforms are ideally responsible for trust and accountability, but there must remain a distinction between responsibility and liability. Platforms cannot realistically guarantee perfect outcomes, particularly in a market as large and complex as India.

THE FUTURE OF TRUST

The internet's next trust challenge may not be counterfeit goods or fake reviews alone. It may be a world where synthetic identities, AI-generated content, and automated fraud networks become commonplace.

The industry's response is likely to involve more verification, more auditing, and more automation. But technology will form just one part of the answer, as trust will be shaped by governance, enforcement, and accountability systems as much as machine learning models.

For India, the stakes are particularly high. The country's digital economy continues to grow rapidly, even as online fraud becomes more sophisticated.

Consumers may never see the systems working behind the scenes. They may never know how many counterfeit listings were removed, how many fraudulent accounts were blocked, or how many AI-driven checks occurred before a purchase was completed. And that's job well done. In an age where deception is becoming easier to manufacture, trust may become the internet's most valuable product.

Abhishek Baxi is a New Delhi-based tech writer.



REVIEW | GOOGLE PIXEL 11 PRO FOLD

Is holding steady enough, or can Google do more?

The Pixel 11 Pro Fold is a solid foldable, but is it lagging behind its peers?

Sahil Bhalla
feedback@livemint.com

This year is shaping up to be one of the most consequential for foldable smartphones. There's the new tri-fold Huawei Mate XT2 (with a built-in privacy display), or wide folding smartphones like the Galaxy Z Fold8 and the iPhone Duo. Google, on the other hand, has leaned on software and a clean Android experience for the Pixel 11 Pro Fold (₹1,86,999).

WHAT'S IN THE EXPERIENCE?

The Tensor G6 chip with 16GB of RAM and up to 1TB of storage works like a charm. Unless you try to play high-end games or take a thousand photos in an hour, this foldable will never feel slow or sluggish. Then there's the durability. The Pixel 11 Pro Fold gives users full peace of mind with its IP68 rating, and Google does so while making the foldable lighter and thinner. Furthermore, Google added a back glass that's "nearly impossible to crack", according to the company. It also adds Qi2.2/MagSafe compatibility.

With the Pixel 11 Pro Fold, Google finally gives users a 6.5-inch glass-ceramic cover screen by thinning the bezels, and this is a

The phone's camera and performance don't get a bump from last year's model

game-changer. If you've never used a foldable before, with this phone you'll feel right at home, as texting, scrolling, and browsing feel natural and recognisable. The Pixel 11 Pro Fold's two main drawbacks are that its cameras and raw performance don't get a bump from the previous generation. The foldable has a 48MP main sensor, a 10.5MP ultrawide, and a 10.8 (5x optical zoom) telephoto camera. The two selfie cameras are 10MP shooters.

CAMERAS AND PERFORMANCE

For the most part, the Pixel 11 Pro Fold cameras perform well. The 30x Super Zoom shots come with decent detail and sharpness, while the new Camera Looks feature lets you choose from a range of photography styles. There's also Google's Magic Capture where the user can let AI record the best moments instead of having to hit the shutter button every time. The ultra-wide is the weak spot, and the front cameras are just about passable for self-

ies. Google's Tensor chips have long been criticised for underperforming, overheating, and other issues. The Pixel 11 Pro Fold won't beat other foldables in raw performance: There are no generational leaps here, but steady improvements.

Can the Pixel 11 Pro Fold last an entire day on a single charge? That's (mostly) a yes. The 4,806mAh battery is a downgrade from the previous year's Fold and while Google suggests over 24 hours of battery life for the Pixel 11 Pro Fold, but in my testing, it hasn't come anywhere near that. On average, I've been getting 5-6 hours of screen-on time (SoT). It's learned my usage habits and improved over time, but it still lags behind its rivals. On the bright side, wireless charging speeds have improved. Qi2 wireless charging is a boon and super convenient.

Sahil Bhalla is a Delhi-based writer. He posts @IMSAhilBhalla.

The serene joys of getting lost in translation in Japan

Holidays are planned mostly online these days. But what if you try to enjoy a vacation the old-fashioned, offline way?

Pooja Singh
pooja.s@livemint.com

I am not a to-do-list kind of worker; procrastination is often what drives my work. But when it comes to travel, I am the "planner" type: monuments to see, restaurants to eat at, Instagram-famous stores to shop at.

All of this went out of the window in August, when my brother and I travelled to Japan with one rule: we would not let Google or social media dictate where we ate, shopped or went. Google Maps would be used only to get to and from the airport. We picked our hotels and other destinations from a printed city map.

Instead of chasing everything that is documented, reviewed and recommended, we would let curiosity guide us—like meandering into a street simply because it looked interesting.

On our first morning in Tokyo, after depositing our luggage in the hotel, we headed out for breakfast. After 40 minutes of walking through the lanes of Taito City, known for its old-world charm, we ended up at a hole-in-the-wall café serving English-American breakfast. We were too hungry to complain that it wasn't Japanese. Between the two of us, we polished off an avocado toast, croque monsieur, crème brûlée, pineapple pop soda and what I can only describe as the best tiramisu I have had so far.

After buying our Metro cards and picking up a Metro map from the train station, we spent our first day strolling around in the neighbourhood we were staying in. We met a 90-year-old artist who had a small roadside shop selling antiques, old prints and her own artwork. She didn't speak English, and we know no Japanese. But hand gestures were enough to understand each other. We bought two of her paintings depicting everyday life in Tokyo.

For dinner, the hotel receptionist gave us directions to a 50-year-old ramen place, which we never found. We ended up, instead, at the Sensō-ji shrine, one of the oldest Buddhist temples in Tokyo. Eventually, we ended up at a ramen place



Is there a richness to travelling offline?

ISTOCKPHOTO

we had visited last year. It has no signboard, just a white wall and a machine where you place your order.

The restaurant can seat no more than ten. Last year, I had requested the owner's daughter, who was also serving, to leave the meat out of my bowl. "No pork?" she smiled as soon as she saw me this time, making an 'X' with her hands.

The taste was just as I remembered—the umami intact.

The next day we went to the Tokyo Metropolitan Art Museum, which was celebrating its 100th anniversary—something we discovered only after arriving, an hour before closing. We made a quick round of the Edo in Focus exhibition, which featured paintings on folding

screens (*byōbu*), hanging scrolls (*kakejiku*) and handscrolls (*emaki*), along with prints by eight renowned Japanese artists, including Utamaro, Sharaku, Hokusai and Hiroshige.

Outside, we stumbled upon a food festival celebrating Pakistani culture in front of the National Museum. We had biryani with cans of Suntory, before moving on to the panic part of the day: we hadn't booked our train tickets to Fuji for the next morning. When we finally reached the station to buy them, the seats were sold out and our only option was to stand for 3 hours.

So that's what we did. Just before arriving at our destination, when I checked our hotel booking for the exact address, I realised that I had bought tickets to the wrong destination. We were now four hours away from where we were supposed to be, the conductor confirmed. We had landed in Kawaguchiko, a little resort town at the base of Mt Fuji.

While regretting our resolve not to rely on technology, we headed to the tourist information centre. It was the weekend, most hotels were full, barring one that had a single room available. The silver lining? It was a ryokan, a traditional Japanese inn with tatami-mat floors, sliding paper

doors and an *onsen*, or hot spring bath. Best of all, the room came with a view of Mt Fuji.

The next three days were filled with even more happenstance. Back in Tokyo, instead of landing at a Michelin-starred restaurant recommended by a fellow tourist, we walked into a ramen place, which had an Indian chef. The food wasn't particularly memorable, but the chef, Rakesh, told us stories of how he arrived in Japan 15 years ago and about the small community of Indian chefs in the city he now calls home. The Michelin-starred restaurant was in the building opposite this ramen shop.

Similarly, a Guinness beer sign took us to a basement pub in Shibuya, where the bartender-cum-cook-cum-server told us stories of his childhood in Osaka and his plans to visit China and India. We parted with a promise to meet again on our next trip.

Perhaps that's the real beauty of travel, and one that is slowly fading with our increasing reliance on the internet. Taking a wrong turn, following a random sign, talking to a stranger who becomes part of your story—sometimes, the most memorable experiences happen when you don't know exactly where you're going.